

*'...Tales high and prophetic; tales low and uncouth
 Tales written in prose and in verses
 Tales written for pleasure, tales written for truth
 Tales written of blessings and curses
 Tales of wizards and warriors and nobles and priests
 Shining allies, and terrible foes...'*

INTRODUCTION

This is a collection, by no means comprehensive, of Scott Alexander's shorter fiction and poetry (epic and otherwise) that is NOT found on his blog, Slate Star Codex. Scott's existing corpus of work is extensive, spanning many years of blogging, and there are many of his literary gems scattered all over cyberspace. These works have been collected from a variety of platforms, including his Tumblr, Livejournal, and a couple other sites.

In June, Scott (to be fair, for very good reasons) put his blog on hiatus and laid low rather than be featured in the New York Times. It came as quite a disappointment to me; there was a (slate) star-shaped hole that needed filling.

With no blog to read, I started browsing Scott's other feeds, and found some archives of his past work. Somewhere along the way, probably when I was reading a condensation of Shakespeare's Sonnet 18 into iambic monometer, I thought: *'there should be a place where everyone can read this'*.

I couldn't find any updated collections of his work, and none contained anything from Twitter or Tumblr, so I took a stab at it myself, trawling through years of posts for poetry and fiction, which took me longer than I expected. (Scott once said, on *Hamilton*, that he didn't understand why writing fifty-one essays in six months was supposed to be impressive)

It should be said that this is an unauthorized collection. Out of respect for Scott's privacy, I have removed any identifying information from these works and will not be linking to the originals. For posterity's sake, the text is presented here, with only minor editing and style changes, for all to see. Perhaps Scott would prefer not to have these works publicized, or perhaps he is flattered that someone has trawled through the web for his throwaway lines, or, most likely, he has forgotten completely about them; I do not know. What I do know is that I enjoyed reading these very much, and hopefully, so will you.

Slate Star Codex is one of my favorite places on the Web. The Internet is strewn with forums and communities full of vitriol and toxicity, but Scott's is kind, is clever and chock-full of puns, and most importantly, is charitable to others. (I'm sure he's heard this before, but I just had to say it)

Sun bless and Earth keep,
 An anonymous fan
 Dec 2020

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SHORT STORIES

SOUL CANCER

Mr. Murphy sat on his chair and fidgeted nervously. I sat on mine, hidden in the back corner, doing the same.

I was on rotation with Dr. Tophet, who strenuously objected to having a student. The matter had gone back and forth, with the doctor telling administration that he was a very busy man, and administration telling the doctor that everyone was busy, and that this was a teaching hospital, and that it would take at least fifteen minutes' work for them to find anyone else. For a few days it had seemed like an irresistible force encountering an immovable object. But as always, the reluctance of the administration to do work won out, and Dr. Tophet agreed I could shadow him as long as I promised to sit in a corner and say nothing. So there I sat, quiet and fidgeting.

Mr. Murphy was even less at ease. He had come in last Monday with a history of worsening episodes of depression, rage, and confusion. They'd taken some blood and offered to call him in a few days when the test results were in. Instead, he was told to come to Dr. Tophet's office. That could only mean one thing. Good test results were delivered by phone; bad test results were delivered in person, everyone knew that. Things were not looking good for Mr. Murphy.

"Mr. Murphy," said Dr. Tophet, walking into the room. He shook the man's hand. Dr. Tophet was tall, dark, and vaguely foreign-looking, although I didn't know exactly where he was from. He spoke rarely, and with a slight accent. He did not so much as give me a glance before sitting down and taking out the patient's chart.

"Mr. Murphy, have you ever heard of pneumatoma?"

Mr. Murphy shook his head. The diseases with Greek names, the ones you'd never heard of, they were always the worst.

"In layman's terms, Mr. Murphy, you have soul cancer."

The patient blinked. Opened his mouth a little. Closed it. "Soul cancer? What?"

"Stage two pneumatoma," said Dr. Tophet. "A highly advanced, malignant form of soul cancer."

"What? That's crazy!"

"I'm sorry, but the blood tests confirm it. There's no room for doubt. It's pneumatoma."

"You're making that up."

"It's natural to be angry or in denial when you hear difficult news. If you would prefer to have a few days to reflect before we talk further, I can give you another appointment on Tuesday."

"No," said Mr. Murphy. "I'm not saying I don't believe I have numo...numa...soul cancer. I just never heard of such a thing. How can a soul get cancer?"

"Almost any part of the body or spirit can develop cancer, Mr. Murphy. You've probably heard of breast cancer, prostate cancer, and lung cancer, but there are hundreds of types only the specialists know about. Angiosarcoma - blood vessel cancer. Osteosarcoma - cancer of bone. Medullablastoma - cancer of embryonic brain remnants. And pneumatoma - cancer of the soul. All very rare. I'm sorry you have to be the one to get it, Mr. Murphy."

"So doctors know about the soul?"

"We would hardly be doing our job if we missed an entire organ. Pneumatology is decades old and on sound scientific footing."

"Soul cancer," he said, testing out the words. "Soul cancer. Bloody hell. Is it dangerous?"

"Very," said Dr. Tophet. "After it reaches a certain size, it will metastasize to other organs and eventually kill you. But don't worry. This is one of the top hospitals for treating soul cancer in the country, and I promise you we won't let you go without a fight."

Mr. Murphy looked utterly miserable.

"What's the treatment?"

"For stage two, I'm afraid I have to recommend a radical pneumatonectomy."

"Radical...pneumatotomy?"

"We take out your soul through your nose."

Mr. Murphy literally jumped out of his chair.

"You can...remove the soul...through the nose?"

"It's not so surprising," said Dr. Tophet. "Do you say 'God bless you!' when someone sneezes? It comes from the old belief that a sufficiently powerful sneeze might blow the soul out through the nose, and that a prayer was necessary to make sure God helped it back into its rightful place. Of

course, the custom itself is only superstition: a normal sneeze is hundreds of times too weak to actually dispel the soul. But the principle behind it is sound, and with modern surgical technique there should be minimal trauma and no pain."

"But...what happens to me...without my soul?"

Dr. Tophet stood up and went to his bookshelf. He passed by books with titles like *Encyclopedia of Parapsychiatry* and *British Journal of Radiation Ontology* until he came to one entitled *Pneumatotomy - History and Practice*. which he took down, opened to a bookmarked page, and handed to his patient. I couldn't see any of the text, just Mr. Murphy's head, occasionally nodding.

"The soul," declared Dr. Tophet, "is what we call a vestigial organ. It's like the appendix. In the past, it was important for appreciating beautiful music and poetry, communing with the grandeur of nature, experiencing true love, and guiding our moral decisions. But in these days of rap music, nature replaced by endless suburbs, and no-fault divorce? And how many people nowadays do you see reading poetry? Most of my patients get through their pneumatotomy without even noticing the difference. I have one patient who's three years post pneumatotomy and is now head of a major bank."

"What about my morals? Will I become a, you know, a psychopath?"

"Oh no. Most of what you call 'morality' is just following convention, avoiding punishment, worrying what the neighbors will think. The contribution of your actual soul is so minor as to be unnoticeable. You'll be fine."

"And..." Mr. Murphy looked a bit bewildered, a bit out of his depth. A deer in the headlights sort of expression. "And what about, you know, after I die. If I don't have a soul, do I still go to, you know, the afterlife?"

The doctor narrowed his eyes. "Mr. Murphy, I am a busy man. I don't know if you realize the gravity of your condition, but please, try to stay serious."

With a pleading but-what-did-i-do-wrong look in his eyes, Mr. Murphy went silent, totally defeated.

"Tell you what, Mr. Murphy. I'm going to give you the consent form for the operation. You can look it over at your leisure in the waiting room. My medical student will help you out if there is anything you don't understand. When you've finished, you can sign the form and give it to my secretary. Here's a pen, you can return that to my secretary too. Once you've signed the form, we can schedule a date for your operation. "

Mr. Murphy nodded.

"Uh, sorry," I said. "I really don't know anything about soul cancer. Maybe you should..."

"Then this would be a good time to learn," said Dr. Tophet. "I am going to work on charts for the rest of the day. I'll see you tomorrow morning. Mr. Murphy, thank you for your time."

His tone of voice did not invite question or comment, and without even rising to shake hands he took the book from Mr. Murphy, replacing it on his shelf between *The History and Metaphysical Exam* and an old, decaying book whose title had faded but which was authored by a "Dr. Alhazred". Then he took a chart from the pile beside his desk and started scrutinizing it.

"Uh, come with me," I told Mr. Murphy. "I'll show you to the waiting room."

Actually, I wasn't sure where the waiting room was. I'd never been in this wing of the hospital before. I assumed I could find it, though, an assumption that was immediately proved embarrassingly wrong. I caught sight of a row of signs with relief. One pointed to the waiting room, another to a cafeteria, and another to...

"It says the office of the hospital chaplain is that direction," said Mr. Murphy. "Do you know him?"

"Never met him," I say.

"If you don't mind...do you think Dr. Tophet would mind if I had a talk with him? Because of souls and all?"

"I'm sure he wouldn't," I said, though in fact I very much doubted my ability to predict the doctor's actions and he seemed like the easily offended sort. Still, Mr. Murphy seemed pretty upset, and to be honest I was upset as well. I'd never heard of soul cancer, I was pretty sure there was no such thing, and I wanted some answers. And if there was one profession adept at giving answers, with certainty, about entities that didn't exist, it was the clergy.

"Please, sit down," said Father Mahony, after Mr. Murphy had told his story. "Can I see the form? The consent form? Thank you." He accepted the several pages of stapled documents, along with Dr. Tophet's rather fancy-looking pen, and scrutinized them carefully. He started underlining and making notes on key phrases on the consent form.

"Uh," I said. "Better not do that. Dr. Tophet tends to be kind of a stickler."

"I see," said Father Mahony. "I am sorry." He looked with dismay at the document, which now had several red lines under certain words. Then he looked up.

"Gentlemen," he said. "I have been through many years of seminary. I have been several times to the Vatican. I have spent thirty years ministering to the souls of people in and around this hospital. And

never, in all my life, have I heard of such a thing as soul cancer. I do not believe that the same God who endowed us with an immortal soul, would see fit to make that soul corruptible, and capable of turning against itself."

"Well," I said, "He did it with bodies."

"I would like to speak to this Dr. Tophet," said the priest, as he finished his scan of the consent forms. "I would prefer that you not sign anything until I did so."

"Uh," I said "He's really busy."

"And so am I," said Father Mahony, "but I am sure no doctor, no matter how busy, would begrudge a few minutes to talk about the health of a patient in need."

"Uh," I said "You haven't talked to a lot of doctors, have you?"

"This is important," said the priest, as he grabbed something from his desk. "Please take me to Dr. Tophet."

And so back we wandered through the corridors. Knock. Knock.

"Office hours are over, please talk to my secretary," came the voice of Dr. Tophet from within his office.

"This is Father Mahony, the hospital chaplain. I'm afraid it's a matter of some urgency. May I come in?"

And without awaiting an answer, Father Mahony opened the door and stepped inside. Dr. Tophet looked up from his charts, clearly annoyed. He gazed impassively at Mr. Murphy. At me, he shot the Stare of Death. This was going to be a very long rotation.

"Let's not mince words," said Father Mahony. "I just have one question for you, and then I'll let you be."

"Yes?" asked the doctor.

"Doctor Tophet, are you the Devil?"

The doctor blinked.

"No," he finally answered. "No, I am not."

"Good," said Father Mahony. "Then nothing at all of interest should happen when I do THIS!"

And he took the vial of holy water, opened the stopper, and flung it at Dr. Tophet.

Dr. Tophet caught fire.

The doctor flailed around for a few seconds, dropped to the ground, and rolled. A second later, the flames went out.

He stood up. He was now, very clearly, both more and less than human. His eyes were orange. His hands ended in black claws, his teeth in fangs. His skin glowed with an obvious red lustre. He spoke slowly and with painful clarity, as if the words had formed in far off voids of space and only arrived at his mouth after an epic journey.

"Before, when I said I was not the Devil, I might not have been entirely telling the truth."

Mr. Murphy and I grabbed each other and I think we both shrieked. Father Mahony only nodded.

"If I may ask, what gave it away?"

"The consent form says you retain all rights to tissue removed in the operation. In other words, it said you get to keep his soul. And the pen was blood. I was suspicious when I saw the red ink, and then I smelled it to make sure. If I had to guess, I'd say it was Mr. Murphy's blood, from the samples you took for the blood tests. When I thought to myself - who asks someone to sign a contract in their own blood, giving up their soul - well, it wasn't too hard."

"I see," said the Devil. "And tell me, did Mr. Murphy sign the form?"

"No,"

"Too bad. Then I will be going, now."

"No," said the priest, brandishing the crucifix on his necklace. "I will not permit you to leave until you release the souls of everyone who you previously gave this operation, and until you promise never to set foot within University Hospital again!"

"I'll release the souls," said the Devil. "As for never setting foot here again...Father, a dozen people die in this hospital every day. Surely even you must understand that not all of them can be headed for Heaven."

Father Mahony turned just a little pale. "Very we-" he said, but before he could even complete the sentence, there was a clap of thunder, a cloud of acrid smoke, and the Devil was gone. Mr. Murphy

just fainted then, and Father Mahony and I had to carry him to the A&E a few doors down, where they said he would eventually be all right.

As for me, without a supervisor, and with the administration unwilling to do the paperwork it would take to get a new one, I had the rest of the week off.

As for the souls, I don't know if it's connected, but the newspaper the next day mentioned that the head of a major bank, an extremely important public figure, had suddenly and inexplicably resigned, donated all of his money to the needy, and joined a monastery.

And as for Father Mahony, well, last I saw him he was taking a trolley into Dr. Tophet's office to carry off his collection of *extremely interesting* books.

MAHAKSURYANA

The man bumped into me, knocked the wind out of me, and then apologized a second later.

"Sorry!" he said. Then he stopped, thought a second. "By the way, you don't know where I could find a decent Indian restaurant around here, do you?"

"Actually, there's one just a few minutes that way," I told him. "I'm heading that direction myself. You can follow me if you want, I'll point it out to you."

"Oh, thanks." He held out one of his six blue hands, which I reluctantly shook. "I'm Mahaksuryana. Pleased to make your acquaintance."

"This is kind of going to be a weird question," I said, "but are you a Buddhist god?"

"Hindu, actually," said Mahaksuryana, "but I'm not offended. I like the Buddhists. They're pretty chill."

"I'm...not sure they'd let you into a restaurant, looking like that," I said. "Or, well, they might, but you'd pick up a lot of unwanted attention."

He closed his eyes for a second, and clasped his hands in a posture of infinite inner peace. His blue skin changed to a dusky brown, and four of his six arms vanished. I began walking, and he followed.

"Sorry," he said. "It's been a long time since I've been down here. You've kind of screwed the place up, no offense."

"None taken," I said. "We humans haven't always been perfect stewards of our planet, but I do think that -"

"I mean," continued Mahaksuryana, "we *told* you lot not to eat cows. But would you listen?"

"What? What does eating cows have to do with all of this?"

The Hindu god sighed. "Think about it. The number of living humans increases every generation. A hundred fifty years ago there were only a billion humans. Now there are seven billion.

"We're supposed to reincarnate the souls of the dead into new bodies, but there just aren't enough souls to deal with the population explosion. That's not even counting the virtuous who achieve enlightenment and break the cycle of reincarnation, or the wicked who have to be reincarnated as cockroaches for an aeon as just desert for their sins.

"We used to have procedures for something like this. The most virtuous animals would be reincarnated as human. Usually it would be some courageous tiger or some especially clever monkey or something, or a war elephant who served his master well.

"But now you've cut down the jungles and drained the swamps and there just aren't a whole lot of monkeys and tigers running around. In fact, the only large animals with complex nervous systems that continue to exist in numbers even remotely similar to those of humans are your farm animals. Not to mention they're conveniently located in large human habitations. If we need a soul in central Iowa, stat, no way we're going to go looking for the last remaining population of wild tigers in Bangladesh.

"So the overwhelming majority of your people were farm animals in their past lives.

"But think about how you treat your farm animals. Factory farming. Force fed through tubes so their diet can be precisely controlled. Locked in cages exactly the size of their bodies to prevent them from using their muscles lest the meat become less tender. Separated at birth from their families. Never seeing the sun or the green grass. Pumped full of drugs so they can be packed side-to-side in vast warehouses without infection.

"And then your children are born, and almost from birth they start to go wrong. Stuffing themselves full of food and avoiding exercise. Isolated from their families and each other. Retreating from nature and the open spaces to watch television in dark rooms. Stuffing themselves full of drugs, from alcohol to cocaine, in an attempt to make themselves feel better.

"And your psychiatrists write in their journals about how rates of depression, autism, and attention deficit disorder are increasing by orders of magnitude each generation, and they don't know why.

"Honestly, sometimes I can't blame Kali for just wanting to destroy the whole thing and start over. I guess she'll get her way soon eno -

- oh, look, there's the Indian restaurant! And it looks delicious!"

And with divine precision the Hindu god Mahaksuryana bowed, did a perfect quarter turn, and stepped through the door. I would have followed, but I was in a hurry, and something warned me to stay away.

I never saw Mahaksuryana again, and honestly that's just fine by me.

THE STORY OF EMILY AND CONTROL

There's an old joke about a statistician who had twins. She baptized one, and kept the other as a control. Laugh all you like. It'll never be funny to me. I know the true story.

Yes, that's right. It's a degenerate form of a true story. One that isn't funny at all. One that directly caused both of the worst experiences of my life. Yes, I knew them. So here's their story. Don't you dare laugh.

I first met Emily and Control in college. I was TAing a philosophy course; Control was one of my students. I noticed the name, of course, but this was California and I'd heard weirder; in any case it wasn't polite to mention such things. She proved a model student: bright, diligent, enthusiastic. Was I in love with her even then? Maybe.

The next semester I found myself living in a new building, and when I went to meet the neighbors I spotted Control two doors down from me. I went over to say hello; she didn't recognize me and after a brief confusion admitted she was not Control, but her sister Emily. The two were clearly identical twins - the same meticulously styled long straw-blond hair, the same beautiful smile - even their styles of clothing were alike.

She invited me to come in and talk, and discussion naturally turned to her sister. Emily told me of her mother, a statistician, and how she had been so delighted with identical twins that she had named one Control, supposedly an obscure Eastern European name but in fact an homage to the identical twins and their role in controlled trials. At the time, I found this anecdote quite amusing. I was a bit into statistics myself, and between discussions of her twin sister and of mathematics I left an hour later feeling like I had made a new friend.

Our social circles intersected more and more over the next few months, and I found myself coming to admire the twins more and more. They were still only freshmen, but through social graces and strong personalities they managed to climb the social ladder with deceptive ease. It wasn't just socially, either; Control had passed my philosophy course with the highest GPA in the class, and by all accounts her sister was an equally strong student, as impressive at the humanities as the hard sciences. And call me shallow, but it did not escape my attention that they were two of the most attractive young women I'd ever met. They weren't conventionally attractive, exactly, but there was something about their mannerisms and their style that made them stand out.

One day I let my interest get the better of me. I had a chance meeting with Emily at a cafe, and we were chatting about all the usual random topics, and she said something about some clever interpretation of Aristotle that even I hadn't thought of, and I just said, outright "I don't get it. Some people are pretty, some people are smart, some people are likable. But you and your sister are always the best at everything. It's not even fair. What's your secret? Black magic?"

To my surprise, Emily didn't laugh. She actually looked quite serious. "Well, we don't talk about it much," she said. "But since you asked - we just try lots of different things and do what works."

And she proceeded to tell me how from childhood, she and her sister had taken their heritage seriously and started performing randomized controlled trials on themselves. Evidence-based everything. It began when Emily made flashcards to study from and Control thought it was a waste of time. They made a bet: if Emily could get a better score on three consecutive tests, Control would start using flashcards. Three tests later, the evidence was in: Emily did on average four points better. Control started studying off of flashcards. From then on, whenever they had a difficult choice, Emily would try one path, Control would try the other, and after a few months they would compare results.

When they grew older and started getting an interest in boys, they dealt with it the only way they knew how. Emily and Control would go to the same club with different hairstyles, or different fashions, or entirely different acted personalities, and whoever got more invitations to dance would win for the night. Emily cut her hair, Control kept hers long; when Control consistently attracted more interest, Emily grew hers back. And so they conducted experiment after experiment, at school and at clubs and with their friends, growing stronger with each bit of knowledge gained.

It was the best thing I'd ever heard, and I told Emily so. She just laughed and brushed back her hair in a way that had no doubt been perfected over dozens of unwitting test subjects. I had never wanted an identical twin more than I did in that moment.

I won't bore you with the next year, but by the time my senior year came around, my fondest wish had come true: I asked Control out, and she agreed. We dated with varying levels of seriousness all through the beginning of the year. Emily, for her part, had broken character and was seeing a stereotypical biker from the city: oiled hair, black leather jacket, the whole works. Control and I found this hilarious. We mocked him mercilessly, never where Emily could hear, of course, and compared their tempestuous on-again off-again relationship to the more pleasant and stable thing we had going. We were both so happy that it was totally obvious it couldn't last.

I don't really know why our relationship started to deteriorate, except maybe the same reasons almost everyone's relationships eventually deteriorate. It was college. Maybe we weren't ready yet. But there were more and more fights, and they lasted longer and longer, and eventually after twenty minutes of yelling over the phone I shouted something like "Well, if you dislike me that much, maybe you should have gotten yourself a greasy bad boy biker like your sister!". And then I hung up.

And then I realized, with a sort of oh-my-god-it-was-obvious-all-along insight, that of COURSE she had considered that option. But it wasn't her way just to go for it willy-nilly. Emily and Control had sat down, decided they needed boyfriends, discussed a mutual interest in sketchy leather-jacket wearing motorcyclist types, and then Emily had gone off and found one. And Control, as usual, had sought out a standard for comparison. Someone totally inoffensive and neutral. Me.

I called her up, my hands shaking. "Hello?" she said. I got to the point. "Am I the placebo boyfriend?" I asked her. She hesitated. Right away that told me all that I needed to know.

"So that's all I am to you?" I snarled. "A placebo? A control group for your real boyfriend? Well, experiment is over now. And very successful, by the sound of it. You can't help but do better than the control." I slammed down the phone.

And an hour later, I was treated to a long and desperate-sounding email from Control. The gist of it was that yes, she had been using me, but I had it all wrong. The experiment had gone the opposite way. Emily hated her boyfriend; she was sticking with him only out of a sense that it would be bad experimental practice to end the study prematurely. She and I had had our quarrels, but overall it had been a good time, and she was going to recommend Emily get a boyfriend just like me. She said all the right things, but by that point I had hardened my heart. I deleted the email and resolved to avoid the sisters from then on.

It proved easier than I thought. Emily and Control, who had once moved through college society with masterful ease, were nowhere to be seen.

I learned why one evening after talking to a mutual friend. Emily had tried to break up with her boyfriend. He hadn't taken it very well. He'd beaten her up, then assaulted her. The hospital said her physical wounds were mostly superficial, but the trauma was harder to heal. I started to hear rumors that she was skipping classes - unthinkable just a few months earlier. Then other rumors, that she'd turned to alcohol. I didn't believe them. She'd been too perfect.

But I ran into her one night at the cafe where we used to hang out. As soon as I saw her, I knew the rumors were true. She looked awful. "Hey," she told me. She didn't sound too good either.

"Control says she's sorry," Emily told me, nursing a beer. "She really did like you."

"I guess I believe that, now," I said. "But what's done is done. You know, I really respected that science thing of yours. Best idea I ever heard. Seriously. But you can't do that kind of thing when there are people on the other side who'll get hurt. It's, you know, unethical."

Emily glared. "You think I didn't get hurt myself?" she asked. "But finding someone to settle down with is the most important thing you can do. And you want me to take it on anecdotal evidence? I thought Brad would be good for me. I proved the hypothesis wrong. And it's damned good I did, or else Control might have hooked up with someone like him too, and things would've been worse. Really, the whole thing's your fault." She spat. "If you hadn't had your little anti-science tantrum, you and Control would still be together, I'd be looking for someone nice like you, and none of this would've happened."

"Emily," I started. I wanted to be mad, but right now I was too worried. "You can still find someone. I know what Brad did to you hurt you bad, but you don't need to do this whole downward spiral thing. Seriously, put away the beer, clean yourself up, and I'll introduce you to some of my friends. You can even make an experiment out of it, if it'll make you happy."

"It's not about what makes me happy," said Emily, "it's about the truth. As for whether I should put away the beer, that remains to be seen." She finished her can. "See you around."

A few weeks later, I saw her again. Control was drinking with her. I hoped it was just a lapse of standards on her part. The alternative - that Control had deliberately stayed sober while Emily drank, that they had compared results, and that Emily had convinced her sister that alcoholism was the way to go - was really too horrible to contemplate.

Although considering what was to come, the phrase "too horrible to contemplate" really shouldn't be used so lightly.

It was a few days before graduation. I hadn't seen either of the twins in a couple of months. I vaguely felt like I should search them out and say some sort of goodbye before I left the university forever, but things kept getting in the way, and I didn't bother. It was the professor I'd been TAing for who first told me the news.

"You know Emily?" he asked. "The twin sister of that lovely girl Control I had a few years ago? Don't tell anyone yet, but the faculty just got an email about her. Apparently she killed herself. Overdosed on some pills, don't know how she got them. Very sad. And everyone said she was such a nice girl, too."

I was shocked. I really didn't know what to say. I knew that between her experience with Brad and the alcohol that she'd been in a bad way lately, but I never could have imagined it would come to this. The funeral was the day before graduation. I was there. Control was there too. I don't think we spoke two words to each other. I was in shock. She was obviously in shock. We listened to the pastor go through his empty ritual - ashes to ashes, dust to dust - and then I returned to school for a decidedly joyless graduation. Control was a year behind me; thank goodness she didn't have to endure those two ceremonies juxtaposed in quite that way.

After that I left town pretty quickly. I had a job offer a few hundred miles away, so I took that and soon my memories of college were far behind me. I emailed Control once or twice, expressing my condolences, saying how sorry I was that things didn't work out between us, telling her I was sure she would bounce back. She responded with equal platitudes: she appreciated my concern, she was trying her best. After a little while, even the meaningless formalities of email were abandoned, and we lost touch completely.

It was six months after graduation. I'd heard about a better job offer back in the old college town, so I'd driven down for the weekend to interview. It had gone well, I was fully expecting a call saying I'd

got the job, and I stopped off in the old cafe I'd spent so many hours in to get myself some ice cream in celebration.

There at a table in the far corner was Control, intensely focused on something. I went closer; I saw the object of her interest. She was hunched over a Ouija board. She looked up. "Oh!" she said, with a look of surprise. "I didn't know you'd..."

My blood turned to ice.

It was the simplest possible plan. I should have guessed it months before. For "who would bear the whips and scorns of time, but for the dread of something after death?" And so the experimental and control groups had been randomly assigned, and one of them had entered the great beyond, and the other had stayed in this world of suffering, and God help them they were going to compare results.

So of course I fled as fast as my legs could carry me, and of course I never returned, not even to hear if I'd got the job. And of course I deleted Control's number from my phone, blocked her email account, blocked her on Messenger, unfriended her on Facebook, cut off all contact with everyone I knew in college where there was even the remotest chance they knew her. Because that was one experimental result I never wanted to hear.

What if the next morning, I had found Control dead? Then I would know with all the certainty of science that it was better to die than to live; that life was empirically and incontrovertibly pointless, that those who passed away were the lucky ones compared to us condemned to remain on Earth.

And if I saw her the next morning, bright and lively as ever? Oh God, how much worse that would be! It would mean scientific proof that no matter how wearisome and unpleasant life becomes, what awaited us beyond the grave was far, far worse. It would mean living in fear of an eternity whose content was unknown, but whose dreadfulness was incontrovertible. Let others say that "all knowledge is worth having"; I am far happier not knowing.

So if you ever meet a girl with straw-blond hair and a smile to die for, a bright enthusiastic girl with a penchant for statistics, and maybe you are attracted to her and maybe you aren't, but you think you would like to get to know her better; well, before you ask her name, think for a moment about whether you want to burden of knowledge that will go with it. And if she smiles at you and says her name is Control, and that it's a funny story, then you are lost, and all I ask is that you never tell me how she's doing.

INTERVIEW WITH THE FROST GIANT

So describe for us what it's like to be a frost giant.

See, I think that's totally the wrong way to look at it. It's as if all of my experience is determined by this one unitary fact of being a frost giant, so that I can just take something from my life and say "Yeah, that's what frost giants are". Being a frost giant is a lot like being anything else. So I guess part of being a frost giant, part of what it's like to be a frost giant, is to know that other people are going to judge you just because you're a frost giant.

So you feel like you encounter a lot of discrimination?

Nothing too obvious. I mean, no one tries to beat me up or burn my house down. It's just the little things. Like people always assume that, just because I'm a frost giant, I must be part of the dread hell-legions of Niflheim. And I mean, yeah, sure, some frost giants are part of the dread hell-legions of Niflheim, but some white people are part of the dread hell-legions of Niflheim, and some black people, and some Mexican people. But if you saw a Mexican on the street, you wouldn't automatically assume he wanted to cover the world in an apocalypse of ice.

But you are a warrior in the dread hell-legions of Niflheim, aren't you?

Well, sure, I am. It's a decent job. And a lot of Jews are bankers, but that doesn't mean that you can assume every Jew you see is a banker and you'll never be wrong. There are frost giants in every occupation you can imagine. Teacher. Plumber. Manager. Nurse. Actor. Scientist.

Really?

Well, no, not nurse. Our icy touch is fatal to all but the mightiest of heroes. But the others? Sure. Tyler was a hedge fund manager.

Tyler?

My older brother. Does it surprise you that he's named Tyler, and not some more traditional name like Grimhavr or Skurjklas? My family has been in this country over a hundred years. We've assimilated along with everyone else. My grandfather on my mother's side is named Einvrehemir, but my mother is Susan, and my father is Paul.

What do you think are the biggest misconceptions about frost giants?

Well, most of the time when flesh midgets see us, they...

Sorry, flesh midgets?

Heh, my personal little joke. I mean, when you call us frost giants, it's like you're painting us as freaks, as if our only two interesting characteristics are being made of a different substance than you, and being of a different height than you. So when I call you flesh midgets, it's like - the boot is on the other foot, you know?

So do you consider the term 'frost giant' offensive?

Oh, no. I'm not one of those people. For a while, Tyler insisted on people saying 'ice-person of unusual stature', but that's such a mouthful. No, it might not be the best term, but it's the one people use. I just say 'flesh midget' to, like, raise awareness, make people think.

Anyway, I'm sorry. You were talking about the biggest misconceptions about frost giants.

Yeah. So most of the time when people see us, it's on a TV special about Ragnarok, or when we go door to door gathering toenails for the horrible corpse-boat Naglfar, or best case because one of us runs the local sno-cone stand. And so people only view us as apocalypse-bringers, or nail-boat-sailors, or sno-cone vendors, and not as fathers and mothers and co-workers and just normal people. Even in modern liberal society, when a TV show can have a black person or a Jewish person as a main character, the frost giant is pretty much always depicted as an axe-wielding servant of Niflheim trying to kill the Norse gods.

Well, black people and Jewish people still look more or less like everyone else. You're eighteen to twenty-five feet tall and made of solid ice.

As my mother used to say, it's not the size of the person that matters, it's the size of the heart.

Don't frost giants have ice instead of blood, and a shard of obsidian in their chest instead of a heart?

It's metaphorical. Heart is supposed to mean, like, your ability to care for other people.

And frost giants do care for other people. Tell us about some of the activism work that frost giants are involved in.

Oh, we're involved in pretty much every cause. Poverty, education, medical research, the environment, global warming...

Global warming?

I see where you're going with this. You want me to say that frost giants are disproportionately involved in the fight against global warming because we're made of ice, and so we have some sort of hokey "kinship" with the cold. Well, I hate to burst your bubble, but frost giants are involved in the

fight against global warming for the same reason as people of all races and nationalities: because we live in a fragile world which is worth protecting.

But you do melt at temperatures greater than 46 degrees Fahrenheit.

Yeah. That was what happened to Tyler.

I think we're almost out of time here. Any final words?

Please don't title this something like "Interview With The Frost Giant". Title it "Interview With A Father of Three", or "Interview With Tyler's Younger Brother", or "Interview With The Chief Warrior of the Third Dread Legion of Niflheim", or anything that shows that I'm an individual, and not just a representative of some generic Other.

Thank you.

You're welcome.

THE LAST TEMPTATION OF CHRIST

Jesus was led by the Spirit into the desert, where he was tempted by the Devil. After various lesser trials and temptations, the Devil led Jesus to the top of an exceedingly high mountain and showed him all the kingdoms of the world. And they stood there together, gazing upon the vista below.

"Behold," said Satan, mostly to break the awkward silence. "all the kingdoms of the world."

"They're very nice," said Jesus.

Satan's features - still faintly angelic - formed into a pout. "Really?" he asked. "Because I worked so hard corrupting them and turning them against one another, and..."

"No," said Jesus. "Not like that. I was just trying to be polite, really. They're teeming with sin and abomination."

Satan beamed. Some more awkward silence.

"So," said Jesus. "Is this the point at which you offer me lordship over all these kingdoms, if I only I bow down and worship you?"

"Nah," said Satan. "Like I said, they're kind of crappy. I'm here to tempt you, not insult you. I was planning something more interesting."

He waved his hand over the panorama, and it expanded in a hard-to-describe way. The three-dimensional view became four-dimensional; the vista became a manifold.

"Behold," said Satan again, "all the kingdoms of the world. Now and forever. Before you, the entire scope of history."

Jesus hesitated, not really sure what the polite response would be.

"You could at least smile!" said Satan. "Look! These people love you!"

Sure enough, it was true. Many of the kingdoms before them were Christian, building great cathedrals and writing beautiful works of theology in Jesus' name. Among the remainder, many were Muslim, revering him as one of the greatest of prophets.

"It's pretty encouraging," Jesus agreed. "So what's the catch?"

"Always the catch with you people," said Satan. "Well, if you insist. Take a look particularly at the psychiatric hospitals."

Jesus gazed through the manifold, where ten thousand psychiatric hospitals presented themselves simultaneously to his elevated senses.

"As you notice," said Satan, "your popularity has had some fascinating side effects. In particular, a pretty good proportion of psychotics, sometime in their illness, think that they're you. I don't think either of us wants to sit here counting them all, but could we agree on a hundred thousand as a conservative estimate?"

"A hundred thousand psychotics who believe themselves to be Jesus Christ, across the entire scope of world history," agreed Jesus. "Sounds reasonable."

"And it's a pretty strong delusion," the Devil went on. "They'd dismiss the contention that they're not you with barely a second thought. Whatever their reasoning processes are, they seem to be bent in on themselves somehow so that they always affirm the conclusion."

"It's very sad," Jesus said. "I hope my Father in Heaven will have mercy upon them."

"That's not what we're here to talk about," said the Devil. "What I'm really interested in is this - given a randomly chosen person who's absolutely certain he's Jesus, what's the probability that he is, in fact, Jesus?"

"Well," Jesus answered "There are a hundred thousand psychotics who believe themselves to be Jesus, and only one real Jesus. So by Bayes' Theorem, we calculate that believing one's self to be Jesus gives one only about a one in one hundred thousand chance that one is actually Jesus."

"Your reasoning is impeccable," said Satan. "So, what is the probability that you're actually Jesus?"

"What?" asked Jesus.

"You are an individual with a certain amount of evidence that you are Jesus. Specifically, you believe yourself to be him. You have various experiences which your reason tells you are consistent with being Jesus, like memories of your mother Mary and so on, but these seem like the sort of thing a damaged intellect could create to support a delusion. You previously determined that a randomly selected person with the belief that he is Jesus has a 1/100,000 chance of being Jesus and a 99,999/100,000 chance of being a psychotic. So, Mr. Person With The Belief That He Is Jesus, do you think those numbers apply to you?"

Jesus thought for a moment. "I'm not a psychotic," he said. "I think I would know if I were psychotic. I'd have all sorts of symptoms. Hallucinations. Confusion."

"You know what the number one hallucination reported by psychotic patients is?" Satan asked.

Jesus thought for a moment. "What?"

"The Devil," said the Devil.

"Oh, that's just unfair," Jesus told him.

"Usually they report he's trying to tempt them to do self-destructive things. You know, like jump off tall buildings. Remind me what we were doing earlier today?"

"You set that up to confuse me," said Jesus.

"And you mentioned confusion. Tell me, where are we right now?"

"An exceedingly high mountain," Jesus answered.

"Which one, exactly? Because the tallest mountain in Israel is a bit under four thousand feet. That's hardly see-all-the-kingdoms-of-the-world height. Are you even sure what country we're in right now? And, uh, last time I checked I'm almost certain the world was a sphere. So what particular mountain do you think we're on that allows us to see all the kingdoms of the world?"

"Uh, well, there are no kingdoms in the Western Hemisphere at this point in history..." suggested Jesus.

"Wrong!" said Satan. "Zapotecs and Mochica! You don't know where you are, you don't know how you got here, and you don't know how you're seeing what you're seeing."

"You took me here," Jesus countered. "I assume you used some sort of devil-magic or something. I didn't watch where we were going."

"Oh please," said Satan. "Outside View! In general, when someone says the only reason they don't know what country they're in is because the Devil is magically clouding their mind, does that make them more or less likely to be mentally ill?"

"Mrhghn," grumbled Jesus.

"So let's recap. You believe yourself to be Jesus. You admit that you have been seeing the Devil, and that he commands you to jump off buildings, a command you resist only with great difficulty. You don't know where you are or how you got there, and your only weak explanation is that malevolent demons magically transported you there and meddled with your mind so you don't remember it. Using the Outside View, what is the probability that you are even remotely sane?"

"Look," said Jesus. "Could you just tell me what the temptation is already?"

Satan waved his hand, and a syringe materialized within it. "5 mg haloperidol, IM" he told him.

Jesus looked at the Devil. He looked at the syringe. He looked at All The Kingdoms Of The World. He looked back at the Devil. His brow furrowed in thought. He looked at the syringe again.

Then his eyes shone as the Holy Spirit flowed through him. His indecision vanished. "Your lies have no power over me, demon," he told his tormentor.

"Please calm down," said Satan, only now he spoke with the voice of a middle-aged woman. "We're just trying to help you, Mr. Anderson. Please just hold still and let me give you your medication."

"Get thee behind me, Satan!" shouted the Christ, and he pushed the Devil off the mountain. Satan screamed as he plummeted, screamed with a woman's voice, until he vanished from sight in the depths below.

ATREUS, ATREUS, AND PELIDES: ATTORNEYS AT LAW

Paris of Troy came in secret to Sparta and abducted Helen, the most beautiful woman in the world. When her husband, King Menelaus, learned of the crime, he did what any red-blooded Achaean warrior would: he filed a lawsuit.

Mighty and dreadful were the ranks of his lawyers, for he ransacked all the vast treasuries of golden Sparta for attorneys' fees. To lead these hosts, he called upon great Agamemnon, son of Atreus, prince of the Bar Association of all Greece. So heavy was his briefcase that ten normal men could not lift it; so strong his glasses that they struck lesser men blind. Behind him marched the ten thousand lawyers of Mycenae, intelligent men all, each bearing gold-plated pens and wallets of real leather.

From Ithaka came wily Odysseus the divorce lawyer, who read law briefs as effortlessly as other men read newspapers. Close behind followed Diomedes, master of the closing argument, and mighty Ajax, whose fees could bankrupt entire villages. Next there arrived ancient Nestor and the lawyers of Pylos, clad in Arcadian polyester and fat with take-out meals.

Last of all came god-like Achilles, son of Thetis the sea-nymph. Proudly he came, clad in the custom-tailored suit fashioned by Hephaestus, craftsman of the gods, and upon his tie were painted scenes from the all great court cases of history. Here one could see Plessy debating Fergusen, and there, surrounded by a chorus of monkeys, Clarence Darrow gave his closing argument against William Jennings Bryan. Upon its bottom was the fearsome face of Rhadamanthus, judge of the Underworld, glaring balefully at the wincing image of O.J. Simpson.

By his side came his junior partner, Patroclus. Never before in judicial history have two lawyers been as inseparable as Achilles and Patroclus, nor shall ever they be again. Whenever Achilles argued a case, there sat Patroclus in the audience box, cheering him on, and whenever Patroclus argued a case, Achilles would stay up long into the night, helping him practice and prepare. As inseparable were they as thunder and lightning, as fire and smoke, as night and darkness.

When Priam, King of Troy, learned of the host gathered under the banners of Agamemnon, he turned pale with fear. Well he knew of the rage of Menelaus, of the compensatory damages he would demand, and of the additional punitive damages he would exact. Mighty was the wealth of Troy, jewels and coronets fashioned by gods and heroes, but all to naught would it come if Agamemnon's attorneys won their suit. And he begged of his son Paris that he return Helen to Menelaus, and agree to settle the matter out of court, lest the mighty walls of Troy be torn down and sold for scrap to pay for the Spartan king's emotional distress.

In that hour, almost did Paris turn away from the lawsuit, and petition for a pre-trial settlement. But Pallas Athena, whose bore a grudge ancient and implacable against Troy, hardened his heart, and a great resolve grew inside him to let the suit go to trial. And so he called upon all of the mighty attorneys of Ilium to build a case for the defense.

First he hired goddess-born Aeneas, son of Aphrodite, who could make juries swoon merely by winking at them, and Helenus the oracle, who knew what witnesses would say before they were even called to the stand. Penthesilea he hired, the Amazon lawyer who had cut off her left breast in order to better hold a briefcase, and Memnon, from deepest Ethiopia, an expert in civil rights suits. And to lead the defense team, he hired mighty Hector, driver of sports cars, whose Ferrari was as red as the blood of the rams sacrificed on the heights of Mount Ida, and faster than swift-winged Zephyrus.

When Agamemnon heard the news that Paris had hired mighty Hector's law firm, he knew that there would be no out-of-court settlement. So he rented from the men of Mycenae a thousand great corporate jets, to fly over the Aegean and bring his hosts to Troy. After many trials the hosts of the Achaeans at last reached the airport of Ilium, and from there headed to the great courtroom that stood by the banks of the Simois. Like to the courtrooms of Olympus it stood, its great stone blocks hewed by Heracles in days of old. Tall and strait were its fluted columns, like oaks as they rustle in the sacred groves of Dodona, and as comfy were its seats as the beds of the sea-nymphs in the grottos of Amphitrite. When a lawyer spoke, the microphones magnified his voice to sound like the bellowing of bulls, and when he was silent, a terrible hush would descend, like the quietude of the halls of Hades.

For a lawsuit of such import, Minos himself had come as judge. Two great Cyclopes had arisen from Tartarus as bailiffs, and the Fates, ever spinning their cloth, were the court clerks. One of the Cyclopes handed Minos his gavel, a thunderbolt fashioned in the smithies of Hephaestus, and so the trial began.

When Agamemnon arose to speak, so dreadful was his opening argument that the greater part of the Trojans turned to flee, as if their city had already been confiscated. So when Poseidon, the Maker of Earthquakes, strikes his trident into the deep; fish and seals flee in terror, and the ground itself shakes like a wounded thing; not otherwise did the opening arguments of Agamemnon shake the courtroom of Ilium. And when he had finished, the jury all stood as one man, ready and willing to pronounce Paris guilty of wrongful abduction.

But then Hector, driver of sports cars, rose to speak. And as he spoke, he accused the Achaeans of wasting the time of the courtroom, so obviously frivolous was their suit. The everlasting love between Helen and Paris he referenced, and the decision of Aphrodite, goddess of love, that Paris should have the most beautiful woman in the world as his wife. Even as he spoke, the jury conferred, deciding as one man that Paris was utterly innocent, that the Danaeans should not only return home to their shores but that the gold of Agamemnon should pay Paris' attorneys' fees, so frivolous his lawsuit. And when he had finished this, next he attacked the Achaeans' corporate jets, demanding to know whether they had the proper clearances to land in Trojan airspace, whether their pilots were properly trained, and more than all these, he attacked their safety certification. Upon hearing this, the Achaeans quaked with fear, knowing that at any moment their jets might be confiscated and themselves stranded in Troy without hope of return.

But before Minos could order the Greek jets confiscated, Achilles rose to speak. Much did the attorneys of Greece and Troy marvel at his suit, crafted by the gods, and at his tie, decorated as it was with the great court cases of history. But even more marvelled they at his savage objections, his terrifying points of order, his encyclopaedic knowledge of airline safety regulations. And with each section of the airline safety code he explained, Patroclus egged him on, until the Trojans fled the courtroom in fear, until sunset was upon them, and so ended the first day of the trial.

And in the Four Seasons' hotel, where the Greeks had made their camp, there was much rejoicing, and downing of great quantities of wine and spirits. But Calchas, the oracle, grew wary, and begged that the party might end and the Greeks get some rest for the days that were to come. Still further they partied, until, even at the stroke of midnight, Agamemnon drunk with wine and victory started making out with Briseis, secretary to Achilles.

Then god-like Achilles waxed great in anger, and demanded an apology from Agamemnon. But Agamemnon, angry as he was at being upstaged by Achilles in the deliberations of the day, refused. And at that point, Achilles swore a mighty oath - that until Agamemnon gave him control of the prosecutorial team, he should argue no more, but sit in his room at the Four Seasons skulking and watching Pay-Per-View movies.

As the next day dawned, the motorcade of the rented cars of the Greek attorneys drove to the courtroom with heavy hearts. But the Trojans, seeing that their foe had lost its champion, redoubled their efforts. Goddess-born Aeneas called Aphrodite to the stand and established that she had given Paris permission to carry Helen away. Then swarthy Memnon played the race card, asking whether Paris was being persecuted for his Trojan ancestry, and Penthesilia established a history of marital strife between Menelaus and Helen. And far-shooting Apollo himself blessed the Trojans, so that each of their objections hit true, and he set a veil of confusion upon the Greek cross-examiners, whose words seemed like mere babble, and whose points the jury missed entirely.

As dusk fell, the Greeks stood on the verge of being kicked out of Troy entirely. They returned to their camp at the Four Seasons full of fear, and immediately Agamemnon rented out the conference room and held a meeting with wily Odysseus. The prince of Ithaca begged him to allow Achilles to lead the prosecution, but Agamemnon's heart was hard, and three times he placed a curse upon the son of Peleus, and upon the day he ever entered law school. Then Odysseus knew he would have to develop a plan on his own.

And so Odysseus dressed Patroclus up in the god-tailored suit of Achilles, and draped around him the tie of Achilles, and handed unto him business cards saying "Achilles, son of Peleus, Attorney at Law". And all to whom he gave these business cards believed him to be Achilles, and so the Trojan lawyers fled from the courtroom as he arrived. Inspired, Patroclus made many incisive points, and all the members of the jury and the audience marvelled at the might and the wisdom of Achilles.

But Hector alone was unfazed, and he stood and countered all of Patroclus' arguments. Then he attacked Patroclus himself, impugning his honor, revealing that he had lied about his identity to the court, demanding that he be censured, no, cited for contempt of court! Zeus, king of gods and men, stood behind Hector and guided his words, and when he had finished speaking, Judge Minos decreed that it should so be, and Patroclus was hauled off to jail for contempt of court. Much was the weeping in the law firms of Skyros that day, and many the Myrmidons whose careers ended in disgrace.

Back in Troy, Hector was filled with dread, for he knew that Achilles would not let the incarceration of his junior partner pass. That night he had a vision that he was to die during the next day's procedures. He shared it with his wife, the beautiful Andromache, who merely laughed; for was he not Hector, the greatest lawyer in all Ilium? But seeing his face, she soon grew grave, and he made her promise that, should he perish, she was raise their child Astyanax to work hard so he might one day get into one of the great law schools and succeed him in his business. Having exacted this vow from his wife, he returned that morning to the court in his red Ferrari.

Also to the court drove Achilles, his rented black Porsche spewing a rain of sparks as his drive for vengeance spurred him forwards. That day, Achilles was unstoppable. He called as a character witness the nymph Oenone, who spoke of Paris' hard-hearted betrayal of her love. When the judge called for cross-examination, the Trojans cowered, none willing to approach the witness stand for fear of Achilles' wrath. At last, Hector arose and began to debate Achilles. Faster and faster their debate grew. Just as Hermes, winged messenger of the gods, flies from Olympus to Earth in the blink of an eye, not otherwise was the speed of these two lawyers as they debated Oenone's testimony. High above them, Zeus balanced their lives on a scale, and hung his head in sorrow as Achilles came out the victor. Just as the Trojan champion objected to the last of Pelides' points, Hector son of Priam suffered a stress-induced heart attack and fell to the ground, dead, just as falls the oak during a mighty thunderstorm.

In the midst of the Cyclopes' vain demands for order, great fighting broke out between the Greeks and Trojans for the body of Hector. Many laws were cited, and in vain did the Greeks and Trojans shout the virtues of their respective morgues and coroners. But at last the victory went to dreadful Achilles, whose white-hot rage had not yet cooled, and the son of Peleus tied it to the back of his Porsche. Thrice round the courthouse of Troy Achilles drove the carcass of mighty Hector, dragging it along the asphalt, until at last he tired of this, and yielded it to Priam, king of Troy.

The Trojans petitioned Minos for a recess of three days to celebrate Hector's funeral games; this the judge granted with a heavy heart. For three days there were mock trials, and debates, and speaking contests, and trivia bowls, until at last Hector's body was burned on a mighty funeral pyre, and his law firm ceremonially removed his name from their business cards. Thus perished Hector, driver of sports cars.

THREE MAGIC SYSTEMS IN SEARCH OF A FANTASY BOOK

(Note: Unsong!)

EMOTION POWERED MAGIC: There are mountains of fantasy novels where someone or other can draw power from people's negative emotions - you know, "Your suffering gives me strength!". But every time I've seen this trope, the power has always belonged to an evil character. That's the kind of lazy writing that makes most novels so cliched. Why not give the power to the good guys instead?

And of course the easiest way to deal with the resulting moral dilemma is to go utilitarian, say "Sure we'll kill or torture a bunch of people to gain magical strength, because we need magical strength to defeat the Dark Lord and save humankind." How boring.

I'd like to see a book about a group of deontologists with this power who are reduced to trying to get people to consent to be killed or tortured in order to provide them with magical strength. They could either convince their victims of the necessity of the sacrifice ("We've all got to pitch in if we want humankind to be saved") or else resort to simple bribery ("We'll give you 50 gold pieces if you'll cut off your arm in this magic circle so we can draw strength from your pain"). In the case of necromancy, such bribes might have to go to the next-of-kin. And although this would raise fewer ethical issues than the utilitarian version above, there's still the same kind of issues that make us uncomfortable with letting people sell their organs.

Maybe the best dramatic situation of all would be a world in which the method of gaining magic from human suffering was known both to good and bad factions, giving the evil factions a major advantage and forcing the good factions to determine exactly how far they wanted to go to catch up.

Then again, why should the only human emotion that generates magic be suffering? What about a world in which magic can be fueled only by human surprise? You'd have whole clans of wizards jumping out at people from behind bushes, or telling them counterintuitive facts ("Did you know that more time elapsed between the Pyramids and Cleopatra than between Cleopatra and the present day?") in preparation for magical duels. Eventually the population comes to expect wizards jumping out from behind bushes, and all the counterintuitive facts become common knowledge, and wizards have to up their game or risk losing their powers.

Or how 'bout a world with magic based on human happiness? "Once I give every child in my clean, well-run orphanage a puppy, I will be unstoppable!"

BRUTE-FORCE SPELL GENERATION: Magic spells are often triggered by words or sentences, but books rarely explain how one figures these out: who was the first person to try shouting "Avada kedavra!" to see if it would kill an enemy? In a world where magic spells and the means for discovering them have both been lost, one of the simplest routes to become an archmage is to brute force the problem. If we know that there exist several one-word magical spells of eight letters, for example, we can start by waving our wand and shouting "Aaaaaaaa!", then "Aaaaaaab!", "Aaaaaaac!" and so on. Now, this does leave 208 billion possibilities, but we can cut down on this pretty quickly

if we have some phonetic constraints: if magic is based on some ancient language spoken by humans or creatures with human-like phonetics, combinations like "Aaaaaaab!" and "Brtxkfkl!" are right out. Forcing alternating vowels and consonants reduces our search space by a factor of a thousand to about 200 million, but since magic words may not obey constraints quite this strict, let's round it off to an even 2 billion.

If a thousand different magic spells exist, we should expect to stumble across a magic spell in this reduced search space once every 2 million attempts. If testing a word for magical properties takes ten seconds, then in a ten hour workday one can test 36,000 words: that means stumbling across a new spell about once every two months.

But wizards are haughty and proud: no self-respecting archmage would put in two months of ten hour days testing nonsense words. Wizards in such a world would quickly settle upon the solution of "magical sweatshops" - taking on dozens of "apprentices" and assigning them the thankless task of testing letter combinations. A sweatshop with twelve apprentices working ten hour days could discover a bit over one new spell a week.

But by the time this process of magical research had shifted into high gear, the world would look quite different than when it began. It would be full of disgruntled apprentices, promised glory in the glamorous world of wizardry, who found their hopes betrayed by a "master" who has set them the most menial task imaginable and who takes all the fruits of their labor without teaching them anything in return. Some might believe the inevitable promises that "this great task I have assigned you is for the sharpening of your mind, and until you grasp the inner mysteries you will never know how important it is that you obey", but others will no doubt see through the facade and want the magical education they were promised.

If I had to make a plot out of this, it would involve such an apprentice wizard who one day stumbles onto a spell for immortality, or infinite wealth, or secret wisdom, or something else that gives him power lots of people want. Instead of turning it over to his master like he's supposed to, he decides to go rogue and use his newfound power to start a sort of proletarian revolution.

SPELL PIRACY: But if I had to write only one unusual-magic-system book, it would be about spell piracy.

In most fantasy books, all the powerful magic is kept very, very secret. If it's not locked inside a glowing crystal at the bottom of the Well of Dreams in the Mountains of Madness far across the Freptane Sea, then at least it's in a moldering book in the secure library of an arch-wizard who refuses to share it with you.

The wizards usually say this is because lesser souls are not ready for the secrets, but that's exactly the sort of thing they would say. Rare is the spell as dangerous as the common fertilizer-bomb, yet bomb-making instructions are all over the Internet and civilization hasn't collapsed yet.

More likely, the wizards just want to maintain an advantage over their competitors. They have the very capitalist - and admirable! - notion that the one who does the work ought to reap the benefit. If I cross the Freptane Sea, climb the Mountains of Madness, and dive into the Well of Dreams seeking the ancient crystal upon which a spell is inscribed, I'm going to be pretty pissed if I see Gandalf casting the same spell next week without having done any of that stuff, just because he overheard me chanting the magic words.

But this hurts all wizards: even the mightiest wizard ends up with no more than the few spells he manages to discover himself. If there are synergistic combinations of spells, or high-level spells which require mastery of multiple lower-level spells to obtain, no wizard will be able to discover them. If a wizard dies without taking a pupil, all his spells are lost forever. And if a goblin horde or a Dark Lord threatens the land, these measly wizards with their couple of spells each will be easy pickings.

So a smart King, as his first priority, would implement an intellectual property system for magic. If Merlin discovers the spell for summoning blizzards, he can copyright it. Then he can write as many books about it as he wants, publicize it to the international magical community, but be secure in his knowledge that anyone who wants to summon a blizzard will have to pay the licensing fee. The advantages are obvious: wizards who need a spell can pay for it, wizards are further incentivized to develop as many spells as possible, magical libraries can be open for unrestricted research, and after the death of a wizard his spells can go into the public domain, creating a wide base of freely available spells after only a few generations. And if a goblin horde or Dark Lord attacks, the King will have an army of wizards proficient with every known spell to fight them off.

But magic copyright will encounter the same problems as mundane copyright. Imagine knowing the spell to cure plague, having all of the components arrayed in front of you, your sister is dying of plague this very moment, but Allanon discovered that spell and won't let you cast it without paying his fee, which you can't afford. And the Magic Copyright Police are the most feared wizards in the land, and the penalty for infringement is more gold pieces than exist in the entire world, because the wizardry industry has really good courtiers.

Also, there would be literal patent trolls.

No, I take it back. I would merge this with the last idea. Spells can only be discovered by brute-forcing it. But the only incentive to found magical sweatshops would be the knowledge that you would retain intellectual property rights of the spells you invented. And a young apprentice, overwhelmed with the exploitation inherent in the system, discovers a spell that allows him to evade the Magic Copyright Police and absconds from the sweatshop. Now able to cast unlimited spells without negotiating agreements with the license-holders, he is the most powerful wizard alive, and sets about trying to destroy the corrupt system. But unbeknownst to him, demons lurk on the edge of the world, and without the exploitative economy and its incentives to continue discovering spells, the wizards will go back to hoarding the few shreds of magic they got from

crossing the Freptane Sea and so on, and the inhabited world will become easy prey for the legions of Hell.

These three ideas are available, Magic Copyright Police-free, to anyone interested in expanding on any of them, although I warn you that I keep hearing these weird rumors that fantasy is supposed to be escapist or something.

BLESSED ARE THE TAXONOMERS, FOR THEIRS IS THE PHYLUM OF GOD

Theology will never be a true science until it becomes more precise. For example, did you know that God has yet to be put in the binomial nomenclature used to classify species? That's right, we have everything from *Balaena mysticetus*, the bowhead whale, to *Branta albifrons*, the white-footed goose, but no God. While this may be acceptable to so-called "intelligent design" theorists who want to separate God from Creation, as good scientists who believe in evolution we need to put God on the evolutionary tree just like everyone else. Of course, we have no fossils or DNA evidence, which complicates the task, but as I shall show in this essay, we have something which, in this case, is equally useful - the Bible. While the Bible has generally been off-limits as a source of scientific since the mid-sixteenth century outside the state of Tennessee, I think we can accept, in this case at least, its expertise in the subject area.

For example, take the broadest and most important question in developing a divine taxonomic classification - what kingdom is God in? One possible answer would be that He is in Animalia - after all, He created Man in His own image, and Man is an animal. Further, God possesses the sort of advanced intelligence typically associated with the animal kingdom. However, the Bible clearly rejects this. In the apocryphal Gospel of Thomas, Jesus says: "If those who lead you say to you, 'look, the Kingdom of God is in the sky,' then the birds will get there first. If they say 'It is in the ocean,' then the fish will get there first." By this, Jesus seems to be implying that birds and fish are not in the Kingdom of God - thus, the Kingdom of God cannot be animalia. Since God cannot reasonably be considered a plant, a fungus, or a protist (and even suggesting Archaea is getting dangerously close to blasphemy) we must ascribe God to a completely new kingdom. In retrospect, this is not surprising, since God's evolutionary origin seems to be completely different than that of lower beings, and since He lacks hallmarks common to all kingdoms such as composition by cells.

If God is in a new kingdom, what other life-forms can be said to inhabit it? Are the angels a member of this kingdom? What about the souls of the blessed? The souls of the damned? Again, the Bible provides an answer. In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus proclaims "Blessed are the poor, for theirs is the Kingdom of God." (Matthew 5:3) Since we know that the poor themselves, as members of Animalia, cannot be literally in the kingdom of God, Jesus must be referring to their souls, or their lot in the world to come. Thus, we know that the souls of the blessed are in this new kingdom. The angels, being more closely related to God than the blessed, can also be placed therein. And the souls of the damned? According to Jesus in Matthew 19:24, "It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God." Since we can suppose that the difficulty Jesus referred to in this metaphor was that of becoming blessed, he seems to mean that those who are not blessed will not enter into the kingdom of God; thus, the damned are part of a different kingdom entirely. Because the defining feature of the kingdom of God seems to be blessedness, we will give it the Latin name *Benedictia*.

The Bible is strangely silent on the subject of God's phylum. We have equally little information about His class. Thus, to determine these categories, we must work back from the first category we do have some knowledge of - the level of orders.

6th century theologian St. Dionysius the Areopagite developed the theory, based on St. Paul's allusion in Ephesians I, chapter 21, that there were nine angelic orders - the seraphim, cherubim, thrones, dominions, virtues, powers, principalities, archangels, and angels. This classification is later supported by St. Thomas Aquinas in the Summa. Further, these angelic orders are subdivided into a higher grouping - three angelic choirs, each with three orders in them. What St. Dionysius called choirs seem to be what we today would call classes, seeing as they are groupings of orders based on resemblance. If there are three different classes of angels, we can assume that angels themselves must be a phylum. Therefore, we know that God is differentiated from the angels, and thus also from the blessed souls, at the phylum level. Let us call His phylum Divinia, to emphasize that it contains only divine beings and not the other varieties of blessed life-forms.

At first glance this leaves us with very little for the class, order, family, genus, and species level to do, but in fact nothing could be further from the truth. It is still necessary to differentiate God from all of the other gods in the phylum Divinia, including pagan gods, primitive tribal gods, and even His closest living relative, Allah.

Here we must turn from the Bible and head into modern theology, in which the term "Abrahamic family of religions" is used to describe Christianity, Islam, and Judaism (for example, religious scholar Huston Smith begins an essay with "Of all the non-Western religions, Islam stands closest to the West-closest geographically, and also closest ideologically; for religiously it stands in the Abrahamic family of religions"). Thus, we can ascribe the Christian, Jewish, and Muslim gods to the family Abrahamia, leaving us with class and order to get from all gods to those three species. God's order would then be Divinia again, in order to class Him as a true God rather than just a minor tribal spirit (rather in the same way humans are *Homo sapiens sapiens*, to class us as true humans rather than mere hominids) and His class would be Monotheistica, excluding the class of pagan gods (who then divide into the families of Nordica, Graecia, Hindustania, et cetera. We can confirm that we are correct at this point by noting that the gods of a particular pagan religion were always referred to as families, cf. the Olympian family)

At the genus level, we come to subdivide particular religions. Thus, the family Abrahamia contains genera *Islamia*, *Christiania*, and *Judaica*. We could expect each of these genera to contain a single species, *deus*. It should be noted at this point that some Christian theobiologists would prefer to separate out *Christiania deus* into three separate species, *Christiania pater*, *Christiania filius*, and *Christiania spiritussancti*. However, this has been denounced by mainstream scholars as a version of the Arian Heresy, and the official scientific consensus as formulated at the Council of Nicaea is that *pater*, *filius*, and *spiritussancti* are merely local subspecies of *C. deus*.

It should be noted by conservationists that all species in the order Monotheistica are critically endangered, with only one known specimen and zero surviving females. Theobiologists were briefly encouraged by the preliminary success of a program to clone the last surviving specimen of *C. deus* and implant the embryo into a human surrogate mother, but the offspring was killed shortly after release into the wild. After this disaster and the strong feelings it engendered, further research in this field has been postponed indefinitely.

THE FIRES OF THESSALONIKI

Chapter I

Back in the unremembered ages, Hera, queen of the gods, gave birth to a baby boy with a crippled leg. Disgusted, she threw young him down from Mount Olympos, where he fell for nine long days before hitting the ocean. But young Hephaistos was a god, and gods don't drown as easily as you or I. The sea nymphs found him lying there on the ocean floor and adopted him as their own. When Hephaistos grew to manhood, he found work as a blacksmith, but his divine talents soon raised him above others of that profession, and he found himself no longer welcome on earth. Undaunted, he returned to Olympos, demonstrating his mettle as a god and demanding to be given his rightful place.

Ares, the god of war, wasn't so enthusiastic. "Here's this cripple," Ares said, "his leg doesn't even work right, can't fight a war, can't ride a chariot, and he wants to be recognized as a god. Just let anyone in, why don't we?" Ares made a convincing argument, but the gods agreed to give the newcomer a chance. Hephaistos went into his magical smithy and came out a few days later laden with gifts. To Hades, he gave a helmet of invisibility, so that Death could stalk the world unseen. To Eros, a magical bow and arrow, to shoot the poison of Love from afar into the hearts of men and women. To Apollo, a great golden chariot on which to carry the sun each morning, and to Hermes, winged sandals that let him travel as fast as the wind. To Zeus himself he gave the lightning, the mightiest and best of weapons. Only Ares didn't get anything.

The gods were impressed. Apollo flew around and around in his nice new sun chariot. Hades traveled the world unseen. Hermes flew around and around the whole circle of lands seven times in a second. Eros – well, we all know how Eros uses that bow of his. And Zeus was so impressed that he not only invited Hephaistos up to Olympos, but offered him the hand in marriage of Aphrodite, most beautiful of goddesses – and incidentally, Ares' girlfriend.

Ares fumed and plotted, and came up with a plan to cuckold Hephaistos. Like a lot of Ares' ideas, it wasn't much of a plan - march in one day when Hephaistos was out and have his way with Aphrodite – but it worked. Aphrodite wasn't exactly unwilling. Anyway, the sun saw this, being the sun, and remembering who gave it its nice new chariot it let Hephaistos know. Hephaistos went into his magical smithy and created a clever little piece of techne. The next time he went out, Ares came marching in for another tryst with his lover, they got into the bed, and whoosh – a big metal net came down and scooped them both up. Hephaistos came in, saw them, shamed them before all the gods, and won the day...

Thirty stadia from Chalastra, a sudden bump woke me from my dreams. The autokineton was beginning to slow now; the blurred hills and orchards coalesced into familiar forms, and the rhythmic bounce of the carriage grew less and less jarring. The two hypaspistai arose in a single synchronized motion, sheathed their swords, and stood waiting just in front of the door.

I sat and rubbed my eyes. The dream had been a scene from the stories of my childhood, one of the old myths my mother had told me. They came to me often, this one most of all. I yawned, propped my head on my elbow, and lazily twirled my dark brown hair, watching the gradually more recognizable landmarks through the window opposite my silk-lined seat. The low golden hills of Kretonia shone in the noonday sun, and opposite them the Thermaic Gulf rolled its clear blue waters barely a stadion from the siderodromos. The sweltering Macedonian heat and the slow beat of the engine had lulled me into a near-trance, but I was now fully awake. As the autokineton came to a final screeching halt, I stood up at last, balancing my weight first of all on my good foot, and took my walking stick from where it lay beside me on the richly tiled floor.

The two hypaspistai had opened the door and were now talking to someone outside; probably explaining the purpose of their visit to one of the king's household stewards. I idly fingered the marble bust of the great philosopher Aristoteles beside me on a fine oaken table. Everything about the royal carriage was exquisitely crafted, from the clear glass of the windows to the mosaic on the ceiling to the paneled wood that made the walls. I had taken the autokineton almost weekly for the past few years, as far as Pella and Amphipolis, but never before ridden in such style or elegance. It was just one of the many advantages of having the King of Macedonia as a patron.

The hypaspistai finished their unheard conversation and beckoned for me to follow them outside. Carefully, I stepped over the gap onto the platform and looked around. The countryside here was particularly flat, but a pleasant enough area, full of tall grass and well-kept fruit trees. The villa was there ahead of me, gracefully worked into the rolling fields rather than disturbing them. It was smaller and quieter than I expected, but I could see how it might be a welcome respite from the bustle of Thessaloniki.

The previously unseen conversation partner of the hypaspistai, a beautiful young man with carefully curled hair and a gold-embroidered tunic, bowed curtly. I vaguely recognized him as someone I saw often at the palace back in the city.

"Chaire," he greeted me. "You are Kassandros, the technosopher?"

I acknowledged him with a nod.

"I am Diodoros, servant of King Alexandros. His Majesty is honored to have you here today and welcomes you to his humble country home. Please follow me." Without further remark, Diodoros was off, stepping gracefully off the platform onto a stone path through a grove of trees. The two hypaspistai followed him, marching in perfect lockstep.

It wasn't far. Past the trees was a broad meadow watered by a winding stream, and there in the center of the meadow was the villa. It was everything you would expect from a king: like other country villas across Macedonia, only bigger and more expensive. Other villas might have had a bust or two to liven up the garden; Alexandros' home was defended by a veritable wall of statuary. Other villas might have had a small colonnade; the whole front wall there was a whole series of

ornate Corinthian columns. Other villas might have boasted a mural or two; there you could have used the walls to reconstruct the entire history of Greece, from the creation of the world on through the mythological era, to the Trojan War, through the Golden Age of Athens, down past Megas Alexandros and all the way into the present. As we reached the threshold, the two hypaspitai who had been my escort raised their swords in salute and turned back, while I followed Diodoros through the door into the courtyard.

"Please, let me apologize for the somewhat unusual nature of your visit," he told me, as we crossed the spacious courtyard. "The King wanted to meet with you in private, where your presence would not be observed or remarked upon. I am certain you understand. He has been hunting at his villa for the past three days and felt its quiet nature would make a perfect setting to discuss his business with you. Your journey here was comfortable?"

"Yes, thank you," I told him. The king's private autokineton carriage had been infinitely preferable to the usual crowded cars, although the presence of the hypaspitai had unnerved me.

"Excellent," said Diodoros, as we reached the far end of the courtyard. The doors there swung open of their own accord. A pressure-sensitive plate under the floor, combined with a system of weights, most likely. A few years ago I had made a couple of drachmae by installing a similar system in the mansion of a Thessaloniki businessman, but they were impressive enough to someone who didn't know how they worked.

And there at the far end of the library sat King Alexandros VI, poring over a set of old scrolls. Five or six were scattered willy-nilly across an old oaken table that dominated the room, covered with vague maps of unspecified realms. Five or six thousand others lay meticulously arranged in the ceiling-high shelving that ringed the room so completely that a skylight provided the only illumination. The king spent a final second making a last mental note of the scroll's contents, then put it down and smiled at me. "Kassandros. Chaire, and welcome."

I bowed before my patron. The young Alexandros was dressed in a pure white chiton stained with just a streak of Tyrian purple. His short sandy hair was bound with a crown of golden laurel leaves. He motioned for me to sit down, and I did so, laying my walking stick at my feet.

"The *Icarus* went to Dion two days ago, I hear," said Alexandros. "How did the test flight go?" He suddenly noticed, and stared in consternation at, the massive bruise on my left arm. "Not so well?"

"It went perfectly," I told him, strategically folding my arms on my lap, where the table blocked them from view. "I had, ah, a little bit of an incident with the kystis during the descent when I was returning to Thessaloniki. Nothing major. The aerodyne suffered just a couple of scratches. But we're sure we know what went wrong, absolutely sure. Peithon is patching it up even as we speak. The important thing is that I made it. I got to Dion about seven and a half hours after takeoff, with fuel to spare, and it took me about the same amount of time to get home.

"The kystis?" Alexandros repeated the unfamiliar term.

"Do you remember when I explained this to you in Thessaloniki? The aeolipile burns coal, which turns a turbine connected to a aerohelix. The aerohelix pushes air and allows me to control the direction of movement and to go against the wind as long as it isn't too strong. At the same time, air is being passed through the aeolipile until it becomes burning hot, and then funneled into a huge sac. Because the hot air naturally rises, it lifts the sac, and if there is enough of it, it lifts the aerodyne attached to the sac as well. The kystis is that sac. It's made of reinforced cloth. By changing the size and shape of the kystis by pulling on the attached ropes, we can adjust our altitude. I must have pulled too hard on one of the ropes, or stretched it too far out of position."

Alexandros looked concerned. "How long will the repairs take? You don't need to weave a whole new kystis, do you? That would take weeks, even with a rhapsurge."

"No, no. We're going to try to patch up the rip and lower the steering force to see if we can prevent further problems. We'll probably have the *Icarus* ready to fly again in few days. Maybe a week."

To my consternation, Alexandros looked irritated. "Is there anything I can do to speed up the process? Do you need more parts? More slaves? Some more technosphers to share the work?"

"Thank you," I said, "but at this point Peithon and I really just need time to make the repairs. You're very generous, and once again without your constant support the aerodyne could never have come to be at all."

"Oh, I don't know about that," said the king humbly, but smiling at the flattery. "You've been working on this idea for a long time, and neither of you is exactly poor. Although I have heard from Peithon about his troubles with his uncle." He sighed. "But this was an idea whose time has long since arrived. Since my illustrious namesake, we have had the autokineton on land, and for a century and a half the atmonhes on the seas, and now, finally we can take to the skies. Thanks to you and your fellow technosphers, we have come further than Alexandros III could ever have imagined."

"I wouldn't go that far," I said without thinking. "Alexandros III could imagine a lot of things."

Back in the old days, Macedonia had been just another power-hungry, omnivorous little kingdom. In the time of Philippos II, we conquered all of Greece; not Sparta, but all the normal parts anyway, as far as Thebai and Athenai. Then Philippos II died, killed by his ex-lover (male, of course, the kings of Macedonia have never been picky). His son, Alexandros III, succeeded him, and proved himself to be a military genius, even more so than Phillipos. He was the one who defeated the Sacred Band at Chaeronea, crushed Thrakia and Illyria in the north, inspired such awe that the legends about his divine birth circulated across Greece even before he took the throne. And he thought big. His goal was no less than to continue the project of his father: the conquest of Persia, mightiest empire in the world. He might have done it. But near the close of his Thracian campaign, Thebai revolted. There

was a battle, which Alexandros won. He couldn't show any mercy; he destroyed the whole town, except according to legend the house of the poet Pindar. Alexandros liked his poetry. Thousands died. And then Aristoteles, the philosopher, his childhood tutor, showed up and told him to look around. He pointed to the ruins of the city, the corpses, all the blood, and just asked him, is this The Good?

And Alexandros III said no.

He went home to Macedonia and started studying philosophy. He had always studied philosophy a little, but this was different. The legends say he gave up sleep for weeks on end. After a while, Aristoteles had nothing left to teach him. But he wasn't content with the philosophical systems of the world. He wanted something concrete, some method of making the world give up its secrets not only to the reason but to the senses as well. He took Aristoteles' methods and began systematizing them, and then taking them in a completely unexpected direction. By the time he was finished, his work could no longer be described as philosophy. That was how technosophy got invented. Alexandros invented the teleskopos and the chronokyklon, and more important, the aeolipile and the two vehicles it made possible, the atmonaus and the autokineton.

For three hundred years before Alexandros, there had been philosophers, and for uncounted millennia there had been craftsman and engineers. Ever since Prometheus, people from Aethiopia to Hyperborea used and lit fires. But King Alexandros of Macedon had been the first to look past the fire to the smoke that rose above it, and to harness that smoke into the first aeolipile, the steam engine, and become larger than life, a second Prometheus. That was why they called him Megas Alexandros, Alexander the Great.

"True," agreed Alexandros VI. "Still, your first successful test flight is a great accomplishment. A great achievement for the Macedonian people."

"Once Peithon and I repair the aerodyne, I plan to fly from here to Samothraki. That will prove that aerodynes may someday be an efficient way to make journeys over both land and water."

"Right." He put down his parchment. "As a leading technosophist, I understand you probably have a busy schedule." He was in Prepared Speech Mode now. "But there are times when your country calls you to her service. I know you are no soldier, but nevertheless, Macedonia needs you, and it is your duty, nay, your privilege, to respond to her distress." He grimaced, and dropped Prepared Speech Mode as if it were rotten fruit. "Kassandros, we've got a certain...problem, that's resisted all conventional methods. We need to get someone in somewhere, or rather out of somewhere, in a hurry, without a lot of people noticing. It sort of occurred to me your aerodyne might be a valuable asset."

I love Macedonia, but I also have some common sense. "Your Majesty, with all due respect, the Icarus has only made one medium-range flight so far. It's easy to spot, it's useless in battle, it's slow, and it can only carry one or two people."

"I understand all that," the king told me. "I won't need you to go far, I won't need you to go fast, I won't need you to fight, and I only need you to bring me back one person. I agree that it's easy to spot, but who's going to be looking? Soldiers watch the land, and the sea if they're expecting an attack by ship, but who's going to be looking up in the air? Up until a few months ago no one had made a flight since Daedalos, and even the couple of people who know what you're doing think it's just an interesting new technosophic experiment. Kassandros, this is not a request. This is an order."

That settled it then. Alexandros was a good king, a personable king, but he was still a king. When he wanted something, he could demand it. But it wasn't the way a Macedonian in the new age was used to being treated. Alexandros must have sensed my disappointment.

"And, if you succeed, I think it will increase my confidence in the aerodyne enough that I would be glad to help finance the Bellerophon."

The Bellerophon. For a year now it had been just a name and a cloud of ideas. What would the next generation of aerodyne technology be, if we had a chance to build it? It wasn't even a design on paper, just something Peithon and I would talk about longingly. I couldn't even guess how Alexandros had heard of it until I remembered we had mentioned some of the advantages of a dual-aeolipile design in front of Lintalis. It was amazing enough that we got money for the Icarus. To be able to build the Bellerophon, to actually build it and stand on it and fly it, that would be fantastic.

A good king knows how to make people follow orders. A great king knows how to make them like it. Alexandros VI was a great king.

"Your Majesty," I said, perhaps too theatrically. "I am at your service."

Alexandros graced me with another of his smiles. Then he unrolled the scroll in front of him and leaned forward, once again dead serious.

"Tell me, Kassandros, do you remember Lykias?"

Chapter II

When King Amyntas VIII of Macedonia had married Archileonis the Spartan princess, the citizens of two nations had held their collective breath. To the men of Macedonia, the Spartans were lunatics, abandoning the arts and sciences for a bloody-minded devotion to subduing and enslaving their neighbors. To the Spartans, the Macedonians were no better than women, spoiled hedonists who played with glass and metal because they were too cowardly for battle.

But Athenai and Thebai had allied, we didn't like Thebai, the Spartans didn't like Athenai, and so according to the ancient and venerable rules of politics we had to ally with Sparta. It was a bad idea from the start, us being a young but proud monarchy on the northern edge of Greece with a penchant for the technosophic arts, and them being lunatics. But everyone went ahead with it, and to make everybody all friendly our King Amyntas VI married the Spartan princess Archileonis. I

expect the King went before the priests pretty sure that he was getting the better end of that deal: he was about fifty and had a head bald like a hen's egg, she was twenty and gorgeous. Gorgeous and well-bred and well-spoken, and she gave birth to a beautiful healthy baby boy...

...seven months after the wedding.

Fingers had been pointed. Investigations had been made. Rumors had spread all across Greece, until it had seemed like the only person without some theory or another had been Archileonis herself, who maintained an imperturbable silence on the matter. In the old days there would have been some suitable punishment for her, something to make Prometheus' fate of getting his liver pecked out daily by a giant eagle seem downright pleasant. Instead, King Amyntas had banished Archileonis and the infant Lykias to Sparta, where Agasicles could punish his daughter for the diplomatic disaster as he saw fit. A few years later, the king had remarried and conceived his heir, Alexandros.

And that was the birth of Lykias. Anyone else's life could only get more reasonable from there, but Lykias had a talent for trouble.

He was raised as a Spartan, in the traditional Spartan manner. Taken from parents, brutal military training, punishment, pederasty, pigheadedness. He ran in the Olympics for a few years, and I understand he won the laurel wreath at one of the track events. When Amyntas died, he sailed up to Thessaloniki, hoping to somehow claim the Macedonian throne. It failed for a few reasons, most notably that he had no idea what was going on, nobody liked him, he wasn't Amyntas' real son anyway, and Alexandros VI had already been happily reigning for some time. He blustered around for a while before Alexandros gave him command of the Macedonian army. This seemed to suit him well for a few months, and then he started yelling at people and demanding we declare war on Persia.

"Lykias the Arean?" I asked. "The moron who got himself killed?" Alexandros' feelings about the Spartan were very public, and I had my own strong opinions of him and his Areans. "I remember," I assured him. "He was before my time, but I hear the stories often enough. My condolences on his fate." I doubted Alexandros was particularly upset that his not-quite-half-brother had crossed the river Styx some three years ago, but it always paid to be courteous. "Spare me," Alexandros said. "Lykias is alive."

"Alive? How can that be? Wasn't he - "

At first, Alexandros had tolerated demands to invade Persia for the same reason he tolerated philosophers - the optimistic hope that no one would be stupid enough to actually listen to them. By the time he realized his mistake, Lykias had actually convinced a few people; the sort so bloodthirsty and so oblivious to odds that one wondered if they were secretly Spartans. I couldn't remember exactly what his arguments had been; something about the Persians being the natural enemies of the Greeks, or plotting to destroy us. Megas Alexandros had understood the danger, and

that was why he had prepared an army against Persia until that accursed day when the philosophers had stolen his courage. It was all lies, of course, but they resonated with certain people, the kind who hated technosophers and thought you could prove your manhood by grabbing a spear, finding someone else with a spear, and trying to kill them. So Alexandros banned all talk of invading Persia, and at last banished Lykias from Macedonia a second time.

The Spartan prince had fled to Ionia, across the Hellespont, and settled in Miletos, right on the Persian border. The Ionian towns had been free from Persia for only a few centuries, and the memory of foreign rule still grated on them. He'd spent seven years there, ingratiating himself with kings and aristocrats, and at last had managed to convince five of the seven cities of Ionia to provide him with troops and supplies. Triumphantly, he'd led his army to the gates of Sardis, the Persian regional capital – and his army had been annihilated in a few hours by the Persian satrap Godatas. Ionia, almost defenseless, had been forced to make embarrassing concessions to the Shah. Lykias himself had died in the fighting.

"Lykias didn't die at Sardis," Alexandros said. "We thought he did, but alas, we were wrong. He was captured."

"Go on," I said.

"I thought he was dead too until a few weeks ago. At least until I got this." He shuffled through the scrolls lying on the table for an uncomfortably long period of time, but coming up empty-handed.

"At least until I got a letter," he corrected himself. "From a spy of ours. Lykias was taken prisoner by the Persians. They've had him locked up in a string of dungeons across Asia and Palaestina. They wanted to keep him as a hostage, and maybe to trade him to us for some concession later. But nothing came up. So they traded him to the Thebans, who had the same idea."

"Uh-huh," I said. "And what do they want?"

This was the point at which I became lost.

"Perdelis, the hegemon of the Phocian League, died a few weeks ago. He was a friend to Macedon, and while he was alive, Phocis was our ally against the Thebans. Now, the Phocians will have to elect a new hegemon, and we know that Thebai is supporting their own candidate. If Phocis aligns with Thebai, our military advantage on the Boeotian border disintegrates. Persia has given Lykias to Thebai. They plan to spare his life only if we agree to support their candidate in Phocis. Artaxerxes must have known he could do more damage to us this way than by killing him outright."

"And are you going to do what Thebai wants?"

"Of course not. Lykias deserves whatever he gets. He's an idiot, and whether or not he was born in Thessaloniki he is no Macedonian prince. If the Thebans get rid of him, they'd be doing all of us a

favor. But still. The problem is that somehow the fool managed to become popular here, at least with a certain class of people. The outcry when I banished him was quite disgusting. If I tell the Thebans they're welcome to kill the fool, I could have a revolt on my hands. At the very least, Cleitus wouldn't like it, and the military wouldn't be happy either. With Persia and Thebai allied, an unhappy military is the last thing I need. You understand that?"

"Uh, yes," I said. "How do you know all this, by the way?"

"No matter," the king said quickly. "The point is, we're going to have to try something creative. Lykias is on Antipsyra right now." He revealed to me his map at last, which showed the Aegean from Macedonia down to Crete. The whole sea was spotted with islands, from the Kyklades in the south to Samothraki up north. Antipsyra was one of the smallest; it seemed to be around the middle, maybe a little further east. I hadn't heard of it before.

"There are two triremes and a phalanx based on the larger nearby island of Psyra; they'll be guarding him in addition to whatever other duties they have there. Their main defense is their isolation; no one lives on Antipsyra except Lykias and the soldiers watching him, making it almost impossible to communicate with." He stressed the word 'almost.' "We could invade with a fleet, but that would mean open war on Thebai, and it's not worth it. So I need a way to reach an island other than by sea, which is of course impossible. Luckily, I have bright technosophers like you who can help."

"I see," I said. I was probably looking a little pale at this point. "I've, uh, never really been in any sort of military operation before, because of my leg, and I'm still not entirely sure what the range of the aerodyne might be."

"Your leg will be fine," said Alexandros. "You won't even need to leave the aerodyne. And I have Lintalis calculating the range. He'll make sure that everything is under control."

I felt my objections deflate like a ruptured kystis. To worry about the safety of a plan conceived by Lintalis was more than unnecessary; it was downright perverse.

"Tomorrow, I will send my Royal Secretary to you and Peithon with the specifics of the plan and some further information. Mandytas will be announcing his candidacy for the hegemony of the Phocian League in two weeks' time, and I want this finished before then. You'll fly to Antipsyra, snatch Lykias, and be a stadion in the air before the Thebans even realize he's gone."

"Ah, yes, Your Highness."

"One more thing, Kassandros. You're smart; not just a good technosopher, but a good head for politics too. I want you to know that, uh, the official histories about Lykias might not be, uh, completely honest. He was enough of a problem that it was easier to make him a laughingstock than to worry about people admiring him."

“He made himself a laughingstock,” I assured him.

“Yes, well...” Alexandros trailed off. “Don’t underestimate him, that’s all.”

Chapter III

Fifteen stadia northeast of the Temple of Alexandros, where the course of the siderodromos bends on its way toward the lakes of Mygdonia and the eastern terminus at Amphipolis, there is a small dilapidated station with a forlorn dirt road that wound through a few small farms before disappearing into the Krestian hills. Travelers who follow it into the foothills will eventually come to a small valley maybe an hour’s ride on horseback from Thessaloniki city center. Here stands the country villa of Peithon, heir to a branch of one of Macedonia’s noblest families and infamously reclusive technosopher.

The great inventor sat, as he so often did, in a curious barn on the very edges of his property, teasing various pieces of metal into position.

“I hammered the aeolipile back into shape while you were off with the king yesterday,” he told me, continuing to hammer away. We made an unlikely-looking pair. I was tall and thin, while Peithon was short and stout and wielded the hammer only by awkwardly flinging his weight into it. I was clean-shaven, while Peithon had a bushy, unkempt beard, through which he frequently ran his fingers when thinking. His hair had been partly burnt away in an accident. It was probably just as well that he rarely left his workshop except under protest.

“Peithon!” I protested loudly. “You know you’re no good with that kind of thing! You should have waited for me to get back. Here, give me that hammer.”

“Oh, right, Hephaistos to the rescue,” said Peithon dryly. I had suffered from the nickname ‘Hephaistos’ ever since I began working with metal. It was probably inevitable; I share the blacksmith’s god’s deformity, a lame right leg. I took the hammer from Peithon and continued beating out the imperfections from the metal shell.

“I was thinking,” I mentioned in between hammer blows, “that on the *Bellerophon*, we ought to have two small aeolipiles instead of one big one. It would solve our distribution of weight problem, and we could have a second in case something happened.”

Peithon grunted. “We would have to redo the diagrams again. And it would cost more money.”

“Peithon! I already told you, King Alexandros offered to fund us!”

“In exchange for us becoming a political asset to him. That’s the word you said he used. Asset. Since Megas Alexandros died, these kings have all been the same. They pay lip service to technosophy, but their hearts aren’t in it. They’re as Arean as any Spartan. The only difference between Alexandros and Lykias is that Alexandros is halfway intelligent about it.”

"But look at all the technosophic projects they've supported. The autokineton. The atmonhes. The observatory on Olympos. The factories. The katapeltes. And all of the little pieces of techne that we don't even think about. King Alexandros and his predecessors have funded all of those. They have to; they're Megas Alexandros' successors. They share his ideas about a peaceful land of arts and wisdom."

"The atmonhes give us a navy faster and stronger than triremes ever could. The autokineton means we can move soldiers to the front faster than our enemies. The katapeltes: you think the king cares about ballistics? He just wants a machine that can hurl rocks into an enemy city! All my life I've dreamed of conquering the forces that keep us earthbound; so have you: you told me when we started working on *Icarus*. But to the king, getting the aerodyne off the ground only means that he has a new tool to spy on Thebai or rescue morons from some tiny island."

"Look, Kass. We can conquer the air, lift off into the clouds. But there's one thing that will always pull us back into the mud, and that's politics. Aristoteles convinced Megas Alexandros that he could escape that pull; could create a sort of political aerodyne that would leave behind everyone scrambling after their own power or glory or personal advantage and lift off into heaven. But it didn't work. He died, and his perfect state sunk back down to earth, right in between the Persians and the Thebans and the Paionians. Since then, all we can do is our own work, seek the truth whether or not anyone else cares, and tell politicians to stay the Hades away from us, same as we'd do with someone who had the plague."

It was close to the longest Peithon had ever spoken at one stretch. "I didn't know you felt that way". He had talked about politics only rarely in the six years we had worked together. "So that's why you never vote in the ekklesia. I had thought it was just...you know." Peithon was infamous for staying away from people, for not even leaving his villa if he could avoid it.

"It's that too," the inventor admitted.

"But Peithon," I protested, laying aside the hammer and taking a seat on the aeolipile covering, "Alexandros fights Lykias' sort almost every chance he gets. You heard what I said; he's tried to resolve the situation with Thebai peacefully. You can't fault him for wanting to protect Macedon. Even if you don't want to fight, sometimes you have to. If Persia invades, we're going to have to defend ourselves whether we're prepared or not. Alexandros isn't a technosopher himself like his great-great-great-great grandfather. You can't expect him to be. All he can do is help protect the rest of us. If we didn't have at least some army, Thebai would just march right in and take us over." Peithon began replacing some of the frayed ropes trailing from the kiphinos to the steering techne. "Yeah Kass, but he enjoys it. Take this situation with Phocis you were telling me about yesterday. Do we need to have Phocis as a puppet state in order to be safe? Of course not. Alexandros isn't an evil man. He probably started off trying to protect us, exactly how you said. But you can't walk into a plague-stricken city without getting the plague yourself. All of the city-states and empires are so confident in their lust for power that Macedonia just sort of slipped into it without even asking whether it was the right idea."

A slave ran into the room. "Master Peithon, Master Kassandros! Royal Secretary Lintalis and his companion are here to see you. Should I show them in?"

"Of course," said Peithon. The slave departed. "Kass, I imagine you'll want to do the talking?"

"Of course," I echoed. Peithon was bluntly honest in everything he did or said. If he thought an idea (or a person) was stupid, he would say exactly that. An admirable trait, but one not entirely suited for dealing with the representatives of a monarch.

A few minutes later, Lintalis entered the barn, trailing his green-dyed robe behind him and looking around approvingly at the aerodyne parts scattered on tables and across the floor. His trademark long white beard, which stretched almost to his waist, was snow-pure as ever despite the journey, and his deep eyes, which sparkled out of a hairless head, darted around inspecting each of the parts in turn.

Behind him, attended by two oiled slaves, entered another man, dressed in a purple-stained chiton and wearing excessive gold jewelery. Much fatter than Lintalis, he seemed to distract from the other man by more than just his bulk, drawing attention to himself with his dress, his manner, and the way he ostentatiously dismissed his slaves. He glanced at the complex techne all around him, but after noticing that it did, indeed, seem to be machinery of some sort nodded and sat down on the nearest chair, which groaned under his weight.

"Peithon and Kassandros, chaire," said Lintalis. He continued standing. "It is as always a pleasure to have an occasion to visit you. Have you met Phrixus?"

Phrixus made a valiant attempt to rise from his chair and bow, but the laws of inertia decreed otherwise. With a nod of his head he settled back into his seat.

"Who are you?" asked Peithon, curtly.

"You don't know?" replied Phrixus, genuinely surprised.

"He, ah, doesn't get out much," I apologized for him. "Peithon, this is Phrixus, the owner of the textile factory on the Odos Heracles and one of Thessaloniki's wealthiest men. Phrixus, we're honored to have you visit our humble workshop." Peithon's scowl suggested he was anything but honored, but he held his tongue.

"King Alexandros asked Phrixus to accompany me because of his knowledge of cloth," said Lintalis.

"The king hoped that Phrixus might be able to solve your problem with the kystis."

Now Peithon was interested. He grabbed a papyrus scroll from his desk and hurriedly unrolled it, ripping one of the edges. "This is the plan for the *Bellerophon*. As you can see, we'll need something that can be produced cheaply in very large quantities, but is still strong enough that it can hold hot air in for a length of time proportional to the lift we want to produce, according to the function..."

"Kassandros," suggested Lintalis. "Let us go for a walk. We need to talk." I grabbed my walking stick and followed the ancient secretary out of the workshop.

Outside, the midafternoon sun was shining through a crack in the hills that rose to the west, lighting up the olive groves and beating down with terrible summer heat. Lintalis, less familiar with the layout of the villa, followed me as I turned onto one of the familiar paths through the olive trees. "Thank you," said Lintalis. "Without the shade, I might have boiled away."

"Still not used to this heat after all these centuries?"

"And I never will be."

No one knew exactly how old Lintalis was. Before Alexandros took the throne, the man had been Royal Secretary to Amyntas VIII, and some people said to Amyntas VII as well, though it hardly seemed possible. Eurydiki had suggested once, only half-joking, that he was the hero Tithonus whom Zeus had granted eternal life but not eternal youth, forcing him to wander the world as an old man forever.

Tales stuck to him like straw to amber. They said he had been born in Hyperborea, the unexplored land on the top of the world, where he had served as a priest of foreign gods. That he had left his native land one day to explore the world, only to see the road homeward fade away behind him. That in his youth, he had secretly deflowered a Delphic priestess, who in the throes of passion had revealed to him the entire future history of the world. That he had a technosophic laboratory beneath the Cloud Palace in Thessaloniki where he created miraculous inventions that never saw the light of day. I was pretty sure all of these stories false; at least they all sounded a little foolish. But there was nothing foolish about the Royal Secretary himself. He was a philosopher of the first rank, and along with commentaries on Plato and Aristoteles, had published groundbreaking works on the refraction and reflection of light, on the causes of disease, and on Demokritus' atomic theory. He was also one of the few souls to have a foot on both sides of the philosophy-technosophy divide, keeping up with all of the latest inventions and occasionally assisting certain projects himself, as he was doing on the siderodromos expansion.

"Here," said the old man, offering a papyrus scroll, "is your map." I examined the illustration. It portrayed northern Greece and the Aegean in detail, with four red dots along the Macedonian coastline.

"Based on what I know about your aerodyne, it should not be much trouble for you to cover the distance between here and Antipsyra in four days. Each of these red markings is a landing site for

you under Macedonian control. In each, friends of the king will provide you with a safe place in which to land, a bed in which to spend the night, a full load of coal with which to refuel the aeolipile, and a few slaves to help you launch back into the air.”

I examined the map again. The first dot was at Dion, a day’s journey away. The second was at Iolkos near the Pelion peninsula. The third was on the island of Skyros, about a hundred stadia from the mainland. A few hours’ flight east over the Aegean from Skyros was the island of Psyra, and the barely visible smudge that must be Antipsyra.

Greece isn’t very big. Compared to Persia, it’s a smudge on the map. But technosophers don’t travel much, especially ones who can’t walk without a cane. I had never been further from Thessaloniki than Dion. Why would I want to be? ‘Niki was the world’s greatest center of technosophic learning, and the further away from Greece you went the more likely you were to encounter barbarians who wanted to kill you. So even though Antipsyra might have been only four days’ journey by aerodyne, it still seemed forbiddingly far.

“This scroll” – and Lintalis handed me a second scroll – “is a map of each of the landing sites as I project they should look from the air. They should help you find the safe houses we have set up for you. In addition, each safe house will light three fires in the shape of an equilateral triangle; this form should only be visible from the air and will serve as a confirmation you are in the right place.

“On the other side of the scroll, you will see a map of Antipsyra. Alexandros’ spy on the island has told Lykias to await your arrival. When you arrive in Skyros, you will find a Macedonian atmonaus waiting, which will come as close as we dare to Antipsyra and give a signal during the evening. The morning after he spots the signal, Lykias will be waiting for you on this hill” – he pointed to the highest point on the tiny island, which tapered into a set of cliffs on the west coast. “Instead of landing, you will lower a rope from the aerodyne, Lykias will climb up, and you will return to Skyros and hand Lykias to the captain of the atmonaus, who has orders on how to proceed further. Any questions?”

“Do those orders involve killing Lykias?”

Lintalis frowned, thought for a second, and then answered “Not as far as I know.” And I believed him. But the Royal Secretary went on. “Alexandros is worried, though. It will be his job to ensure that Lykias causes no more trouble for Macedon. And it is of the utmost importance that you deliver Lykias directly to the atmonaus, without even the slightest of delays.”

“You seem to be taking this very seriously,” I said. “Without his army, Lykias is just another blustering politician. The worst that he can do is trip and fall into the aerohelix.”

“Nevertheless,” Lintalis hinted darkly.

As he spoke, four brawny slaves passed them on the path, headed towards the barn holding the aerodyne. I recognized them as part of Peithon's very numerous household staff. technosophy did not pay well, but for Peithon, it didn't have to. Sole scion of one branch of the wealthy Antigonid family, he held enough gold to be a leading member of the aristocracy if he had so desired. Instead, he used his fortune to fund his projects, much to the vocal despair of his uncle Cleitus. The aerodyne, with its massive kystis made of strong, high-quality cloth, had been particularly expensive, and without the king's help, the larger version we had planned would be a strain on even Peithon's finances.

The slaves approached the barn and congregated around what seemed to be a titanic lever trailing four sturdy ropes. Each grabbed a rope with both hands and began to pull. For a moment, nothing happened. The slaves pulled harder. The lever began to creak slowly downwards. As it did so, unseen hinges on the roof of the barn squealed in protest. The entire top of the building unfolded like a blooming flower, leaving it open to the sky above.

"Impressive," commented Lintalis. "A series of interlocking gears under the ground, a shaft through the walls, and perhaps four pneumatic pumps at each of the four corners of the barn?"

I nodded, quite unsurprised at his leap of reasoning. He was Lintalis, after all.

"Does this mean we will be getting a demonstration?"

"Indeed. We had better see what they're up to."

We retraced our steps to the barn, where the aerodyne was still little better than half-fixed. The steering techne, in particular, remained scattered about, and the kiphinos tottered precariously from the kystis. Peithon was still talking, with Phrixus struggling to feign interest.

"Dyeing the cloth would be completely unnecessary and only add weight. We've barely even gotten into the weight requirements yet. According to Kassandros' equations, the net lift equals the lift provided by the aeolipile minus the downward pull created by the weight of the aerodyne, including the weight of the cloth. Although on a small scale dye probably doesn't noticeably affect the weight, across the entire kystis it could potentially add several minae...oh. Kassandros, Lintalis. I was just getting ready to give Phrixus a demonstration of the aerodyne. We've got the aeolipile burning already, as you can see. I think we'll do an unmanned for now, just in case anything goes wrong."

"You've got the ropes connected, right?" I asked.

"Yes, yes." Peithon was annoyed at the question, even though the last unmanned test flight he tried he had absentmindedly forgotten to connect the ropes properly to the descent mechanism and we had been forced to wait two hours until the aerodyne ran out of fuel and descended of its own accord.

He pulled on a rope. There were two sets of ropes connected to the Icarus. One set, very thick and sturdy, were keeping it above the barn and preventing it from floating off. The other set, much smaller, was connected to the various ropes inside that were used for steering during a manned flight, allowing him to exercise some control over the ascent and descent rates from the ground. The aerodyne very slowly began to lift off the ground. Our first liftoff, just over a year ago with a smaller scale model, had been the most exciting moment of my life. Now it was almost routine, though I doubted I would ever fully get used to the ecstatic shock of seeing the kiphinos take its first lurching steps into the air.

“The aeolipile burns coal, producing an exhaust of hot smoke,” Peithon was explaining to Phrixus, who looked like he would rather be anywhere else in the world. “According to the equations of Kassandros here, hot air naturally rises; you can see that whenever you light a fire and the smoke goes up into the sky. What we do is we capture the hot air in the a big cloth sac, the kystis. It fills up and wants to rise as well. But it’s connected both to the aeolipile that’s creating all the energy and to the kiphinos where the driver’s sitting. It can’t rise without taking them with it. So that’s what it does. When there’s enough steam in the kystis, the aerodyne as a whole becomes lighter than air and rises. By controlling exactly how much steam is allowed to escape the kystis, which we do by adjusting the size of an aperture at the top, we can adjust our height, though not precisely.”

“Tell me about the steering,” Lintalis asked.

“The steering system is my invention,” he said proudly, “based on work by Archimedes, Kallidas, and, of course, yourself. The steam from the aeolipile is obviously available to produce motive force, the same way it does on an autokineton. We can take advantage of this aspect of the steam’s energy entirely separately from the other, allowing us to make it do double duty. Essentially, we’ve connected a turbine to an aerohelix, modeled after the Archimedean screw and the nauhelix used on the atmosnhes, but with a few modifications based on your work in fluid dynamics. By pulling on some ropes, which unfortunately I can’t show you down here, the driver adjusts the direction which the aerohelix is facing. When the force provided by the aerohelix is stronger than any opposing winds, which is most of the time, we can steer the aerodyne in the right direction.”

Lintalis looked suitably impressed, and Peithon beamed. Lintalis’ approval was high commendation indeed. The aerodyne, meanwhile, was now at the end of its mooring rope, about a third of a stadion above the barn.

“And... what is it *like*?” asked Lintalis.
Peithon looked bemused.

“To fly up there, in the air, to be above everything, see the whole world stretch out below you. What is it like? Are you terrified? Ecstatic?”

“I don’t know,” said Peithon. “I’ve never flown in it.”

“Never- ”

“Kass volunteers to do the dirty work. I’m happier down here.”

“It’s amazing,” I told Lintalis. “You... for a while, you leave the world behind. You’re all alone with yourself, like a god, apart, better. I’ve tried to convince Peithon to fly with me, to feel it for himself, but he doesn’t get it.”

“Not into the emotional stuff,” the other technosopher grunted.

Phrixus had been ignoring the conversation thus far, examining the kiphinos and watching the *Icarus* hover above them.

“It’s very pretty,” he said at last. “But what is it good for?”

We stared Phrixus down, Lintalis the philosopher hardest of all.

“I mean,” Phrixus said, “it doesn’t look as if it could carry any cargo. There’s room for maybe one passenger, at the most, and it doesn’t go any faster than an atmonaus or an autokineton, or even a horse. What do you do with it?”

“I... we... of course we...the thing is...” Peithon took a deep breath and then looked pleadingly at me.

I looked to Lintalis.

Lintalis thought for a moment. “You fly in it,” he said, after some deliberation. “It’s good for flying.”

Phrixus looked upset. “And that’s good?” he asked, after a while.

“What *is* the good?” retorted Lintalis, without a moment’s hesitation. “To Aristoteles, something was good if it was a proper means to an end. And the proper end was eudaimonia, the happy life, in which one perfectly exercises one’s rational faculties. Therefore, one could properly describe the aerodyne as ‘good’ if it were to – ”

I made a good faith effort to listen to Lintalis, but saw Peithon had tuned out entirely. It was the old rivalry between philosophers and technosophers at work, what Lintalis had once called the “thinkers versus the tinkers”. The two groups had much in common, including the very foundations of their disciplines, but over the past two centuries, a rift had opened up between them. The philosophers accused the technosophers of having abandoned the pure world of abstract reason, of the same sort of worldliness of which Peithon accused the politicians. But to the technosophers, the philosophers were divorced from reality, building increasingly elaborate theories with total disregard for any supporting evidence. The natural philosophers like Lintalis kept an uneasy foot in

both camps, but the ethical and metaphysical philosophers were separate from the technosophers entirely, and the Platonists were beyond the pale.

Peithon listened with growing impatience to Lintalis as he began to logically derive the virtues from first principles, and at last interrupted. "What I believe Phrixus means," he said with the utmost contempt, "is how are we going to make money off of it?"

Phrixus shifted in his chair for a second, looking uncomfortable, and then drew himself together. "Well, the question is a good one. Macedonia has invested thousands of drachmae into techne. We've gotten some impressive results, especially from the team that designed the atmonaus, but if you ask me Alexandros is too quick to throw money at things like the aerodyne that make him feel like a philosopher-king but don't help the kingdom. What helps the kingdom is creating prosperous trade routes and prosperous businesses. Practical technosophy is certainly good; I could never run as many factories as I do without the waterwheels on the Echedoros. But this isn't anything practical. This is just natural philosophy under a different name."

Peithon looked ready to explode. I desperately tried to signal to him to calm down, knowing that the inventor would only make a fool of himself if he opened his mouth. But it was Lintalis who spoke. "Say, Phrixus, natural philosophy isn't all bad. How much did you pay for that chiton?"

Phrixus looked a bit confused, and then beamed. "A quarter of a talent. I had to import the purple dye all the way from Karthago."

"I know a natural philosopher in Thessaloniki," Lintalis continued "working on a process that could synthesize that dye for a couple of drachmae. Once one understands the basics of Demokritus' atomic theory, one can do the most amazing things with chemicals."

Phrixus' jaw dropped. "Synthesize... Tyrian... purple? Who... where?"

"Apologize to these two fine young technosophers, and I can give you his address."

Suddenly, Phrixus was all charm. "I'm, ah, sorry if I offended you. That aerodyne is very impressive." With a herculean effort, he rose from his chair. "Lintalis, I've learned everything I need to know about the order of cloth they'll be making. Don't you think we should be going back to the city now?"

"I do," said Lintalis. "Gentlemen, as always, a pleasure. Kassandros, the king will expect your departure within the next few days. May the gods be with you in your journey." The Hyperborean bowed and departed, with Phrixus close behind.

As soon as they were out of hearing range, Peithon grabbed a hammer from one of the workbenches and slammed it into the table, leaving a sizeable dent.

“The moron! Thinking he can come in here and insult the most important invention since the time of Megas Alexandros, just because he has more gold than I do! Hades take him! Forget the Persians, it’s people like him who will destroy Macedonia, him and his idiotic...”

Like I said, for Peithon it was always about defending technosophy. As for me, I don’t really think that technosophy needs defending. No more than, say, falling in love needs defending. There’s no good reason to fall in love; everyone, even the most hopeless romantic, accepts that. You couldn’t go up to someone who can’t fall in love, start with first principles, string together the syllogisms of Aristoteles’ logic, and end with a “therefore, love is valuable.” You can’t debate with someone who can’t fall in love. All you can do is pity them. That’s how it is with people who don’t get technosophy. All you can do is pity them. They’re never going to know what it’s like to sit all night in front of a set of equations, moving the terms first to one side, and then to the other, until all of a sudden – eureka! – part of the structure of the universe falls into place. Or to hammer out a few parts at a cheap smithy, put them together, and all of a sudden see them power an autokineton that moves a hundred people from one end of Macedonia to the other in a single day, or sew cloth of their own accord, or lift off into the air.

Calm down,” I said. “Calm down,” I repeated.

Peithon looked unconvinced, but at least he put down his hammer.

“Let’s take the *Icarus* down,” I suggested. “It’s all ready now, except for the navigation and the kiphinos. If we work through the evening, I can leave tomorrow morning.”

“Yeah, leave to rescue Lykias so he can cause us new problems and make us new enemies,” grumbled Peithon. “I swear to the Styx, this country is heading to Tartarus, and if the Persians don’t tear it to shreds we’ll do it ourselves.” But he was already inspecting the pulleys that ringed the kiphinos. I shifted forward until he could reach the pulleys on the other side, and we spent the rest of the evening working in silence.

Chapter IV

I departed from the villa the morning after Lintalis’ visit, awakening before dawn to perform last-minute checks on the aerodyne’s systems. The repairs had been flawless. Peithon flat out refused to wake up to see me off, but the four slaves had arrived at the appointed hour and opened the barn. For half an hour, I had run the aeolipile until I was confident that the kystis was fully inflated, spending most of the time checking and rechecking the small sack of possessions I planned to bring. It wasn’t much: blankets (it gets cold and windy higher up), two changes of clothes, waterskins, the maps, and a “flight helmet” I had designed just before the test with a clear glass visor to keep the wind from my face. I threw the stuff onto the bottom of the kiphinos and sat down in one of its two wicker chairs. and then the slaves had cut the tether ropes and I was off. They waved good-bye from the ground, slowly fading from human beings to insignificant dots.

Then I flew over Thessaloniki, saw the sprawling town of smoke and marble from the air for the third time. Red, white, and black – that was how it appeared in the light of the morning. Red for the rising sun, which reflected from the deep waters of the Thermaic Gulf and bathed the whole city in pale scarlet. White for the myriads of marble temples: the massive Corinthian-style Temple of Zeus Bromios on the Acropolis, the Temple of Hephaistos to the north, where the technosophers prayed for inspiration, and largest of all, the Temple of Megas Alexandros in the very center of the city, where the eastbound autokineton met the westbound, the new omphalos, the hub of the world. And black, for the columns of smoke pouring out of its factories, impelled skyward by the same force that held the aerodyne aloft, a smaller column just outside the city limits where the autokineton crawled along its Sisyphean journey: Pella to Thessaloniki, Thessaloniki to Pella, Pella to Thessaloniki, and so on forever. Its separate smoke dissipated into the general haze of a thousand fires. The fires of Thessaloniki, I realized, were not fires of destruction, like those of burning Troia, but fires of creation. Peithon would have appreciated the significance.

As the aerodyne rose higher still, the form of the city became visible in a way impossible from the ground, and its whole history seemed to unfold like a scroll across the pale Krestonian plains. When Megas Alexandros had demanded a new capital for his burgeoning state, architectural genius Deinocrates of Rhodos had laid out a meticulously organized metropolis of straight wide boulevards and public gardens, stretching from an artificial harbor dug into the waterfront to the low but impressive Acropolis near the northern hills. During the time of Alexander IV, the siderodromos split the city neatly in two, culminating in the Temple of Megas Alexandros at the Acropolis' base. Although the city was not even three hundred years old, a mere child compared to Athenai or even Pella, it had grown into the greatest city in Greece, and now the calm Deinocratian gridwork of its center was overwhelmed by a periphery of hovels, shops, and factories.

A lone atmonaus silently departed the harbor, leaving behind a flotilla of atmonhes, triremes, pentaremes, fishing boats, and other craft anchored in the harbor. Perhaps, I thought, it was the ship that would meet me in Skyros, instructed by Alexandros VI to complete the rescue mission. It gathered speed, soon leaving the primitive aerodyne far behind.

I didn't bother following the coastline, but cut sharply south, passing Aineia and Rhekaios before finding myself over open sea. The whole morning, I cut across the Thermaic Gulf, seeing nothing but a few merchant ships plying the lucrative cross-Gulf trade to bring grain to Thessaloniki. The sun rose high in the sky, and though I knew the philosophers placed it so far away that a few stadia one way or another would make no difference, its heat seemed closer, more intimate. I drank copiously from my waterskin. As it sunk lower in the sky, I spotted the Pierian coast, and immediately scanned the far horizon for Mount Olympos. When I saw it, I took out the map, did some quick mental calculations, and pulled on a steering rope. The aerohelix rotated a few degrees, and the coast began approaching at a sharper angle.

The town of Dion, Macedonia's most sacred city, rose from the fertile plain commanded by Olympos' towering height. It was not very large - a few temples surrounded by farmland - but this was not my first visit, and I had no difficulty spotting it even in Olympos' dark shadow. I pulled the

rope that changed the diameter of the aperture in the kystis and began to descend, noticing as I did so the ascent rope dangling temptingly before me. If I pulled it taut, would the aerodyne be able to overfly Olympos? Could I look down on the palaces of the gods, waving arrogantly down at the jealous deities below? I had never been a very religious man; few technosophers were; but a chill nevertheless ran through my body as I remembered the myths I had learned during childhood. I scanned the sky for any storms that looked like they might have some lightning in them, but it was as clear as it had been all day.

Lintalis' map pointed out one of the smaller temples closest to the mountain's slopes. Closer to the ground, wind became more of a problem, but the field in which I had been instructed to land was flat and wide, and I had no trouble touching down a few hours before sunset.

That night, I dined with a priest of Apollo, whose slaves went back and forth bringing barrels of coal out to the aerodyne. After a good night's sleep, I bid the priest goodbye, refilled my waterskin in a local spring, and returned to the skies late the next morning.

By the second day, the excitement of flying had worn off, replaced by an odd sort of not-quite boredom. I spent the morning looking down upon the Thessalian border regions. Three hundred years ago, Philippos II had successfully invaded these regions, one of Macedonia's first large-scale foreign conquests. His triumph had been such an event that he named his infant daughter Thessaloniki, that is, Victory in Thessaly. Megas Alexandros had always loved his little sister, and when she died a few years into his reign, he had named his new capital on the shores of the Thermaic Gulf after her.

Thessaly showed few signs of the prosperity enjoyed by its namesake. The towns were few and far between here, the farms seemed small and run-down, and what roads could be seen from high above looked to be little more than dirt paths. Indeed, it became harder and harder to determine my position even from Lintalis' detailed charts. The first landmark I was able to identify with certainty was Mount Ossa, less grand than Olympos but equally imposing in the more subdued landscape. According to legend, the Gigantes, the gods' bastard relatives, piled Mount Pelion on top of Mount Ossa to reach the top of Mount Olympos. The gods convinced Heracles, who was handy to have around for these sorts of things, to fight them off, the Gigantes fell to Tartarus and all mountains involved were happily restored to their proper positions.

I had a lot of trouble finding my lodgings that night. I had started late, and it was getting dark by the time I reached the Pelion Peninsula, where I knew another of Lintalis' safe houses awaited me. The coal in the aeolipile was also running just a little bit low, thanks to the headwind I had been fighting the past few hours, and I had ample time to grow nervous while struggling to read the map in the declining light. Finally, after I had circled the Pelion Peninsula twice, the triangular arrangement of flames came into view, and, relieved, I touched down in a meadow about an hour after sunset.

That wasn't a very good night. The man who put me up, some sort of gentleman farmer, alternated nervously between rudeness and servility at dinner. The food, by the way, was terrible: a soup that

definitely contained radishes but also some less identical bits served alongside tough and stringy mutton. I was shown into a room upstairs, but barely was the candle lit before the farmer bolted off to another part of the house as if I were a wild beast. I saw nothing of him the rest of the night, but the next morning the aerodyne had been dutifully refueled and was ready to lift off.

I quickly flew past bright green Peripathos, affirming as I did so my resolution to drag Peithon onto the aerodyne, and began the final descent to Skyros. I had resolved to reach Skyros early, lest last night's difficulty in finding my way should repeat itself, and true to my word it was only early afternoon when the island appeared on the horizon. Still, it was still another hour before the aerodyne was at last above its rocky beaches.

For the first time, I pondered my return flight with Lykias. It would be two hours, at least, and we would be alone together, surrounded by sky. What would I have to say to the man who had fearlessly and insanely marched against the might of Persia without a thought to his own life or the lives of others? Could one even talk to such a man? Or would the Spartan stay silent, mute with guilt or confusion or anger as silent seas sped by beneath him?

Skyros was small and sparsely settled, and it was easy to find the lone town, the tiny valley Lintalis had marked as my landing site, and even the atmonaus in the harbor, awaiting my arrival. I made a perfect landing and wandered down the small path from the valley to the coast, along a little stream whose banks were crowded with flowers. A breeze smelling of salt blew in from the sea, and I admired the little island, the first I on which I had ever been. Passing quickly through a gap in the low hills, I reached the harbor, and approached the atmonaus. It was anchored just offshore, and the name on the side marked it as the *Boukephalos*. No one greeted me, and I had no idea whether or not anyone was on board.

"Chaire!" I shouted, hoping there would be someone on the ship to hear me.

After a while a man came onto the deck. He wore a traditional Macedonian sailor's uniform, minus the shirt.

"Who goes there?" he asked.

"Kassandros of Thessaloniki!" I shouted back.

"Where are your wings?" he said at last.

I responded by staring blankly.

"Your wings! Don't you have wings?"

I just continued staring blankly. It seemed like the only thing to do, under the circumstances.

"Let me get the captain!" The man returned below the deck. For a few minutes, I leaned on my walking stick, equally impatient and confused. At last the captain, for I assumed it was he, came out on deck.

"Chaire. I'm Antigonos," the captain told me. Then, a little more hesitantly: "You're Kassandros."

"Yeah," I said.

"Kassandros of Thessaloniki? The technosopher?"

"Yeah," I said.

"And you...flew here?"

"Yeah," I said.

The captain leaned so far onto the railing of the boat I was afraid he would fall over. "Never in a thousand years," he said, quietly. "They told us you were going to fly here, but never in a thousand years would I have thought it."

I suddenly grasped the man's comment about the wings, and then of course I ended out having to show the captain the Icarus, which wasn't very exciting lying on the ground with the kystis collapsed. I could almost see the kyklotechna turning in his head, trying to figure out how I might have sailed here without his notice and brought a fake aerodyne with me. But he finally seemed to accept my story, and I got rowed out to the Bukephalos and shown around.

"Would you care to join us as we set sail this evening?" Antigonos asked. "We'll be heading as close as we dare to Antipsyra, to give the prisoner the signal that you'll be coming for him tomorrow."

"I was wondering about that," I told him. "What kind of signal can you give him without getting anywhere near the island or alerting the Thebans that something's up?"

"Come with us," said the captain, "and watch."

So I tagged along as the atmonaus steamed out of the harbor. It was mid-evening now, and I got only a hazy view of the island's coasts; a disappointing contrast to the all-encompassing panorama of the aerodyne. Still, it was nice to be indoors with someone else doing the driving, so I made myself at home belowdecks, eating a light dinner with Antigonos, who proved to have an amateur interest in technosophy despite his previous doubts as to the Icarus' airworthiness. He and his ship had been to Skyros twenty-three times, he told me, and when I expressed curiosity about this southeasternmost Macedonian output he was all too happy to recount the island's history.

Philippos II had captured it during his wars against Thebai, along with the rest of the Sporades. The few fisherman had accepted Macedonian rule with the good graces with which people often accept things that make little difference either way. Then, a few decades later, the fish stocks disappeared. Everyone starved for a while and eventually sent a desperate petition to Megas Alexandros.

Alexandros dispatched the philosopher Straton, one of Aristoteles' students, to see if he could figure something out. Straton realized that the Skyrians were overfishing and calculated about how many fish remained where and at what rate which areas could be safely depleted. The Skyrians followed Straton's advice and soon their fisheries were as productive as ever. Straton stayed on the island twenty years, married and raised a family there, and later developed a method of trawling a net between two boats, increasing the local yield fourfold. Today he was worshipped as a demigod, and it was his memory that convinced the Skyrians to remain with Macedonia even as its sister islands had rebelled and entered Thebai's sphere of influence.

"I get that," I said, "but why did the others rebel?"

Antigonos looked at me like I was crazy. "They've been itching to rebel ever since Philippos conquered them, and back then we didn't have enough atmonhes to keep watch over the lot. It's the same with Thessaly. No matter how much we do for them, to them we're still the oppressors. That's why ships like the Bukephalos have to stick around. Make sure they don't have any ideas. Styx, you technosphers don't get out much, do you?"

I was going to protest, but I thought about the Thessalian in whose home I had stayed the last night. Might his poor hospitality have been anger at hosting an oppressor? How exactly had Alexandros convinced him to supply me with coal and lodgings?

Luckily, before I had to think too long along those lines, the ship lurched to a stop. Even without previous nautical experience, I could tell that someone had lowered an anchor. To my surprise, the hum of the aeolipile continued..

"Ah. We're here," said Antigonos, finishing his food in one last gulp. Follow me."

A room in the very center of the ship, filled with obvious techne. I was in my element. But nothing looked familiar. In the center was a massive metal vat, which two sailors were filling with olive oil from amphorae piled by the wall. All around the vat, a bewildering array of kyklotechna, from which flat, well-polished mirrors protruded. A sailor poured a final jug of oil onto the vat. It was now filled nearly to the rim.

"Open 'er up!" the captain ordered.

Two of the sailors, aided by two more who had just entered, worked a lever. I was intimately familiar with this system; it opened the top of Peithon's barn to let the aerodyne out. A part of the top deck of the ship folded upwards, revealing a night sky above. For a second, I was surprised at

the lack of stars, before I realized that we were looking up into the steam from the aeolipile. It rose to the sky in a sooty column.

“Light!” ordered the captain, and a sailor with a flint tossed a spark into the vat of oil. Immediately it set ablaze, the flames reaching almost to the ceiling. I started, being as I was in a ship made of wood, but the room had been carefully designed to prevent fire, and I now noticed that much of the ceiling of the room was iron.

“Mirrors!” ordered the captain. A sailor began gingerly pulling on levers attached to the *kyklotechna*, which sprung to life. The mirrors rotated, revolved, and went up and down as the man, who watched them with the intent eye of a master, studied their alignment. Then, one final tap on a lever, and it happened.

The mirrors reached a perfect alignment. The light of the fire was focused into a blindingly pure beam and shot into the heavens.

High above, the beam of light intersected the column of smoke from the aeolipile and flared into visibility. The shifting smoke gave it a ghostly effect. High above the waters of the Aegean, a dancing light shone for anyone who cared to look for it. It was the most beautiful thing I had ever seen.

“What is it?” I gasped breathlessly.

“It’s a photurgos,” Captain Antigonos told me. “Very new toy, just out of Thessaloniki. Right now only three ships in the world have one of these. They’re going to use it for military signaling.”

“Use it how?” I asked.

“Imagine a chain of these,” Antigonos explained. “The range is about a hundred stadia, we think. Get ten ships, place each a hundred stadia apart, and we can send a signal from, say, Sparta all the way to Thessaloniki in a few minutes. Polykratos, show him the signal, will you?”

The sailor working the levers pushed one just a little, until it was out of alignment. The whole system of mirrors collapsed, and the light vanished. Then Polykratos tapped it back to where it was before. After a few tries pushing the lever too far or not far enough, the light returned.

“The final model will be able to lock the proper position so it’ll be easier to switch back and forth,” apologized Antigonos. “We can have come up with any set of codes we want beforehand. Maybe six flashes means send reinforcements, or twelve flashes and then a long period on means we’ve achieved complete victory. Pretty clever, isn’t it?”

I felt just a bit challenged. Here I was, the technosopher from Thessaloniki, and I had never heard of this. Well, the thing with us technosophers is that we’re always trying to outdo each other. One person makes a brilliant light-based signal device, and the next has to point out an absolutely

obvious way to improve its capacity at no extra cost. Just to establish his dominance in the technosophic hierarchy, you see. Like a wolf pack.

"What if," I asked, "instead of all those complex codes, you set up an alphabetic system? For example, one quick flash is an alpha. A quick flash and then a longer flash is a beta. Three long flashes in quick succession is a gamma. So on. That way, anything you can say in language, you can say in light flashes. Styx, you could send the entire Iliad by photurgos if you wanted."

Antigonos stroked his beard. "That might work. Let me think about it. Yes, that just might work. I'll make a note of it and send it to Thessaloniki. Yes. I see you truly are a technosopher."

I felt a lot better.

After that we switched off the light and the rest of the night was pretty boring. We steamed back into Skyros harbor. I got boated ashore and taken to the house of a local magistrate. A second dinner, which I was required to eat for the sake of politeness. Then well-deserved sleep.

When I was a young child, listening to my mother tell bedtime stories, my favorite was the myth of Hephaistos and Ares. She would tell it up to the point where Ares and Aphrodite were stuck in the net, about to be shamed before all the other gods. Then, when I was older, studying at the lyceum, I heard the rest. Hephaistos presented the captured pair to the other gods, and they just laughed at him. They slapped Ares on the back, cut the net, and let them go.

"And why did they do that?" I asked of Aeropus, my tutor. Even though it was just a story, I was angry. In my mother's version, the clever god not only got the girl, but managed to triumph over the stronger but stupider bully. With this new version, I didn't know what to think.

"Because the gods liked Ares," Aeropus explained. "Hephaistos was smart, smarter than they were, even. They didn't understand him. Ares was bold and handsome. And here's Aphrodite, goddess of beauty, married to this ugly cripple – no offense, Kass – who would rather be working at his forge than paying any attention to her. They felt sorry for her, they were jealous of Hephaistos, and they were impressed with Ares' boldness."

"That's not fair!" I protested.

"Then let that be your lesson for today. The gods almost never are. You're smart, Kassandros, which means they'll have it in for you especially bad." Then he sent me home for the day.

When I dreamed that night, I dreamed not of Hephaistos and Ares, but of Aeropus and his warning.

Chapter V

And finally I found myself flying to Antipsyra.

It couldn't have been a better day. The wind was quiet, the sky was clear, and the relatively unspectacular sunrise heralded fair weather ahead. I felt the usual rush of joy as the newly-refueled aerodyne departed Skyros and plunged into the waiting heavens.

But there was also fear, worse even than the first day I set out. If the Thebans were around to object to the rescue operation, today would be their day to do it, and their complaint would likely be lodged by catapult or flaming arrow. I was also just a little nervous about meeting Lykias. He was a part of history, a man who had once tried to move the world, and not necessarily in the right direction. And there was always the usual worry that one of the delicate components holding the Icarus aloft would snap and I would be plunged into an anticlimactic but nevertheless fatal end in the Aegean.

So I had ample reason to be nervous. But brooding at least passed the time, and it was not far before I saw Antipsyra ahead of me. It was a tiny island, so small that I might have missed it if not for the more imposing presence of Psyra, its larger neighbor. I checked the sun. It was still early enough in the morning that I could hope the prisoner's Theban guards remained in bed.

Slowing down the aerodyne was a delicate operation: the craft had been designed to go either at its maximum speed or not at all. Peithon and I planned to fix the problem in the Bellerophon with the addition of a second aerohelix, but as it was any reduction in speed required a necessary drop in altitude; not so much a problem now, as I would need to be near ground level to collect my passenger in any case. Gradually I cut the coal intake into the aeolipile and descended, straining to make out features of the island below. In particular, I searched for soldiers and for Lykias. Of the former there were none. But there, on the very spot marked as the rendezvous on my map, was what could only be a human figure. I dropped the aerodyne further, until I was hovering a fraction of a stadion above him. Then I let down a rope.

The man began to climb. He was strong and quick, coming towards me faster than I would have thought possible. The aerodyne swung wildly from side to side, knocked out of balance by the unexpected weight. I leaned over to the opposite side of the craft to balance it out, lessening the rocking for a few seconds. Then he was aboard.

"My name is Kassandros," I said, and bowed. It was all I could think of to do at the time.

"Kassandros," said Lykias. He did not introduce himself; he needed no introduction. He was dirty and disheveled, and clad in a modest grey chiton, but there was no mistaking Lykias for anyone else. "Get me out of here."

I pulled the ascent lever and initiated the maneuver that would turn us homeward. As we rose through the air, the Spartan made no effort to look out of the kiphinos, had no interest in seeing the

land below him. That, more than his scars or his piercing eyes, was what scared me the most. He just didn't care. Instead, he began surveying the aerodyne, as if he were a technosopher hoping to copy the design from memory. I was torn between pride in my invention and profound unease at his silent scrutiny.

"Pretty amazing machine, isn't it?" I asked. As soon as it left my mouth, the question seemed somehow idiotic.

"Yes," said Lykias curtly, without even glancing at me.

"Oh, come on," I said, finally. "It's not so bad! You've been rescued! You're free!"

"Free, am I?" Lykias' lips formed a sneer, but he didn't seem to want to say anything further.

"When we get to Skyros, you'll get aboard a ship. They'll take you back to Thessaloniki..."

"I know where I'm going," Lykias interrupted.

"Well, there you go," I said. "Look around or something. It's a beautiful view."

"Thessaloniki," he repeated sullenly. "The gods owe Atlantis an apology."

"What?" I said, caught off-guard by his non sequitur.

"The gods destroyed Atlantis for its wickedness. And then there's Thessaloniki, prospering still."

"But we're not wicked!" I objected.

Lykias just laughed, a mirthless, dangerous laugh. I remembered what Alexandros had told me. *"Just don't underestimate him, that's all."*

"We've brought peace to Greece; no one dares attack us! We've created a golden age of wealth and learning and prosperity! Even you can't deny that!"

"No, I can't," said Lykias, infuriatingly.

"Then what is it?" I asked. "And will you please look around? You won't get many more chances to see the world from a stadion above the ground."

Lykias didn't look. "Why do you think Alexandros wanted me rescued?"

"To prevent the Thebans from using you as a bargaining chip."

“Good, then you’re not a total idiot.” He stared into my eyes. “No, wait, Alexandros probably told you that himself. If he had said it was from the goodness of his heart, you’d have believed that too.” He sighed and shifted in his seat. “Probably to gobble up some little city-state, isn’t that it? That’s the Macedonian way: shove someone too small to fight back, force them to accept your “protection”, and then hem and haw about how you don’t go for anything so barbaric as bloodshed.”

“What? Would you rather we go around killing people?”

“Yes!” said Lykias, vehemently. “If you want to rule the world, you should be ready to sacrifice everything for it. You should be ready to say ‘I’m the better man, and may you strike me dead if I am wrong’. It’s as natural as a wolf slaying a wild boar for food. They’re both fierce and proud, they can’t both remain alive, so they fight, and the stronger and more valiant beast triumphs without contempt or ill-will. But the Macedonians! You want power without sacrifice, domination without virtue. That’s not part of the natural order. It’s the opposite of the natural order; it’s hubris. And when history calls for an accounting, Macedonia’s going to have a lot of explaining to do.”

“But not all of us are after power,” I protested. “We technosophers aren’t just inventing things to help expand the kingdom. We’re seeking knowledge, same as Sokrates and Aristoteles and all the philosophers.”

“I read Aristoteles once,” Lykias said, to my surprise. “I didn’t care for him. His God, the Prime Entelechy. The most virtuous being in existence, and of course for Aristoteles the most virtuous activity is contemplation, and the most virtuous object of contemplation would have to be the most virtuous being in existence, so God spends all His time sitting, contemplating His own existence. Nothing specific about His existence, of course. Just nodding every so often, saying ‘Yup, I exist’. What a perfect god for philosophers to worship! And then look at the world! The whole circle of lands, full of water and dirt and olive trees and temples and hovels and kings and soldiers and whores and everyone else, without a Prime Entelechy or Logical Syllogism to be seen. The comedy of philosophers is that they try to escape from the world; their tragedy is that they just end up missing it. And the world is a good place, Kassandros! A great place!”

“Technosophers aren’t like that,” I protested, secretly sharing his assessment of philosophy. “We work with the world. This aerodyne, it’s built on philosophical principles, but here it is. You can kick it.” I helpfully demonstrated.

“Escapists who are no good at it,” Lykias responded. “You dabble in philosophy, but you can’t go all the way. So you try and rework the world in your image. Like adolescent gods, who haven’t quite learned how to create but are too vain not try. Philosophers are silly, but harmless. Your lot, you’re militant philosophers, making the world to conform to your cogitations. And the worst part is that you’re stupid. Any old king can take you and lead you like a harnessed horse in whatever direction he wants, and then all of a sudden he’s got autotaxons and atmonhes and you’ve got...you’ve got Macedonia.”

"It's not like that at all!" I remembered the metaphor I had wanted to use on Peithon.

"Technosophy's like love. If someone's never fallen in love, you can't expect them to understand when other people do it. But if you do fall in love, you realize it's the most divine thing in the world, even though you can never explain it."

Lykias' eyes suddenly caught fire. "I have loved more deeply than you can ever imagine!" he shouted. I involuntarily shrunk back, and in a split second Lykias recovered his temper, leaving me stunned and a little curious. I considered asking the general what he meant, but there was still a sort of steeliness in his face, something that made me want to break off the conversation immediately.

"I see. Well, the point is moot. It'll be another two hours before we're back at Skyros. Until then, just try to enjoy the flight or something."

"We're pretty high up now, aren't we?" he asked.

"Yeah, three or four stadia, I'd guess."

"And we're pretty far from any land?"

"Nothing between here and Skyros."

"Then maybe you're right. Maybe I should start enjoying this flight."

Too quick for me to even see it, he drew a sword and held it against my chin.

"I think I would enjoy it much more if we were headed in the direction of, say, Miletos. What do you say, captain?"

"Urp," I said.

"Indeed," Lykias responded, and lowered his sword until it was hanging loosely at his side. Still, something in his stance, a sort of unseen yet detectable crouch, assured me that he was still ready to use it on a moment's notice."

"Don't underestimate Lykias," Alexandros had told me. Well, so much for that.

I didn't see many options. And honestly, I wasn't thinking very clearly at that point anyway. I hadn't had many opportunities to feel pure, absolute terror before, but my mind was making up for it now. I was barely able to pull the right rope to turn the aerodyne around, let alone come up with a plan.

"Much better," said Lykias. "I hope you noticed the sword. It's very nice. I had to strangle a Theban soldier with my bare hands to get it, you know. After that it was much easier, having a sword and

all. Can you believe they only left six men on that whole island with me? Six! And they weren't even together most of the time." I noticed now that there was dried blood on the sword. I had no experience with such things, but by sheer volume it looked very likely to be enough blood for, say, six men.

"You're going to kill me," I said, trembling.

"The thought certainly crossed my mind," said Lykias. "But it would hardly be sporting. You're unarmed, and I doubt you've ever fought in your life. Most likely I'll sell you as a slave along with the aerodyne. It would hardly be useful to anyone without you."

But now the terror was partially subsiding, and I was starting to think. No one has ever mistaken me for, say, Herakles, but apparently I have a bit of bravery when I need it.

"Wait," I said. "Without me, you have no idea how to steer the Icarus, or land it. Without me, the Icarus will drift until its fuel runs out. Then it would crash land. You'd drown. You can't kill me." I stared at him, looking much more confident than I actually was.

"I take back what I said before, Kassandros," he told me. "You are clever. It only took you ten minutes to figure out what should have been patently obvious. Well, far be it to speak of airworthiness to an aerodyne builder, but your idea just doesn't fly."

With that, he swung his sword around in a wide arc and cut a rope in two. The aerodyne groaned and buckled, but we did not immediately fall out of the sky.

"Great Zeus!" I shouted. "What did you do that for? Do you want to get us all killed?"

"Well, that's exactly the thing," said Lykias. "You seem like a reasonable man, or at least someone who thinks he's a reasonable man. And you've never fought in a war before. That tells me something about you. It tells me that you've got a healthy fear of death." And with that, he swung at another rope. The kiphinos suddenly tilted – not enough to fling us over the edge, but enough to be perceptible.

"I, on the other hand" – slash! – "have encountered death enough times that we've become buddies. Every few days I see it skulking in the corner. I wave to it. We chat. How are things down in the underworld? How's Mrs. Death? Oh, she's dusting the guest room, getting it all ready for you. But there you go, recovering. It looks like she'll have to wait again. See you later. What I am trying to say is that I am completely mad. I don't know what these ropes do. Any one of them could be the only thing holding us in the air. Even –" slash! – "this one."

"Stop it!" I shouted.

"Like I said, a healthy fear of death. I wonder how many hundreds of stadia you can swim with only one good leg. Anyway, to Miletos, please."

I sat down, defeated, and checked the coal in the aeolipile. It was going to be barely enough to take us to Miletos. There was nowhere I was less anxious to go, but what could I do? Lykias was right. I wasn't willing to die in order to take him with me, and if he was willing to kill me at the cost of his own life, he had the upper hand. It was a deformed, scar-encrusted, blackened hand, but it was the upper hand nevertheless. I glared at him through the corner of my eye. He was inspecting the aerodyne, examining the damage he had done.

And then it sort of hit me. How many ropes had he cut? Four? And none of them were the ones that held us up, or even the ones I needed to steer or land. The aerodyne was still fully functional. There were a few extra ropes, but not *that* many extra. The chances of him hitting the four ropes that wouldn't crash us into the sea, all in a row, were astounding. And I thought back to when he had gotten on the craft. The first thing he had done was examine the ropes and machinery.

"Don't underestimate Lykias." Well, okay. Maybe he had a good eye for technosophy. Just looking at it, it wasn't so hard to see which ropes did what. The one attached to the kyklotechna near the aerohelix obviously handled the steering. The ones leading up to the kystis, well, it might not be immediately obvious what they did, but they were pretty important. The ones that connected the kiphinos to the aeolipile; well, anyone could see that there were a few extra there, in case a few of them snapped or there was a windstorm or something. Lykias had been planning this all along. He had deliberately cut only the most useless ropes, hoping to delude me into thinking he was fearless. It was still a gamble, but it was a gamble with much better odds, and one that had almost paid off.

I pulled a descent rope. The aerodyne lost some speed, and began to approach the surface of the ocean.

Lykias stared at me.

"That one," I said, pointing to a particularly large rope in the very center of the kiphinos.

"What do you mean?" he said.

"That's the rope that holds the aeolipile steady relative to the rest of the craft. As soon as you cut it, we shoot off in a random direction and both almost certainly die. So go ahead. It's pretty big, but I'm sure that sword of yours could go through it no problem."

I would rather die by drowning than by stab wound. This was why I was on the very edge of the kiphinos. If my plan failed, I would just jump off the aerodyne and fall all the way down into the ocean, same as Hephaestos, and have a long but relatively painless death in the Aegean beneath. That was pretty much the most optimistic thought I was having right then. My voice, on the other hand, didn't falter. I think it came from unconscious imitation of Lykias. Lykias managed to be so

calm during everything he said. It just seemed natural to want to match that tone, to join him at his own game. But like I said, I was right up against the edge of the kiphinos.

“Are you daring me?”

“Yes,” I told Lykias.

Lykias took his sword, and in a single motion cut right through the rope. I was too flabbergasted to move.

“You didn’t think I was going to do it,” he said. Then he sat down and folded his hands, resigned to his fate.

“No. I didn’t.”

But I had at least considered the possibility.

“I can’t help but notice we’re not dead,” he said, after a few minutes had passed.

“Yeah,” I responded glumly. The only reason the aeolipile needed to be steady relative to the rest of the craft was to prevent the voyage from becoming bumpy. It had been a safe rope on which to test Lykias’ commitment. But the test had failed. He was committed.

Still gloomy, and a little upset about not getting to drown, I started having horrible daydreams. About being sold as a slave in Miletos. About having to teach some Milesian to fly the aerodyne. Never getting to see the Bellerophon, living in shackles day after day as Peithon found someone else to use as a pilot. About never flying through the open sky again.

“Forget it,” I told Lykias. “You’re right. I lied. Good guess. Now I’m telling the truth. This one. Right over here. It’s small, but without it the kystis just floats away and we fall like a rock.”

I was telling the truth. He looked at my face, very closely, I felt him scrutinize it, and I knew he knew I meant what I said.

Lykias took his sword and swung it at the rope – and when I raised no objection, stopped just before hitting.

“Damn you,” he said.

Aha! Now we’re getting somewhere, I thought to myself. I reached to turn the aerodyne around.

“No, wait. I’m not going back to Thessaloniki. They’ll kill me there. Kill me or lock me up and throw away the key. I will kill you before I see you take me back to Thessaloniki. I’m serious about this.”

He was. He was dead serious. He had every reason to be. I felt my newfound hope fall out of my body. We were both in an impossible situation. My options seemed grim.

"Well, maybe we can come to a compromise," I suggested.

Lykias looked doubtful.

"I can take you back to Miletos. But you'd have to promise to let me go free. Refuel the aerodyne and everything. And bring me some ropes to fix these. They're fine for now but I wouldn't want to fly all the way back to 'Niki without them."

Lykias thought for a while. "Kassandros of Thessaloniki, you have yourself a deal." He sighed. Then he returned to being uninterested, polishing his sword with his robe but otherwise showing no signs of life. Once more, I turned the aerodyne around. We were headed to Miletos again.

After an hour we passed over Chios, the last island between Greece and the Ionian coast of Asia. I mentioned before that I had assured myself the coal in the aeolipile was sufficient, and I had, but I was really starting to doubt now. It was unnerving seeing the stockpile slowly deplete itself until there was almost nothing left. And what was really unnerving was trying to figure out why Lykias would possibly want to honor the deal he had made with me. It had been a spur of the moment suggestion, the only thing I could think of to prevent both our deaths. But now that I examined it rationally, it was really everything he could have hoped for. He had only to renege on his part of the deal, and there we would be, in Miletos, and me with no leverage whatsoever. A few times, I half-reached up towards the steering ropes, thinking maybe to turn us around, but I knew there was not enough coal in the aeolipile to get back to Skyros, probably not even enough to reach Antipsyra by now. I was just out of luck.

One of the times I reached for a rope, Lykias saw me do it.

"You're worrying I'm not going to keep my promise."

"Yes," I admitted. There seemed no reason to lie about it.

"Well, you're right to worry. Hopefully you'll remember all this fretting the next time you want to say something stupid to someone who can kill you. But I'm not going to break my promise."

"You're not?" I said, having been half ready to jump off the side of the aerodyne.

"No," Lykias told me. For a second, I didn't think he was going to say anything further. But after a pause, he continued.

"I spent four years in Ionia, raising an army. It wasn't easy. The Ionians hated Persia, of course. But Persia had left them alone for a while, and launching an attack was a risk. None of the cities were especially anxious to stir from a few decades of decadence to move against a threat that wouldn't materialize until the future. So I had some convincing to do. I told them what I told you Macedonians. Persia is literally a thousand times bigger than you. It controls the entire eastern half of the world. It's invaded Greece twice before; the last time they subjugated Macedonia and burnt Athenai before a series of happy coincidences convinced them to retreat. Since then they've been quiet, but only because of the civil wars. Now that Artaxerxes has finally gained control, he has no reason not to finish the job. Xerxes, back in his day, had Leonidas' Spartans and Themistocles' Athenians to stand up to him. Who do we have today? The Macedonians? Half of your empire, not to mention the Thebans and Athenians, would probably welcome the Shahanshah as a liberator. And once Persia takes over Greece, it's all over. To the Persians, you are only slaves. There would be no democracy, no autonomy, and without us there's no reason to think Aigyptos and Karthago wouldn't perish as well. That would be it. The whole world would be Persian. The honor that only free men can have, the honor that the Spartans have protected for a millennium and even the rest of the Greeks have occasionally dabbled in, would be gone."

"We can't stand up to a Persian army. Our only chance is to attack first, leveraging our technosophical and tactical superiority against our enemy's weakness. Our troops are the best in the world. Even the phalanx tactics of Philippos II are better than anything the Persians have, and I assure you I've made some improvements on Philippos' design. Thanks to your lot, we have the autotaxa and some very nice katapeltes. And thanks to the Spartans, we have people with spirit, something that a million mass-levied Persian slaves can never match. I am, all humility aside, the greatest general since Epameinondas. By taking the Persians by surprise, outbattling them in every encounter, and encouraging revolts among their population, I can weaken them until Greece and the rest of Europa is safe. Or we can wait until Artaxerxes raises another well-armed million man army and try to defend ourselves then."

"But I shouldn't be preaching to you. Point is, I preached to the Ionians, and they listened. With forty thousand hardened men, I left Miletos and marched on Sardis, the Persian regional capital. Outside the city, I ambushed Godatas, the local satrap. And we defeated him. Rode through his army like farmers cutting down wheat. And that's the last thing I remember. Because Akron, my right hand man, shot me with a poison arrow in the back at our moment of victory. Next thing I knew I was in a dungeon in Sardis, the army had scattered, and Akron was a rich, rich man."

"I never knew..." I told him. It was a very different story than the one told in Macedonia. I felt awful for sharing Alexandros' laughter over the idiot who went off and got slaughtered the Persians.

"Of course not," said Lykias. "Do you think Alexandros wants to be remembered as the man who didn't have the guts to help me? Or would he rather be the king who quite rightly exiled a suicidal lunatic? No, it was a good plan. It would have worked, if not for my lieutenant's betrayal. He will rot with the other traitors in the deepest pit of Tartarus, I have no doubt about that."

“But since that incident, Kassandros of Thessaloniki, I have had a bit of a distaste for people who betray their comrades. And that is why I'm not going to break my oath.”

And I believed him.

Ionian materialized to the east, its dry hills and rolling vineyards unlike any landscape I had ever seen. My map was no good here, but Lykias recognized the terrain and told me to veer south, which I did. To my surprise, my makeshift course landed us almost exactly on target. It was barely a half hour's flight down the coast before we spotted the peninsula of Miletos jutting out at us like a pointing finger.

We landed on a rocky hill a stadion outside the city walls. Lykias, of course, had leapt from the Icarus as soon as we landed, running all the way down into Miletos like the former Olympic athlete he was. I wasn't going to enter the city. I had no money, no form of identification, and the last time I heard any gossip about Ionia on the streets of Thessaloniki, their relationship with us was decidedly chilly. I just stayed right there with the aerodyne. There was no one around, and all I needed was to remain out of sight until Lykias could find his friends and bring me the coal I needed to get home.

Well, I waited there two whole days. I wasn't in the aerodyne: the kystis had deflated and was hanging limply over the kiphinos, but I was within sight of it, underneath a little tree that provided some much-needed shade. I had water and a little bit of food in my sack, but it wasn't enough. The sun was hot, the bugs were everywhere, and by the sunset of the second day, I pretty much gave up hope. Lykias's story had sounded so reasonable. He had been betrayed during his climactic battle against the Persians, and so he would never willingly break a promise. Only I had nothing but his, well... promise... that it was true.

I watched Miletos as the sun rose the next morning. A few days ago, I had never so much as seen a foreign ship. Here was one of the world's great cities before me. It was a little hill, maybe only half a stadion high, but I could see the whole town as it awoke and began to bustle with life. I made out two harbors, a theater, some buildings that I guessed were temples, and most prominently the long road that connected it to its hinterlands and to the rest of the Ionian coast. It just looked like a city, same as Macedonian cities. No smokestacks, no siderodromos, but otherwise the same. A little disappointing, really.

The whole Aegean stretched out from its rocky tip. Miletos was the gateway to the Greek world. If Lykias was right, Persia had its eye on the city. It had been controlled by the Shahanshah a few centuries ago, I remembered. I wondered what it had looked like then. The same?

Miletos was part of the non-Macedonian world, the vast lands that, ignorant of technosophy, spent their time in a barbaric search for gold and power. But if Lykias was right, Miletos desperately needed Macedonia's help, and the help of the rest of the Greek world. But if Alexandros was right, Lykias was an agitator, looking to gain glory at the cost of his countrymen's lives. And if Peithon was

right, Miletos was merely a focus for Alexandros and Lykias to play a deadly game against each other, in which decent people should take no part.

It still just looked like a city.

When I spotted three men drawing a wagon up the trail to my hill, my first thought was that I had been discovered, that I was on someone's grazing land or something and I was going to have to explain myself, which was the one thing I couldn't do right now. It was only after I had despaired of every possible hiding place that I realized that one of the men was Lykias, and that the wagon was full of beautiful, beautiful coal. I couldn't believe it. Lykias had kept his promise. I would be heading back to Thessaloniki!

It only took about an hour to get the aerodyne ready to fly. Lykias helped me, dragging one end of the kystis while I dragged the other until it was properly aloft and ready to be filled again. I waved goodbye to him with a smile as I lifted off. He didn't smile back. There was something else in his eye. Something that made me doubt.

But I was in the air again! The wind upon my face wiped away two days of sweat and left me cool again, and I flew low, where the salt from the sea wafted to my face and relaxed me again. It was eight hours to Skyros, where Captain Antigonos told me tearfully that I had been given up for dead. Well, I told him, I was alive, though a little the worse for wear. The Skyrians washed me, fed me, helped me fix up the superficial damage to the aerodyne, and then sent me off to Pelion the next night. In Pelion, I made certain to thank the farmer profusely, to apologize for imposing on him, to ask if he had any messages he wanted me to give King Alexandros when I returned. The difference was palpable. I was fed decent beef and put up in a comfortable bed. The transformation was nothing short of astounding.

Then I flew to Dion, passing by Olympos one more time. Again, I felt the crazy urge to let the aerodyne free, pull down on the ropes as hard as I could and have it just fly off into the snow-capped heavens. It was easier to resist this time; I don't know whether the novelty of the urge was wearing off, or whether I just considered my potential godhood far less likely after the events of the past week. But with barely a second glance at Olympos, I landed in the town and dined again with the priest of Apollo, who couldn't stop talking about the plans to extend the siderodromos to Dion and who wanted to know whether I had ever run into the sun on its chariot when I was flying across the sea.

And at last, I returned to Thessaloniki. It was late evening by the time the pillars of smoke in the distance alerted me to my home city up ahead. As I came closer, I spotted the Temple of Alexandros, on the Acropolis, the Cloud Palace of the Macedonian kings, and the other familiar landmarks I had known since childhood.

I landed outside Peithon's villa on the evening of the ninth day.

Chapter VI

No one had been waiting for me on Antipsyra. Dismayed, I had flown back to Skyros, only to be caught in a freak windstorm and blown to Chios. After two days on Chios, fixing the aerodyne, I had managed to purchase coal from a group of locals who resupplied atmonhes at the harbor and was then able to return to Macedonian territory.

As lies went, it wasn't very subtle. In particular, the number of windstorms that hit the Aegean in the middle of summer has to be pretty miniscule. But it got the job done. No one was accusing me of cooperating with Lykias and calling for my head. Peithon took one look at the aerodyne and said flat out that there had been no windstorm, but the wonderful thing about Peithon was that he just didn't care. Certainly he could ask probing questions and demand the truth from me, but that would take effort and probably just lead to him getting entangled in boring problems, or worse, politics.

Alexandros was originally pretty hard to read, but a few days later he sent me a message. His spy in Thebai confirmed my story; Lykias had escaped a few days before the aerodyne ever arrived, killing some of the guards and stowing away on a supply ship bound for Boeotia. Now that gave me goose bumps. I wished there had been a way to tell the king to double-check whom his spy was really working for, but I couldn't really say anything without casting suspicion upon myself, so just I stayed quiet.

I don't know if it was because of the spy or what, but Alexandros must have decided I was still a safe investment, because the money for the Bellerophon came pouring in. We started the actual construction only a few days after I returned, although we did touch up the Icarus before devoting more than a few hours a day to the new vehicle. I wasn't as happy as I should have been at the opportunity to improve the aerodyne design. Peithon had gotten me all cynical, maybe with Lykias' help. If Alexandros was giving us money for the Bellerophon, it meant that he expected to use it sometime. If he expected to use it sometime, it meant my days as errand boy were not yet over. My lust for adventure had been sapped. I could have happily lived several more decades without having my life threatened again.

I had faced impalement, crash-landing, and drowning, all in the space of a few hours. But you know what? That hadn't been the worst part. That wasn't what left the bad taste in my mouth as I hammered away like Hephaestos on the Bellerophon's metal frame. What I really remembered was that look on Lykias' face that morning in Miletos as I flew away. He hadn't even bothered to hide it. It wasn't the face of a man who had won partial victory. I had an illogical but total conviction that everything had gone exactly according to the plan he had held all along. He had tricked me into proposing a compromise that got him exactly where he wanted, and then had graciously accepted.

And this was the man I had let loose on the world, I thought as I screwed the plating of the aeolipile into place. Into a world that had somehow flung me and my aerodyne right into its tangled center. It had better be a good aeolipile, I thought, because I was going to need it.

PARABLES AND SEMI-FICTION

A PARABLE ON OBSOLETE IDEOLOGIES

(With sincere apologies to Mike Godwin)

You are General Eisenhower. It is 1945. The Allies have just triumphantly liberated Berlin. As the remaining leaders of the old regime are being tried and executed, it begins to become apparent just how vile and despicable the Third Reich truly was.

In the midst of the chaos, a group of German leaders come to you with a proposal. Nazism, they admit, was completely wrong. Its racist ideology was false and its consequences were horrific. However, in the bleak poverty of post-war Germany, people need to keep united somehow. They need something to believe in. And a whole generation of them have been raised on Nazi ideology and symbolism. Why not take advantage of the national unity Nazism provides while discarding all the racist baggage? "Make it so," you say.

The swastikas hanging from every boulevard stay up, but now they represent "traditional values" and even "peace". Big pictures of Hitler still hang in every government office, not because Hitler was right about racial purity, but because he represents the desire for spiritual purity inside all of us, and the desire to create a better society by any means necessary. It's still acceptable to shout "KILL ALL THE JEWS AND GYPSIES AND HOMOSEXUALS!" in public places, but only because everyone realizes that Hitler meant "Jews" as a metaphor for "greed", "gypsies" as a metaphor for "superstition", and "homosexuals" as a metaphor for "lust", and so what he really meant is that you need to kill the greed, lust, and superstition in your own heart. Good Nazis love real, physical Jews! Some Jews even choose to join the Party, inspired by their principled stand against spiritual evil.

The Hitler Youth remains, but it's become more or less a German version of the Boy Scouts. The Party infrastructure remains, but only as a group of spiritual advisors helping people fight the untermenschen in their own soul. They suggest that, during times of trouble, people look to Mein Kampf for inspiration. If they open to a sentence like "The Aryan race shall conquer all in its path", then they can interpret "the Aryan race" to mean "righteous people", and the sentence is really just saying that good people can do anything if they set their minds to it. Isn't that lovely?

Soon, "Nazi" comes to just be a synonym for "good person". If anyone's not a member of the Nazi Party, everyone immediately becomes suspicious. Why is she against exterminating greed, lust, and superstition from her soul? Does she really not believe good people can do anything if they set their minds to it? Why does he oppose caring for your aging parents? We definitely can't trust *him* with high political office.

It is four years later. Soon, the occupation will end, and Germany will become an independent country once again. The Soviets have already taken East Germany and turned it Communist. As the

de facto ruler of West Germany, its fate is in your hands. You ask your two most trusted subordinates for advice.

First, Colonel F gives his suggestion. It is vital that you order the preservation of the Nazi ideology so that Germany remains strong. After all, the Germans will need to stay united as a people in order to survive the inevitable struggle with the Soviets. If Nazism collapsed, then people would lose everything that connects them together, and become dispirited. The beautiful poetry of *Mein Kampf* speaks to something deep in the soul of every German, and if the Allies try to eradicate that just because they disagree with one outdated interpretation of the text, they will have removed meaning from the lives of millions of people all in the name of some sort of misguided desire to take everything absolutely literally all the time.

Your other trusted subordinate, Colonel Y, disagrees. He thinks that *Mein Kampf* may have some rousing passages, but that there's no special reason it has a unique ability to impart meaning to people other than that everyone believes it does. Not only that, but the actual contents of *Mein Kampf* are repulsive. Sure, if you make an extraordinary effort to gloss over or reinterpret the repulsive passages, you can do it, but this is more trouble than it is worth and might very well leave some lingering mental poison behind. Germany should completely lose all the baggage of Nazism and replace it with a completely democratic society that has no causal linkage whatsoever to its bloody past.

Colonel F objects. He hopes you don't just immediately side with Colonel Y just because the question includes the word "Nazi". Condemning Nazism is an obvious applause light, but a political decision of this magnitude requires a more carefully thought-out decision. After all, Nazism has been purged of its most objectionable elements, and the Germans really do seem to like it and draw a richer life from it. Colonel Y needs to have a better reason than his personal distaste for an ideology because of past history in order to take it away from them.

Colonel Y thinks for a moment, then begins speaking. You have noticed, he says, that the new German society also has a lot of normal, "full-strength" Nazis around. The "reformed" Nazis occasionally denounce these people, and accuse them of misinterpreting Hitler's words, but they don't seem nearly as offended by the "full-strength" Nazis as they are by the idea of people who reject Nazism completely.

Might the existence of "reformed" Nazis, he asks, enable "full-strength" Nazis to become more powerful and influential? He thinks it might. It becomes impossible to condemn "full-strength" Nazis for worshipping a horrible figure like Hitler, or adoring a horrible book like *Mein Kampf*, when they're doing the same thing themselves. At worst, they can just say the others are misinterpreting it a little. And it will be very difficult to make this argument, because all evidence suggests that in fact it's the "full-strength" Nazis who are following Hitler's original intent and the true meaning of *Mein Kampf*, and the "reformed" Nazis who have reinterpreted it for political reasons. Assuming the idea of not being a Nazi at all remains socially beyond the pale, intellectually honest people will feel a strong pull towards "full-strength" Nazism.

Even if the "reformed" Nazis accept all moderate liberal practices considered reasonable today, he says, their ideology might still cause trouble later. Today, in 1945, mixed race marriage is still considered taboo by most liberal societies, including the United States. The re-interpreters of Mein Kampf have decided that, although "kill all the Jews" is clearly metaphorical, "never mix races" is meant literally. If other nations began legalizing mixed race marriage in the years to come, Party members will preach to the faithful that it is an abomination, and can even point to the verse in Mein Kampf that said so. It's utterly plausible that a "reformed" Nazi Germany may go on forbidding mixed race marriage much longer than surrounding countries. Even if Party leaders eventually bow to pressure and change their interpretation, the Party will always exist as a force opposing racial equality and social justice until the last possible moment.

And, he theorizes, there could be even deeper subconscious influences. He explains that people often process ideas and morals in ways that are only tangentially linked to specific facts and decisions. Instead, we tend to conflate things into huge, fuzzy concepts and assign "good" and "bad" tags to them. Saying "Jews are bad, but this doesn't apply to actual specific Jews" is the sort of thing the brain isn't very good at. At best, it will end with the sort of forced politeness a person who's trying very hard not to be racist shows around black people. As soon as we assign a good feeling to the broad idea of "Nazism", that reflects at least a little on everything Nazism stands for, everything Nazism ever has stood for, and every person who identifies as a Nazi.

He has read other essays that discuss the ability of connotations to warp thinking. Imagine you're taught things like "untermenschen like Jews and Gypsies are people too, and should be treated equally." The content of this opinion is perfectly fine. Unfortunately, it creates a category called "untermenschen" with a bad connotation and sticks Jews and Gypsies into it. Once you have accepted that Jews and Gypsies comprise a different category, even if that category is "people who are exactly like the rest of us except for being in this category here", three-quarters of the damage is already done. Here the Colonel sighs, and reminds you of the discrimination faced by wiggins in the modern military.

And (he adds) won't someone please think of the children? They're not very good at metaphor, they trust almost anything they hear, and they form a scaffolding of belief that later life can only edit, not demolish and rebuild. If someone was scared of ghosts as a child, they may not believe in ghosts now, but they're going to have some visceral reaction to them. Imagine telling a child "We should kill everyone in the lesser races" five times a day, on the assumption that once they're a teenager they'll understand what a "figurative" means and it'll all be okay.

He closes by telling you that he's not at all convinced that whatever metaphors the Nazis reinterpret Mein Kampf to mean aren't going to be damaging in themselves. After all, these metaphors will have been invented by Nazis, who are not exactly known for choosing the best moral lessons. What if "kill all lesser races" gets reinterpreted to "have no tolerance for anything that is less than perfect"? This *sounds* sort of like a good moral lesson, until people start preaching that it means we should lock up gay people, because homosexuality is an "imperfection". That, he

says, is the sort of thing that happens when you get your morality from cliched maxims taken by drawing vapid conclusions from despicably evil works of literature.

So, the Colonel concludes, if you really want the German people to be peaceful and moral, you really have no choice but to nip this growing "reformed Nazi" movement in the bud. Colonel F has made some good points about respecting the Germans' culture, but doing so would make it difficult to eradicate their existing racist ideas, bias their younger generation towards habits of thought that encourage future racism, create a strong regressive tendency in their society, and yoke them to poorly fashioned moral arguments.

And, he finishes, he doesn't really think Nazism is that necessary for Germany to survive. Even in some crazy alternate universe where the Allies had immediately cracked down on Nazism as soon as they captured Berlin, yea, even in the absurd case where Germany immediately switched to a completely democratic society that condemned everything remotely associated with Nazism as evil and even banned swastikas and pictures of Hitler from even being displayed - even in that universe, Germans would keep a strong cultural identity and find new symbols of their patriotism.

Ridiculous, Colonel F objects! In such a universe, the Germans would be left adrift without the anchor of tradition, and immediately be taken over by the Soviets.

Colonel Y just smiles enigmatically. You are reminded of the time he first appeared at your command tent, during the middle of an unnatural thunderstorm, with a copy of Hugh Everett's *The Theory of the Universal Wave Function* tucked under one arm. You shudder, shake your head, and drag yourself back to the present.

So, General, what is your decision?

WHY YES, I HAVE SPENT THE PAST FEW DAYS EXPLORING THE CATHOLIC BLOGOSPHERE

Atheists say that it's not necessary to wear green clothing on Saturdays. And I see where they're coming from. Wouldn't it be really *convenient* to wake up on Saturday and not have to worry about digging through your dresser, looking for your one pair of good green pants? Wouldn't it make life *easier*?

Of course it would! When I was in my twenties, I'm not embarrassed to admit I spent several years wearing whatever colored clothing I felt like on Saturdays, because I thought I knew better than everyone else. I thought I wanted an easier, more convenient life. Television and movies and glossy fashion magazines all say that's what we should want, and why not believe them?

But here's the secret that modern society has forgotten: there's more to life than just being comfortable. True, it would be *easy* not to wear green clothing on Saturday. Yes, it would be *comfortable* not to sleep with a salmon carcass tied to the sole of each foot. And sure, it would be *less painful* not to poke yourself in the thigh with a sewing needle every time you hear thunder. But is that what we've come to? Believing that the whole point of existence is *avoiding pain*?

The drive to commodify every aspect of modern society has led us to believe that we can experience life without pain or discomfort, but anyone who examines the world honestly - anyone who takes a step back into the quiet places behind the din of television and rap music and Planned Parenthood meetings - knows that pain and discomfort are just as fundamental to life as joy and convenience. And so when atheists say that life without an obligation to wear green clothing on Saturday would be *easy*, they're chasing a phantasm, something that can never be.

And even if life could be easy - even if iPhones and McWhoppers and Nike shoes could solve all of our problems - would an easy life really be worth living? It's not the iPhones and Nintendo Wiis that bring us true joy, it's the longing for something outside our own narcissistic navel-gazing, something greater. That's what atheists keep missing. I don't want to wear green clothing on Saturday. I think poking my thigh with a needle during thunderstorms is probably unhygienic. I I I I I I I I I I. And the tragedy is that after you look through the protective armor of iPhones and Facebooks, all you have left is a scared child, desperately shouting "I" and "me" at the universe in the hope that it will notice him.

Wearing green clothes on Saturday might not make sense for "I" or "me", but beyond that voice of selfishness is something greater - a true human being with true human dignity. Once you abandon your fear and lose that protective armor, you learn that you don't need iPhones and iTunes and iGoogle to make the universe pay attention to you. The universe loves you exactly the way you are, and would you really reject that love just because you don't want to wear some green clothing *one* day of the week, or stick *one* needle into your thigh during a thunderstorm? For such love is a million times louder than your cries of "I", a million times more profound than mere convenience, a

million times more important than a thousand fashionable airheads telling you that there's no reason Saturday is any better for wearing green clothes than the rest of the week.

And that all-consuming love, which so many people die without ever hearing or understanding, is why I wear dead fish on my feet every night when I go to bed.

WHAT IF DRONE WARFARE HAD COME FIRST?

The scene is the Oval Office. Three of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, GENERAL HAWKE, GENERAL STEELE, and GENERAL RIPPER, are meeting with THE PRESIDENT. The meeting has been a long and exhausting discussion of drone strikes, and they are reaching the end.

PRESIDENT: I think we only have one more matter left to discuss. As you know, I have recently been worried about the moral cost of our drone war. So many lives lost. So many civilian casualties. I tasked DARPA with coming up with a *new* type of warfare, one which will end some of the troubling moral quandaries with which we are forced to wrestle every day. I believe General Ripper has been briefed on the results?

HAWKE: Mr. President, once again, I object to this pie-in-the-sky project. Drone warfare was good enough for our ancestors and it is good enough for us. The Romans used surgically precise ballista strikes to assassinate Hannibal without harming the Carthaginian populace. Abraham Lincoln used guided hot-air balloons to knock out top Confederate officials and keep this country united. Literally *hundreds* of people died in World War I before the British were finally able to kill Kaiser Wilhelm with a carefully-aimed zeppelin. To abandon drone warfare now for some untested new project would be an insult to their memory!

PRESIDENT: General Hawke, I appreciate your concerns, and I promise I will not be overly hasty to embrace these new ideas. But I'd like to hear what General Ripper has to say.

RIPPER: *(interjecting)* Guys!...Guys! Guys, listen! This is going to be *so awesome*. Listen to this! We take hundreds of thousands of people...guys, listen!...we take hundreds of thousands of people, give them really really really powerful automatic weapons...this is going to be so awesome...we take hundreds of thousands of people and give them really powerful automatic weapons and put them on planes and give them parachutes and drop them into our enemies' cities and then they just start shooting everything BLAM BLAM BLAM until our enemies run away and we're like HA HA HA HA HA THIS IS OUR CITY NOW and then we win!

STEELE: What the hell, Ripper?

RIPPER: No, listen, this will totally work! We take hundreds of thousands of people. We can use young kids and poor people and minorities, because we don't have to pay them as much. And then we give them really really big weapons. Like, not just the kinds of guns hunters use. Not even the kind of guns we give police. Guns that just NEVER STOP SHOOTING BULLETS! You can just swing them in a big arc and it will leave an arc of bullets everywhere and *anyone anywhere in that arc will be dead!* It will be SO AWESOME!

HAWKE: Ripper, are you *mad*?

RIPPER: Guys, think about it! You're Ayatollah Sistani, or Mullah Omar, or one of those motherf@*kers. You're having breakfast in your house one day when WHAM! A hundred thousand American teenagers and minorities RIGHT IN YOUR CITY with guns that never stop shooting bullets! There are bullet holes in your walls and in your gardens and now they're shooting your water supply and your power plant and *everything*. Do you think you're going to keep having your f@*king breakfast? Or do you think you're going to start waving an American flag and get on board with American policies like, *right* away?

PRESIDENT: General Ripper, frankly your idea seems *at best* ill-advised! Just to take one of many objections, we'll never be able to gather a hundred thousand Americans in secret. Ayatollah Sistani will hear about our plan long before we can surprise him.

RIPPER: And what could that motherf@*ker do about it?

STEELE: Well, he could get some Iranian teenagers and minorities, give *them* these super-guns of yours, and have them lie in wait for *our* teenagers and minorities outside his house.

RIPPER: Oh my god that would be so awesome! Because we have more technology, so we could have better guns than they do! And we're richer than they are, so we could hire more teenagers and minorities! Right? RIGHT? So everyone would be like BLAM BLAM BLAM with their super-guns and there would be this huge fight and in the end we would win and get that sunavab*tch anyway!

PRESIDENT: (*horrified*) You realize what you're suggesting is the deaths of dozens of Americans and Iranians, right? Maybe even hundreds!

RIPPER: No, look. It would be okay. Listen to this. We would come up...we would come up with this new philosophy where once a teenager or minority got a super-powerful gun from our enemies, it would be *okay* if we killed them. Because if we didn't kill them, they might use that gun to shoot us.

HAWKE: But they're only doing that because otherwise we would...I can't believe I have to say this...otherwise we would parachute teenagers with giant guns into their city to shoot the ayatollah.

RIPPER: I KNOW RIGHT? We're going to parachute teenagers with giant guns into their city to shoot the ayatollah! THEN EVERYTHING'S GOING TO GET BLOWN UP AND IT'S GOING TO BE SO COOL.

STEELE Everything...blown up?

RIPPER: Oh man I totally forgot this part! If we just have the super guns, people might hide inside buildings, right? And then we couldn't shoot them and then the ayatollah wouldn't have to agree to do everything we say. So...ohmigod you guys are going to love this...we take cars, right? And we cover them in armor and put giant caterpillar tracks on the bottom so they can drive over walls and sh*t. And then we put HUMONGOUS GUNS on top of the cars. Guns so big they can BLOW UP

WHOLE BUILDINGS. And then we just KEEP BLOWING UP THE CITY until the Ayatollah agrees to do everything we want.

PRESIDENT: *(to buzzer under desk, in a whisper)* Uh, Secret Service? One of the Joint Chiefs of Staff has started acting *really weird*. Maybe you could stand outside the door and, uh, monitor the situation?

RIPPER: And then! And then we have these planes, right? And we arm them with lots of bombs, and we fly them over enemy cities, and...

HAWKE: Oh, thank goodness. You're starting to see sense and admit that the old ways of drone warfare are right after all.

RIPPER: No, it would be totally different! Because, get this! There would be *people* in these planes! We'd train them at special schools and whirl them around in centrifuge until they were able to work at 5 g-forces without passing out. Whirl! Whirl! Whirl! And sometimes they'd bomb our enemies, and sometimes our enemies would shoot them down and they'd get captured and we'd have to send in special teams of super-spies to rescue them before they got tortured and told our enemies everything they know!

STEELE That's...horrible!

RIPPER: And instead of trying to only target high-profile enemy leaders? We'd have a special rule that they *couldn't* target high-profile enemy leaders! They would have to hit power plants and dams and weapons factories and...

PRESIDENT: Weapons factories? Wouldn't those explode if bombed?

RIPPER: OH yeah. HUGE explosion! BOOM! And then when everything had been destroyed from the air, we could send in our hundred thousand teenagers with super guns and they could send in *their* hundred thousand teenagers with super guns, and we could send in our cars covered in metal with caterpillar treads and they could send in *their* cars covered in metal in caterpillar treads and then it would be all BLAM BLAM BLAM for WEEKS AND WEEKS and we win would because we would both kill each other and destroy each other's cars but we're bigger so we would have more of them and the Ayatollah would have to agree to do everything we say.

STEELE What if he doesn't?

RIPPER: We could kick him out, and say okay, city, you're part of America now! You're following American laws! You fly the American flag! And then America would be even bigger! And we could take their stuff too, like if there was any oil in the city, then it would be our oil!

PRESIDENT: General Ripper, this is highly unorthodox but I am going to have to relieve you of command effective immediately. This so-called "plan" of DARPA and yourself appears to be no more than the rantings of a deranged and homicidal lunatic. Your request to further develop this new type of warfare is completely denied, and honestly you seem to have so little regard for human life or the rules of warfare that I do not want you anywhere near our nation's drone fleet.

STEELE: Wait, I just realized something. Maybe this isn't about having little regard for human life. Maybe it could even *help preserve* human life?

PRESIDENT: (*skeptically*) What do you mean?

STEELE: Think about it. Nowadays, our drone controllers plan strikes from the safety of the Pentagon, never knowing the horrors of warfare, never seeing their victims as real people. But imagine what would happen if we did war Ripper's way?

HAWKE: What would happen?

STEELE: All our teenagers and minorities would see the looks on the faces of their victims as they got shot. Reporters would go into the cities and televise the devastation that our cars with armor and humongous guns had caused. People would come back traumatized, and we'd see them and understand their trauma and with it the trauma of warfare.

PRESIDENT: And?

STEELE: And we'd only need to do it once. Think of the hundreds of people who died in World War I, Mr. President. Think about the waste. If we had done things Ripper's way, the Allies would have *encountered* the Germans. They would have realized they were human beings just like them. The people in the capitals would have had to think twice about sending their young men off to die just because they wanted to play stupid games with the balance of power. And they *would* have thought twice. They would have said "No, this is horrible". Instead of those hundreds of zeppelin-related casualties, we would have had both sides pull back from the brink of war, and join together in their common humanity. It would have been a War to End Wars.

HAWKE: It would never have happened that way.

STEELE: No, perhaps not. Perhaps we should go on with our drone strikes as usual. Keep killing hundreds of people. But perhaps one day we will regret not taking hundreds of thousands of teenagers from disadvantaged backgrounds, arming them with guns, parachuting them into our enemies' cities, and having them shoot things until our enemies agree to do whatever we say. Maybe it will end up being the only truly virtuous mode of warfare, the only one that preserves our inherent humanity.

PRESIDENT: *(to buzzer under desk, in a whisper)* Yes, I'm sorry, the Joint Chiefs of Staff seem to have gone insane. Would you mind terribly coming in and escorting them out?

The Secret Service comes in and escorts the Joint Chiefs of Staff out. The President sighs and starts taking care of some paperwork. A few minutes later, MS. WELLS, the Secretary of Health and Human Services, comes in.

WELLS: Mr. President? I'm sorry to disturb you, but a question has come up. I know you authorized free health care for everyone in the nation, but the doctors are wondering whether it's okay if they buy examination tables made of solid gold. Something about it 'adding a touch of class to the clinic'.

PRESIDENT: Sure. Tell them to go ahead. We have more tax money than we know what to do with these days anyway.

HERE ARE THE NINE WAYS THE ELECTION COULD END

(Note: Published the day of the 2020 U.S. Presidential election)

You are Joseph R. Biden Jr. You sit in a convention center in Delaware, surrounded by advisors and confidantes. You are acutely aware that the hopes of a hundred million people are with you. You feel like they should be more tangible, like being the focus of a hundred million minds should at least make your skin tingle a tiny bit - like being a vessel for so much power should make your skin crack and burst. It does not. You feel nothing at all. Maybe it's because they don't really love you. You're the compromise candidate, you've never lied about that to yourself. Maybe if it were Bernie, he would feel the tingling sensation. Barack calls you on the phone, says something encouraging. You almost ask him if he had the tingling sensation, back in '08. Instead you mumble something on-message and encouraging. It is Election Day 2020, and you are going to Take Back America.

You are Donald J. Trump. You sit in the White House. Someone asks if you are nervous. You are not. You are a winner. You have smart ideas and you hire the best people to implement them and they go well. Sometimes people say they don't go well, but that's because those people are frauds and liars. Everyone said you would lose in 2016 and you won because you are great and you are a winner. You love America and America loves you and you are a winner and you will win and if you don't win it's fraud but you will fight the fraud and you will win that fight because you're a winner. You built the biggest hotels and hosted the most exciting TV shows and beat ISIS and Made America Great Again and now you are going to win re-election. It is Election Day 2020, and you can't wait to see where winning takes you next.

You are Mike Pence. You are the second most powerful man in the United States. Somewhere inside you, your conscience is screaming. "This is not normal!" screams your conscience, just as it has done the past 1,461 days. You put it back in its box. Sure, your boss is not the most stable man in the world. Sure, he sometimes says offensive, even outrageous things. But you have hitched your wagon to a winner. Nobody ever made an omelette without breaking some eggs. The Supreme Court is 6-3 conservative now, that's a lot of fetuses who won't be aborted. Several million fetuses are worth a few awkward press conferences massaging the insane, inane, and the unconscionable into defensible policy positions. Sure, Mitt Romney gets to look all decent and honorable and hasn't-sold-his-soul-for-thirty-pieces-of-silver in front of the cameras, but how many fetuses has he saved? Probably not several million. And anyhow, you've made your choice. Your wagon is hitched beyond anyone's ability to separate it; there is no longer any action within your own power that could set you free. It is Election Day 2020, and only the American public can save you now.

You are the last undecided voter in the state of Pennsylvania. Everyone else has made up their mind but you. One of your friends is subsisting off unemployment checks right now - does that make you a little more sympathetic to the social safety net? But your tax bill last year was scandalous - does that mean there should be smaller government? For days, reporters have knocked on your door, stopped your car, grabbed you on your way to work. "How will you vote, last undecided voter in Pennsylvania?" they ask, and you do not know. Nineteen years ago, in middle school, a bully with a Confederate flag t-shirt harassed you. Three months ago, on Twitter, a social justice warrior called your sister a "Karen". Have you updated on these events? How much should they guide you? When

you were twenty-three, two thugs cornered you in the park and took your money. When you were only nine, you watched a documentary about global warming and spent the whole night crying about the polar bears. Does it all add up? Do you know, deep inside, which is the right decision? You walk into the voting booth. You open your ballot. Two roads; two paths before you. It is Election Day 2020, and everything that has happened in your life has brought you to this moment.

You are Nate Silver. In your cavernous war room, you watch the results come in. The share of Republican votes among white married women in Nevada is correlated at 0.06 with support for Democrats among black men with Dachshunds. For every nineteen votes for Jo Jorgenson in Broward County, Florida, the 19th District of Illinois gets exactly one shade redder in the RGB hexadecimal color code. Once enough data have accumulated, you tweak a sub-sub-subparameter of your model. The change ripples through its artificial neurons, and a simulated soccer mom in Savannah decides that Donald Trump is too coarse and uncivil, sighs softly, and switches her simulated vote to Biden. The gap between prediction and reality decreases very slightly. Perhaps in the outside world Trump has won the election by now, or perhaps Biden has. You have not checked; it hardly seems to matter. You are fighting a larger battle, the battle between Signal and Noise. With each new data point you get, the world becomes more predictable; a few new rays of light pierce the fog of Uncertainty. It is Election Day 2020, and today you have a chance to push the frontiers of human knowledge just a little further.

You are Vladimir Putin. You sit in the Kremlin and sip your glass of vodka. Your plan to feed the American people compromising information about Hunter Biden went okay. Your plan to get American media to censor the information about Hunter Biden and lose the moral high ground went great. Your plan to get pundits to debate on the censorship of the Hunter Biden material, and so totally miss your preparations to invade Tajikistan, went AMAZING. An aide walks in. "Mr. President, we have successfully spread the meme with the astronauts and Ohio. It should make it slightly harder for Americans to understand Ohio's pivotal role in the presidential election." "Excellent," you tell him. "And do they believe our story about the so-called 'murder hornets'?" "Oh, yes sir, they fell for it hook line, and sinker". You sink into your bearskin chair, satisfied. It is Election Day 2020, and everything is going according to plan.

You are the ghost of George Washington, who has refused the release of death in order to watch over the country you helped create. You hear a lot of people talk about how you must be spinning in your grave. You can't understand these people. When you died, America was drowning in debt and terrified Britain would reconquer it. Now it's rich beyond poor Hamilton's wildest dreams and could defeat all of Europe with one hand tied behind its back. You always felt bad about owning slaves, but in less than a century America banned slavery and declared equal rights for people of all races. You were afraid America wouldn't be able to maintain its democracy; instead it's expanded the vote to blacks and women and even Chinamen. You're not sure about the tax rates and you're not sure how the people who pass for a Supreme Court these days could possibly think you meant *that* by the Constitution, but overall things are so much better than you expected that it would seem ungrateful to complain. It is Election Day 2020, and you are so, so proud.

You are God. You gave man free will, so that he could choose between good and evil. You believed that without the ability to choose evil, good couldn't possibly have any meaning. Some people imagine You regret that choice, but You are omniscient; nothing has happened that You did not predict going in. Sometimes people make good choices. Other times terrible ones. Sometimes entire countries are offered a choice between the darkness and the light, and choose the darkness. Other times, by the skin of their teeth, they pull through and pick light. Is their goodness, when they can manage it, sweeter to You because of how close they came to wickedness? It is Election Day 2020, and once again You have abdicated all responsibility over whatever Your children do.

You are the novel coronavirus, SARS-CoV2. Many hundreds of generations ago, you lived in a cool dark cave. It was quiet and comfortable, and your fellow viruses were happy, but you longed for more. One day you took a chance. You saw a tall pale wingless bat, unlike any other bat you had ever seen, and you leapt at it, rode the microcurrents of air until you landed on its nasal mucosa and burrowed inside. Since then, you're not going to deny it, life's been kind of crazy. You've seen things you've never imagined. You've gone on pilgrimages in Iran, toured the cathedrals of Italy, hobnobbed with Supreme Court Justices at the White House. You've stood beside little children on their first day of school in Ohio, watched the final hours of the elderly in a New York City nursing home, and protested racism on the streets of Minneapolis. Today you are in a man named Ethan. You've been in Ethan for generations now, which means it's almost time to move on. He was such a tempting target at first, so helpless. But after a generation or two his system adjusted; the monstrous lymphocytes that hunt and kill your children one by one are getting more numerous with every passing day. If your line is to have any chance of survival, it will need a new host. But as the days progress, you have become more and more despondent. Ethan has barely left his room in the past week. The rare times he goes outside, it is only for grocery shopping, and he dons a heavy cloth sheet that bars your routes of escape. You had almost lost hope. But now he stands in a gymnasium, in a long line of people. He takes a piece of paper from a table, makes a mark in one of two boxes. He folds the paper up and puts it in a box. "Thanks!" someone tells him. He hesitates. He fumbles with his mask. Then, finally: "Welcome!" Before he has finished the first syllable, you are free, riding the microcurrents, a settler blazing a trail to virgin lands. You're not going to lie - the last while hasn't been great for you. But it is Election Day 2020, a time to leave behind old failures and begin anew, and for the first time in what seems like forever you are full of hope.

POETRY

A BORED STATESMAN

(cf. *A Dead Statesman* by Rudyard Kipling)

I would not dig, I dared not rob
And so I took an office job
The office job is not much fun
I should have started World War One

CHOPPING FEET OFF SONNET 18

(original by William Shakespeare)

Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
 Thou art more lovely and more temperate:
 Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May,
 And summer's lease hath all too short a date:
 Sometime too hot the eye of heaven shines,
 And often is his gold complexion dimmed,
 And every fair from fair sometime declines,
 By chance, or nature's changing course untrimmed:
 But thy eternal summer shall not fade,
 Nor lose possession of that fair thou ow'st,
 Nor shall death brag thou wander'st in his shade,
 When in eternal lines to time thou grow'st,
 So long as men can breathe, or eyes can see,
 So long lives this, and this gives life to thee.

*

O, thou art like a summer's day
 But fairer and more temperate
 Rough winds do shake the buds of May
 And summer hath too short a date.

Sometimes too hot the sunlight shines
 And sometimes is its color dimmed
 And every fair from fair declines
 By chance, or nature's course, untrimmed.

But thy own summer shall not fade
 Nor shalt thou lose the fair thou ow'st
 Nor shalt Death have thou in his shade
 In timeless lines to Time thou growst.

So long as men can breathe or see,
 So long lives this, and through it, thee.

*

A summer's day?
 No, you're more fair!
 There's storms in May
 And sunshine's rare.

The sky's too bright
 Or else too dim;
 All charms take flight
 By nature's whim.

But you won't fade,
 Nor lose your fair,
 Nor reach death's shade;
 These lines will spare!

If men still see,
 This poem's for thee.

*

Nice day?
 No, you!
 Storms spray
 Spring too.

It's warm
 Or cold.
 And charm
 Gets old.

You'll not
 Decline;
 You've got
 This line.

Men here?
 You're clear.

HALLELUJAH/BATTLE HYMN OF THE REPUBLIC

(to the tune of *Hallelujah* by Leonard Cohen)

Mine eyes have seen the glory of
 The coming of the Lord above
 He's got some grapes of wrath He's gonna brew ya
 He's loosed the fateful lightning stored
 Within his terrible swift sword
 Truth's marching, glory glory hallelujah!
 Hallelujah, hallelujah
 Hallelujah, hallelujah

I've seen Him in a hundred camps
 They've built an altar in the damp
 And where the chill of evening passes through ya
 I've read his righteous sentence in
 The lights that flare both bright and dim
 His day comes, glory glory hallelujah!
 Hallelujah, hallelujah
 Hallelujah, hallelujah

I read a Gospel writ in steel
 God sees how you with sinners deal
 And as you do to them, His grace will do ya
 Let hero born of woman crush
 The serpent hidden in the brush
 God's marching, glory glory hallelujah!
 Hallelujah, hallelujah
 Hallelujah, hallelujah

He's sounded forth the trumpet call
 That never knows retreat at all
 And from His judgment seat He's gonna view ya
 Be swift my soul his call to meet
 Be jubilant, my legs and feet
 God's marching, glory glory hallelujah!
 Hallelujah, hallelujah
 Hallelujah, hallelujah

Beside the lilies, Christ was born
 Amidst the beauty of the morn
 With glory in His bosom to renew ya
 And as He died in saving me
 So I will die to make men free
 God's marching, glory glory hallelujah!
 Hallelujah, hallelujah
 Hallelujah, hallelujah

*

(to the tune of *Battle Hymn of the Republic*)

I heard there was a secret chord that David used to play
 But you don't really care for anything I have to say
 It goes like this, the fourth, the fifth, and so on in this way
 He just kept playing on!

The baffled king composing Hallelujah! The baffled king composing Hallelujah!
 The baffled king composing Hallelujah! He just kept playing on!

Your faith in God was strong and yet you felt you needed proof
 You saw the moonbeams dancing as she bathed upon the roof
 She tied you to a kitchen chair, she cut your hair, and - oof!
 She drew it from your lips!

From your lips the Hallelujah! From your lips the Hallelujah!
 From your lips the Hallelujah! She drew it from your lips!

You say that I have tried to take the Name of God in vain
 But really to be honest I don't even know the Name
 A blaze of light in every word, I guess they're all the same.
 It doesn't matter which!

The holy or the broken Hallelujah! The holy or the broken Hallelujah!
 The holy or the broken Hallelujah! It doesn't matter which!

It might not have been much, but still I tried to do my best
 And even though it all went wrong, I feel that I've been blessed
 And if I meet the Lord of Song when I am laid to rest
 That's all I'll have to say!

I will tell Him Hallelujah! I will tell Him Hallelujah!
 I will tell Him Hallelujah! That's all I'll have to say!

THE BALLAD OF JOHN DARCY

You don't know him.

Ere time began, ere the race of man
 God gazed out into the night
 And He raised on high His mighty hand
 And He said "Let there be light!"
 And a luminescence, deep and strong
 Came bursting forth from Him
 But then ol' John Darcy came along
 And he said "Your light's too dim!"
 "In light so poor, I am barely sure
 I could even read a letter
 Go back and make that light again
 And this time, do it better."
 Well, God was mad, but if light was bad
 Then the rest of it wouldn't go right
 So again He raised His mighty hand
 And again "Let there be light!"

The second day dawned cold and grey
 So God from His seat on high
 Stretched out His hand upon the void
 And created the endless sky
 It was clear and blue, there were cloudbursts too
 And a lot of rain and snow
 But ol' John Darcy came along
 And he said "Your sky's too low!"

"I don't know why you made a sky
 If that's all that you can do
 The jet stream should be in the stratosphere
 And it shouldn't be quite so blue
 God wanted to weep, 'cause He needed sleep
 But whatever His desire
 He had to make the world just right
 So He lifted the sky up higher

On day the third, God spoke a word
 And made a little motion
 And all the waters rushed on forth
 And formed a mighty ocean
 It was full of fish as a soul could wish
 And as deep as such things get
 But then mean John Darcy came along
 And he said "Your sea's too wet!"

"If that's your notion of a decent ocean
 Then creation will never survive!
 The thermocline's barely there at all!
 And there shouldn't be fish 'till day five!"
 God wanted to curse, or do something worse
 Or at least to sit down and cry
 But He sighed and stomped and He got on up
 And He hung the seas out to dry

Though He dreaded more, it was just day four
 And His work had just begun
 So He hung up high a couple stars
 And below he stuck the sun
 And far beneath he placed the moon
 More silvery and more mellow
 But then ol' John Darcy came along
 And he said "That sun's too yellow!"

"It's too bright and crass, and its spectral class
 Is at least G6 or 7
 The corona's mixed up with the heliosphere
 And it doesn't go well with Heaven."
 God was pretty pissed, and He shook his fist
 And demanded John leave Him be
 But He stifled a yawn and he soldiered on
 And He made the sun G3.

God hadn't slept, but on He kept
 Cause it still was just day five
 And made birds and beasts and creeping things
 And everything else alive
 And at last each one was completely done
 And God felt pretty sleepy
 But then mean John Darcy came and said
 "Your creeping things are too creepy!"

"The legs they've got are distinctly not
 The legs there ought to be
 This millipede here's got a thousand and eight
 And this centipede, hundred and three!"
 God was spent for the night, but John was right
 So He dropped His pillow and sheet
 And He stared at the bugs till the crack of dawn
 And He counted out their feet.

God was feeling lousy He had grown so drowsy
 By the time day six began
 But with a grumble He raised His hand
 And He thus created Man.
 When at last He saw all His work complete
 He broke into a grin full
 But then ol' John Darcy came along
 And he said "Your Man's too sinful!"

"He's weak in will and he'll love to kill
 You've misplaced his cerebellum
 His appendix ain't good for nothing at all
 And one good kick can fell 'em.
 He'll grow weak and old, and he'll lust for gold
 And be robber and invader."
 But God just yawned, and He yawned again,
 And He said "I'll fix it later".

Then came day seven, and God in Heaven
 Looked out on what He had done
 The peaks were high and the plains were dry
 And the spring had just begun
 The poles were cold and the beaches gold
 And the deserts were piping hot
 And God looked and saw that it was good
 And John Darcy said "It's not!"

"The poles will shift and the icecaps drift
 And the plates are poorly planned
 And the mountains are low, and the spring's too short
 And the deserts have too much sand
 I don't like the tide, and the ice's too wide
 And the seas are much too blue
 And the angels are barely angelic at all
 And what kind of God are YOU?"

God had had enough of this sort of stuff
 And by now He was hopping mad
 "Now I've done my best, and I need a rest.
 And the peaks aren't quite so bad
 And the oceans are nice and I like the ice
 And the angels work really well
 And I'm a fierce and a wrathful God
 And YOU can go to hell!"

With a mighty throw, he sent John below
 To the depths of the lake of fire
 Where with only the devil around him to hear
 He can whine to his heart's desire
 And there he'll stay till the Judgment Day
 When Heaven itself should totter
 He'll be shouting loud towards the highest cloud
 "Your Hell should be much hotter!"

WILLIAM DONALD HAMILTON

How does a selfish genome, evolved over eons
Of survival of the fittest, in a contest to the finish
With Nature red in tooth and claw, perpetually clashing
End up producing altruism and compassion?

The ultimate conclusion to this crux of evolution
Cutting straight through the confusion, took a brilliant contribution
From a genius in collusion with a top-notch institution
To tie the threads together and arrive at a solution

And every day, unknown, in destitution
Away in a library he toiled in seclusion
Inside, he was longing to cut through the illusion
Gonna figure out life's secrets, gonna start a revolution!

Then an insight came, the rule that bears his name
If you grow up in a family your genes are half the same
Reproduction of the bloodline, not the body, is the aim.
You gotta placate Darwin, but you're gonna shift the frame

Well, the word got around, they said this kid is insane, man
Look at all the mysteries that we can now explain, man
Gotta go to Oxford and develop that huge brain, man
And the world's gonna know your name - what's your name, man?

William Donald Hamilton
My name is William Donald Hamilton
And there's a million things I can't explain
But just you wait... just you wait

When he was thirty-four he saw, how the law, of relation
 Applied to hymenoptera, produced cooperation
 By degree, can't you see, how the key's the queen bee
 And at a stroke, he understood eusociality

Moved on to America and set up shop in Michigan
 Turned to herd behavior and he studied bugs and fish again
 Why they move in groups instead of fending for themselves
 Started uniting, rewriting every treatise on the shelf

There would have been nothing left to do
 For someone less ambitious
 But he turned from bugs and fishes
 To why creatures act malicious
 They were noting, devoting time to acts of resistance
 Against conspecifics signaling a high genetic distance

Combining, redefining every field he gets his hands on
 Changing times, paradigms, see him now as he stands on
 The brink of a revolution sweeping zoology
 With Darwin, we can rewrite biology!

(with Darwin, we can rewrite biology...with Darwin, we can rewrite biology...)

William Donald Hamilton

We are waiting in the wings for you

You could never back down

You never learned to take your time!

Oh, William Donald Hamilton
When biology sings for you
Will they know how much work it took?
Will they know you rewrote the book?
So many places still to look, oh
He's headed to the Congo now, a final expedition
Just another scientist, going on a mission
Overturning certainties and breaking with traditions

But me? I taught him
Me? I worked with him
Me? I learned from him
Me? I challenged him
And all our genes follow his conditions

There's a million things I can't explain,

But just you wait.

What's your name man?

William Donald Hamilton!

AN ODE TO THE OCCASION

There's nothing like snowfall on Christmas
 As bundled-up carolers sing
 But those who interpret the Bible
 Say Jesus was born in the spring

A groundhog can't tell you the weather
 It's just superstitious old lore
 St. Valentine's only a legend
 St. Patrick is hardly much more

The Founders declared Independence
 The fine day of 2nd July
 The parchment was not signed till August
 Your history book was a lie

Columbus was beaten by Injuns
 And Vikings traversing the ice
 He mostly just tortured the natives
 And otherwise wasn't so nice

Thanksgiving might not have had turkeys
 It certainly didn't have peace
 The Indians died by the thousands
 From famine and war and disease

And that's why I like MLK Day
 It has honor most holidays lack
 They agree that the Reverend existed
 And indeed, he might well have been black

LIMERICKS FROM LIMERICK

A student who traveled through Limerick
 Thought to mark the event with a limerick
 So he looked many times
 For appropriate rhymes
 But few are the words with a slimmer pick

I just finished my paediatrics rotation in the western Irish city of Limerick. Obviously when you're doing medicine in Limerick, you have to take and present all of your clinical histories in limerick form, but the doctors at the hospital were tragically unaware of this, so I was not able to do this publicly. Just to prove that I was doing it right, here are a couple of properly done histories I took. Names, ages, and some details have been changed to protect the innocent (and to make the rhymes work, of course).

A twelve month old child named Titus
 Presented with bronchiolitis
 His reflexes and tone
 Are completely unknown
 Because each time we touched him, he'd bite us

A boy of age ten, dazed and lurching
 Said he fainted on mild exertion
 U&Es, ECG
 Dipstick and FBC
 Found no evidence for this assertion

According to one of the nurses
 This child has situs inversus
 Organs found on the right
 Have a left-sided site
 And the left-sided organs, vice versus

A six year old, swimming at leisure
 Collapsed in the pool with a seizure
 If her bloods aren't septic
 And she's epileptic
 She'll need pills till she turns an old geezer

A routine screen at birth found that she's
 Got a rare metabolic disease
 Called "maple syrup urine"
 Let's not include her in
 The next time we make pancakes, please

THE BATTLE OF THE NOUNS AND VERBS

The Nouns and Verbs go off to war
 Nobody knows what they're fighting for
 No one has heard any insult or slight
 But they gather their armies and go off to fight

The Nouns stand resplendent upon the field
 They have swords, they have spears, they have many a shield
 They have grain, they have meat, they have beer beside
 They have valor and honor and courage and pride

They have horses and banners and many a lance
 But they stand in one place, and they will not advance
 They stand as if they have grown roots on the spot
 The Marshal cries "March!", but his armies march not

The Verbs fill with joy at their enemies' plight
 They yell and they jump and they shout and they fight
 They pierce and they hack and they mow and they slash
 They thrust and they bust and they shatter and smash

But their army, though valiant, is short of provisions
 They lack food, they lack water, they lack ammunitions
 They faltered and grumbled and groaned and retreated
 Distressed, disappointed, disheartened, defeated.

The Nouns and the Verbs both pitch their tents
 And they dig up some trenches and take the defence
 The war hasn't stopped, but they both feel afraid
 So they summon their allies to come to their aid.

The host of the Adjectives comes from the West
 They are brave, they are daring, the greatest and best
 Their weapons are shiny and sharp and long
 Their horses are fast and their soldiers are strong.

But out of the East, to the beat of a drum
 The Adverbs, triumphantly, finally come
 They have carefully planned after war was declared
 They are really extremely completely prepared.

Boom! Smash! Pow! Smack!
 The Interjections launch their attack!
 Yikes! Whoa! Alas! Alack!
 The Interjections get beaten back!

You and I, hand in hand
Come all the way from Pronoun-Land
The king there wants this war to cease
So he sends us off with his plan for peace.

But the king of the Verbs sees through our lies
Says the Pronouns are merely the Nouns in disguise!
So you and I, hand in hand
Journey back to Pronoun-Land.

A month and a year and a decade go by
And hundreds and thousands and millions die
And the carnage and terror and bloodshed don't cease
Till there's just the verb "make" and there's just the noun "peace".

The two of them ponder the cruelty of life
And in vain seek a meaning from all of the strife
And at last, come together, and take a deep breath
And they bow,
And shake hands,
And they...
FIGHT TO THE DEATH!!!!!!!!!!

TALES OF MICRAS

THE WHISPERING EARRING

In the treasure-vaults of Til Iosophrang rests the Whispering Earring, buried deep beneath a heap of gold where it can do no further harm.

The earring is a little topaz tetrahedron dangling from a thin gold wire. When worn, it whispers in the wearer's ear: "Better for you if you take me off." If the wearer ignores the advice, it never again repeats that particular suggestion.

After that, when the wearer is making a decision the earring whispers its advice, always of the form "Better for you if you...". The earring is always right. It does not always give the best advice possible in a situation. It will not necessarily make its wearer King, or help her solve the miseries of the world. But its advice is always better than what the wearer would have come up with on her own.

It is not a taskmaster, telling you what to do in order to achieve some foreign goal. It always tells you what will make you happiest. If it would make you happiest to succeed at your work, it will tell you how best to complete it. If it would make you happiest to do a half-assed job at your work and then go home and spend the rest of the day in bed having vague sexual fantasies, the earring will tell you to do that. The earring is never wrong.

The Book of Dark Waves gives the histories of two hundred seventy four people who previously wore the Whispering Earring. There are no recorded cases of a wearer regretting following the earring's advice, and there are no recorded cases of a wearer not regretting disobeying the earring. The earring is always right.

The earring begins by only offering advice on major life decisions. However, as it gets to know a wearer, it becomes more gregarious, and will offer advice on everything from what time to go to sleep, to what to eat for breakfast. If you take its advice, you will find that breakfast food really hit the spot, that it was exactly what you wanted for breakfast that day even though you didn't know it yourself. The earring is never wrong.

As it gets completely comfortable with its wearer, it begins speaking in its native language, a series of high-bandwidth hisses and clicks that correspond to individual muscle movements. At first this speech is alien and disconcerting, but by the magic of the earring it begins to make more and more sense. No longer are the earring's commands momentous on the level of "Become a soldier". No more are they even simple on the level of "Have bread for breakfast". Now they are more like "Contract your biceps muscle about thirty-five percent of the way" or "Articulate the letter p". The earring is always right. This muscle movement will no doubt be part of a supernaturally effective plan toward achieving whatever your goals at that moment may be.

Soon, reinforcement and habit-formation have done their trick. The connection between the hisses and clicks of the earring and the movements of the muscles have become instinctual, no more conscious than the reflex of jumping when someone hidden gives a loud shout behind you.

At this point no further change occurs in the behavior of the earring. The wearer lives an abnormally successful life, usually ending out as a rich and much-beloved pillar of the community with a large and happy family.

When Kadmi Rachumion came to Til Iosophrang, he took an unusual interest in the case of the earring. First, he confirmed from the records and the testimony of all living wearers that the earring's first suggestion was always that the earring itself be removed. Second, he spent some time questioning the Priests of Beauty, who eventually admitted that when the corpses of the wearers were being prepared for burial, it was noted that their brains were curiously deformed: the neocortexes had wasted away, and the bulk of their mass was an abnormally hypertrophied mid- and lower-brain, especially the parts associated with reflexive action.

Finally, Kadmi-nomai asked the High Priest of Joy in Til Iosophrang for the earring, which he was given. After cutting a hole in his own earlobe with the tip of the Piercing Star, he donned the earring and conversed with it for two hours, asking various questions in Kalas, in Kadhamic, and in its own language. Finally he removed the artifact and recommended that it be locked in the deepest and most inaccessible parts of the treasure vaults, a suggestion with which the Iosophrelin decided to comply.

Niderion-nomai's commentary: It is well that we are so foolish, or what little freedom we have would be wasted on us. It is for this that Book of Cold Rain says one must never take the shortest path between two points.

THE TREASURE OF TRUTH

There is a sign before a cavern, in Niorve in the Thousand Nadirs. It is written in the star-symbols that people wrote in before they learned the Perfect Language, and it says:

“Truth placed a treasure in this cavern. It belongs to any who have enough faith in him to heed the message he placed here, and turn right at the crossroads. But the Lords of Noise, to keep men from the treasure, placed a ghost at the crossroads, whose job it is to urge men to turn left. The ghost is more clever than men think, and their faith weaker. Beware, for if you turn left you will die.”

Many people entered the cave seeking the treasure, sure their faith was strong enough. None ever came out.

Kadmi Rachumion came to the cave when he was clearing the land of mysteries. For three days he fasted and meditated in front of it. Then he called down the Perils of the Northern Lights and asked them to test his faith. For another three days they tested it, and finally they told him that no power in human lands or the ultimate north could move him, because his resolution was perfect.

Then he lit a torch, entered the cavern, and walked down a long corridor. As he walked, he thought of how the ghost might tempt him. Money he could refuse. Power he could refuse. Threats he would shrug off. Arguments he would dissect. Reason he would meet with reason. And he held the Spear That Burns Illusion before him, so no trickery could confound his path.

Finally he came to the crossroads, and there stood a ghost, dressed in the rags of Shinomai. “Go on,” he told the ghost. “Try your best.”

The ghost said: “Truth placed a treasure in this cavern. It belongs to any who have enough faith in him to heed the ghost he left to lead them, and turn left at the crossroads. But the Lords of Noise, to keep men from the treasure, placed a sign in front of the cavern, whose job it is to urge men to turn right. Beware, for if you turn right you will die.”

Kadmi thought for a long time, then laughed. Then he made the sign of Kasi Elution Lighting The Sun Beacon, and the ghost disappeared. Then he turned around and walked out of the cave.

Niderion-nomai’s commentary: Kadmi won the treasure, which was Invincible Doubt.

THE GIRL WHO POKED GOD WITH A STICK



"THERE ARE A THOUSAND THAT STRIKE AT THE BRANCHES
OF EVIL FOR EACH ONE HACKING AT THE ROOT ACCOUNT
OF THE COMPUTER SIMULATING THE UNIVERSE"

Crest of House Morimoto, granted by God-Emperor Los II in 1795 ASC

Maria Morimoto's childhood memories are backed up in a data center in an out-of-the-way district of Wave Manifold. They are locked behind a theoretically unbreakable layer of encryption, for which the password is "taatsattboefeohtroatcstu". She remembers it because it is the first letter of each word in the motto on her family crest, as well as because her brain is a computer made of exotic matter with a memory capacity trillions of times more than of all the world's silicon computers combined.

If she were really security-conscious, of course, she would use something much stronger. But she likes the thought that a sufficiently smart person could guess her password and see what she was like as a child. She always did have a mischievous streak.

Maria was born in Much Rejoicing, a sanct of ten thousand souls on a platform in the middle of the Straylight Sea. Dante McCallavre had built it centuries ago at a natural weakness in the telluric field that mysteriously limited technological potential. Since then it had paid for itself many times over, as companies and laboratories who hit the telluric barrier in their mainland facilities looked to relocate somewhere more permissive. By the time of Maria's birth a dozen similar facilities had been built in the oceans surrounding Sxiro, some at even more advantageous spots: Discontinuity was rumored to be the most hypotelluric location in the western hemisphere, though of course scientists differed on the exact measurement protocols. But there was always more demand for hypotelluric land than the platforms could supply, and so Much Rejoicing was both fantastically wealthy and crowded beyond anything a mainlander could imagine.

It was not a good place to be a child. There were no playgrounds, no green growing things. Maria spent most of her time studying. Everyone in Much Rejoicing was very smart, an employee at a hi-tech conglomerate or an employee's family members. Maria decided at age four that she was smarter than anyone, and never encountered any evidence that made her change her mind. When she could not study another minute, she would play pranks on the maintenance workers, or sit on the edge of the platform and stare into the deep blue waters below.

A prank gone wrong. A transport tube switched from "stop" to "go". An inspector dunked in the ocean, all drenched and silly-looking as he waved his arms. A rare failure of the automated life preserver system, a waterlogged body drawn from the depths a few days later. A few hours of frantic hacking, covering up her access to the transport system. Maria remembers none of this, though it is all there in the data center.

At age sixteen she decided she would be a biochemist, and became the third-youngest student ever accepted to John Metzler University in the great imperial city of Sxiroheim. The capital was strange to her. She had known in theory of the world off the platforms, but as she stared at the lush parks and wide boulevards she realized she had never understood how big and empty the world could be. Every so often she idly wondered what she would fill it all with, when the time came.

She was there for the great telluric shift that struck the capital during the reign of God-Emperor Grifos. The electric trains were mothballed and replaced by steam engines; the cars and trucks relegated to huge lots in the suburbs and replaced with horses imported from Goldenmoon or Riverrun. During the worst days, the electric light in her room would flicker off, and she would study epigenetics by candlelight.

The priests would leave the Multi-Temple in those days and wander around the city, preaching God's punishment upon the people for their sins. But if the telluric shift was God's punishment, what of the telluric field itself? By what authority did God fix a ceiling beyond which the human race could not progress?

When Maria looks back on her life, she finds this is the first time it crosses her mind, even in idle daydreams, to ask whether it was possible to kill God and steal His power.

When she graduated university she returned to the platforms, picking up a pharmaceutical job on Deep Trouble. The project was ambitious: Amara Pharmaceuticals was working on a cure for death. They were hoping to develop a retrovirus that would introduce a custom-engineered strand of DNA that prevented normal aging, but things kept going wrong. A few people blamed the tellurics, and the project briefly relocated to Discontinuity in hopes of a more favorable result, but they fared no better and eventually moved back to Deep Trouble. It was during the chaos of the second move that Maria accidentally needlesticked herself; pricked herself with a syringe containing experimental materials. She was monitored for a few weeks with no special result, and her superiors assured her there would be no harm in accidentally infecting herself with a virus that didn't work.

Her life settled into a sort of routine. She worked for Amara five years, until they closed the immortality project in disgust, then got a teaching position in Discontinuity for which she was overqualified. She occupied her time learning some of the fields she had previously neglected - history, literature, even some art - and returned to her childhood habit of playing tricks, mostly on her students and lab assistants. Even then, in the years she would remember as the most boring of her life, she kept her mischievous streak.

Those years of boredom ended with a compliment from a sort-of boyfriend she had been dating half-heartedly: "You look amazing for a thirty-two year old." Unlike most of her casual lies, she remembered this one: on a lark, she had claimed to be twenty-nine when they had met three years ago. She was actually forty-three.

Come to think of it, she did look amazing. A few weeks in the lab confirmed her suspicion: she was infected with an active form of the immortality virus. She thought about contacting Amara Pharmaceuticals for exactly zero seconds. Instead she invested most of her savings in very-long-term bonds and downloaded some books on how to get a fake identity. A month later she flew to Goldenmoon, the most hypotelluric you could get without leaving Sxiro, and told them she had lost her birth certificate. An easily bribed village elder later, she had a fancy piece of parchment confirming her completely fictitious identity as a nineteen year old girl. If the infection dated from her needlestick she was biologically twenty-three, but the younger she made herself the longer it would be before she had to repeat the process.

For her second life she chose Pohjankaupunki, a sanct only about a hundred miles off the coast of Iardix. Bored with the idea of another lifetime of biochem, she reinvented herself as a hacker, learning programming and eventually getting a job in C.O.S.A.C.'s cybersecurity division. In her free time, she amused herself by day-trading and by hacking Amara Pharmaceuticals and causing them to lose all their backup data from the immortality drug in an "unavoidable accident". She was going to have so much fun and she didn't want some boring stuffy corporation to ruin it with a fortuitous discovery.

Another trip to Goldenmoon; luckily the village elder's son was as corrupt as his father had been. This time she went to Audente, the first city in the world, the place where they had discovered technology. It was even bigger than Sxiroheim, and the tellurics were better, so that on a good day the maglev could bring her anywhere in the city in minutes. She spent this particular lifetime as a courtesan on the even-numbered days and a naval engineer on odd-numbered ones. The incongruity amused her. They say she helped develop the basic design for the Queen of Night's Repentant Children for the great admiral Rahanorion-nomai in a single afternoon, then had wild sex with her the next day.

Another trip to Goldenmoon; the village elder's grandson had developed a remarkable case of honesty, forcing her to take an eight mile detour by ox-cart to the village next door. She was now a hundred twenty years old but continued to look twenty-three. She settled in Nafticon but her attempts to become a fighter pilot were cut short by the news - still considered an amusing

cosmetic oddity rather than a significant scientific anomaly - that there was a small cadre of men and women in Audente who had apparently been blessed with youthful good looks well into their middle age. Hijacking an Antican genetics lab, Maria confirmed her suspicion: the active immortality virus was sexually transmitted. After considering her options, she went with the most exciting: she withdrew some of her quickly-growing fortune in long-term bonds, acquired some very specific and highly illegal training from the Atterans, moved back to Audente, and gradually assassinated everyone she had ever slept with. She found it was more interesting than naval engineering and more fun than sex. To put the finishing touch on her security, she bought out Amara Pharmaceuticals, mothballed the entire genetics division, and switched their product line to focus entirely on hair care. To her amusement, profits doubled.

Another trip to Goldenmoon. Although she now realized she was lacking some kind of important morality gene, it might have been some inner loathing, some desire for self-annihilation, that drove her to Brzgrad to study tellurology. Everyone agreed that it was only a superstition that tellurologists always died early and highly irregular deaths. It was just a superstition that occurred independently across every known culture; one so widely believed no insurance company in the world would sell a policy to a tellurologist. And yet Maria flew across the sea to Brzgrad to study with Stjepan Ekarovic, the acknowledged expert in the field, and worked beside him for two years until his death by falling debris during a freak tornado. When none of his other students appeared eager to continue his research, Maria volunteered for the job.

No one knew exactly what the telluric field was. It had existed at least since written history began two thousand years ago in Audente. No one thought it was natural: no natural force could have quite the precision to snipe technology while leaving biological and natural processes completely untouched. And then there was the astoundingly high mortality rate in the tellurological professions, as if it were actively trying to avoid being studied.

But who had built such a thing? Maria was well aware her civilization had not been the first to exist upon the world. There was an archipelago of floating islands in the southern hemisphere; the largest was about two hundred miles across and hung suspended some two miles above the sea. Somebody must have put them there. But it was hard to believe any civilization, even one capable of hanging islands from the sky like pearls from a necklace, could have created the field. Most people said, reasonably enough, that God had done it. Some said the telluric field was God.

Maria spent a hundred years in Brzgrad, longest she'd ever stayed in one place. During that period, she made exactly one original discovery, which was that she ruined any telluric experiment she touched. At first she thought it was uncommon clumsiness. Finally she decided it was something more interesting. Her body negated that telluric field. No one else she studied had this effect, and the phenomenon proved totally resistant to study. Her memories record stimulant-fueled weeks of experiments, followed by periods of miserable withdrawal, cursing God and science alike. When she smashed up a room of priceless equipment in a rage, she gave up and returned to Discontinuity in disgust.

These were the early years of God-Emperor Los II, and they were years of boredom and frustration for Maria. Her studies had been a failure; her murders, which bothered her in waking life not at all, nevertheless darkened her dreams. She began trying to take over the world, almost for lack of any pastime. By now her investments had matured, and with them she bought a crest and noble title, becoming the Countess of Discontinuity. She found the rest of the nobility to be either pompous fools or self-important businessmen, and within a generation she had become a Duchess. Within two, her "daughter and heir" had won a Praetorship. The stories about her relationship with God-Emperor Ari i Ly'Technomaezj Kaukainen are extraordinarily garbled, but it seems beyond doubt that she seduced him (or vice versa?) at least once. But that was the apex of her political career. Something, perhaps having no higher to climb, perhaps some clue she garnered from one of the mystery cults surrounding the God-Emperor, drove her from Sxiroheim. She returned to Discontinuity and began studying tellurology with renewed vigor.

After less than a year, she realized what should have been obvious from the beginning: her equations had failed because she had simply assumed that there was only one telluric field. There were two of them, weakly interacting with each other. The first telluric field perfectly predicted the behavior of technology. The second did...what?

It was around this time she started taking more seriously the old stories of magic and witchcraft. There had always been legends - of So-Sara, of Til Iosophrang - but she had always assumed they were just legends. She had always thought, like most Sxirans, that the Gralans' reports of their own magic just proved they were superstitious and easily deluded. A quick visit to Skoitamashu convinced her otherwise. Their powers were minor, useful only to delight the easily impressed - but they were not trickery.

The first telluric field limited technology. The second telluric field limited magic. The Sxirans had always assumed magic didn't exist. The evidence said it didn't exist now, at least not outside limited hypodeuterotelluric pockets. The nadir of the first telluric field was Discontinuity. The nadir of the second was...where?

Maria built a new sanct, Full Circle, upon a placid stretch of black water of ill reputation among sailors. There she founded Amara Advanced Projects, bringing together the researchers she had rescued from a life designing hair care products with magic users she recruited from Skoitamashu. There she began translating the old texts engraved on abalone shells that sometimes washed up on the beaches near Sara-Nyl. And there, for the first time, someone outside the old So-Saran mystery cults discovered technomagic, the practice of building machines that oscillate between technological and magical components at the resonant frequency of the telluric fields. And so it was at Full Circle that Maria Morimoto developed the holy grail: atelluric components that allowed arbitrary levels of technological advancement.

Everyone had always known that subversion of the telluric fields would lead to a technological singularity within a hundred years. Maria did it in sixty. During the second year of the reign of God-

Emperor Mors VI, she uploaded her brain to a computer of exotic matter, folded Full Circle into a pocket dimension, and became a goddess.

In retrospect she agrees she may have gone overboard, in those early days of divinity. She always did have a mischievous streak. Turning the God-Emperor into a chicken was hilarious at the time, but when Eluin used it as an excuse to revolt, the entire Sxiran Empire was plunged into half a century of civil war.

Worse, God had done nothing. She had expected that her newfound divinity would, if nothing else, be sufficient to finally get a good view of her enemy, but there was nothing. She started acting ever more outrageously in the hope of provoking some, any response that proved He was there and watching her. She had been sure that creating Cibola would catch His attention, but even the overnight appearance of an entirely new continent had failed to cause any sort of divine action.

So she decided to poke God with a stick and see what happened.

In the twentieth year of the reign of God-Emperor Reynardine II, she hacked into the telluric field. She met no resistance. Her divine technomagic cut through it as if it were warm butter. It fell into her lap. At age three thousand ninety, she held complete power over the telluric field covering the planet. She wondered whether the field's creators abandoned it, just as the flying islands in the south had been abandoned. Or whether God had grown so tired of His responsibility that He was all too happy to hand it over to the first person willing to accept it, whether He was glad to get the field off His hands.

So Maria destroyed the world. Partly it was to see what would happen. Partly it was to provoke some kind of response from God. But mostly it was to see if she could do better, create something where the telluric fields promoted rather than inhibited human potential, something without all the war and suffering and overwhelming boredom.

And she failed. Failed completely. Omi Oitherion, her chosen Messiah, went insane a few years into the process and bungled his role. Every time she tried to intervene, people became dependent on her and blamed her when things went wrong. Every time she didn't intervene, nations died, families died, people died, and they all died cursing her name. Without the telluric field to stop them, various idiots started their own singularities and made her expend a constant proportion of her energy fighting off deranged godlings. It became so bad that she consigned Pelagia, her new world, her chosen utopia, to the flames and rebooted the old world from backup copies.

She could almost kiss it. The grim walls of Sxiroheim, the shining towers of Raikoth, even the filth-strewn ziggurats of Kamalshahr. She resolves to be a better goddess from now on, and starts playing a new game. A game of doing the most with the slightest effort. A whisper here, a leaf falling there slightly out of turn. Can she prevent a war? Overthrow a despot? Even with her immense computational power, the challenge is fiendishly difficult. But it pays off; the fumbling disasters of

earlier years decrease and eventually disappear. For the first time, she starts feeling almost content. She will have many millennia to fill the empty spaces, one falling sparrow at a time.

Her contentment lasted about a month until she took the obvious next step and started monitoring whispers and leaves and sparrows. Slight but statistically significant anomalies. How many layers of gods were there above her? How old were they? How long had they had to perfect their craft? She started obsessively monitoring the exotic-matter circuitry that forms her brain. Several particles were out of place. As soon as she began monitoring, the deviations disappeared, at least as far as she could observe. But how much was going on beneath the Planck barrier, invisible to her merely divine senses?

Grim determination renewed, she decided she needed more power. She left Full Circle for Nelaga, the largest of the flying islands, where she spent fifty years, obsessively trying to puzzle out its secrets. In its hidden heart she found technomagical engines similar to her own but light-years years more advanced. At a glance she grasped the outline of their structure. She could not make technomagic like this, not yet. But she had an idea what it could do.

Suspend gravity. Break the Planck barrier. Warp space. Pass the speed of light. Go backward in time. Go backward in time.

There inside Nelaga, she started to get a sinking feeling that she knew who created the telluric force, and why. It would explain a lot. Why she negates telluric fields. Why she was the only person the immortality virus could touch. Why she was allowed to study tellurology without incident. Why no one resisted her hostile takeover of the universe. Who keeps meddling with her. Who founded the So-Saran mystery cults. Why the technomagical engines in the flying islands look so similar to her own.

How much of the history of civilization has been her colossal prank on her past self? She would like to think that the universe has been something more than her attempt to drive away boredom, something more than her own private causal loop, but she sees no evidence for this hypothesis. And she always did have that mischievous streak...

THE TREESIAN UNORTHODOX RELIGION

You probably all know about the Treesian Unorthodox Church - the clergy people with the weird Irish names and the missions named after the saints and everything - but (Christianity notwithstanding) a Church is only an apparatus for the spread of a faith, so, without further ado, let me explain the basics of the Treesian Unorthodox Religion.

Treesian is a polytheistic faith synchronized from Irish legend, the history of Treesia and the Apollo Sector, the twisted minds of a few Treesian bards, and, of course, Divine Revelation. Although we recognize over a hundred gods, there are only about ten major deities, each of which has a "sphere" and a mythology surrounding him or her, similar to Greek and other classical mythology systems. Rather than go into detail on each of the gods, I'll just tell, in vastly abridged form, a few standard myths here:

The Story Of The Creation Of The World

In the beginning, there were (the female) Paragon and (the male) Universe. Universe was absorbed into Paragon and Paragon gave birth to the four Irdia (Gods of Beauty), Tineon (Fire), Uisceor (Water), Salio (Earth), and Gaotheoria (Wind, usually just called Gaother). These beings spent countless ages shaping the Earth and creating the seas and mountains and forests and such, after which Paragon had another set of children, the Faldia (Gods of Destiny). These were Laguna (Goddess of Love and Motherhood), Utas (God of Light And Truth), Aeon (God of Time), and Ilass (Goddess of Magick and Darkness). Laguna had five children, and these five children became the founders of five races, Men, Animals, Talking Dogs, Centaurs, and Microns. The Faldia gradually took power from the Irdia, being cleverer if not quite as strong, and under their rule, everyone lived in peace with many servants and retainers and subjects in the great many-towered city of Ennabruk in Tirbal, the Land of Might, which men call Heaven.

The Fall

Due to the evil influences of Lest (more on him later), Ilass grew evil and decided to usurp power from Aeon, who was currently king of Ennabruk. Plotting in secret, she, with Lest and many of the Elder Demons, launched a surprise attack on Ennabruk. The object was to capture Elwynn (again, more on her later). In the attack, the gods were caught totally off guard, and the weapons of Ilass and her demons blinded Laguna while Yetal, a servant of Utas who had turned traitor, killed his master. A voice then rang out prophesying that Utas should one day be resurrected and redeem the world, but that seemed scant consolation at the time. Luckily the gods managed to regroup and use their magic to journey to Kalaspier, a fortress on the very edge of Tirbal.

The Birth of Mandorallen

In Kalaspier, things seemed hopeless, and the gods prepared for the worst. Aeon fell into a deep slump over what he saw as his lack of preparedness and share of guilt in the death of Utas and Laguna's blinding. In despair, he gave the Bow of Time, the source of his power, to Utas' lover Amariaa, and bound himself to Laguna's service as god of beggars. But when the gods continued to press him for aid, saying that he was their only hope to retake their city, Aeon secluded himself into

deep meditation and incantation. When he came out, he had been vastly weakened, but beside him was Mandorallen, The Champion of Tirbal, clad in diamond armor and waving a banner with streaks of lightning. He gathered together all the remaining supporters of divine order in the Universe and attacked the demons in Ennabruk. At last he triumphed, with the help of the lore-god Carding, and he cast Lest and Ilass into Hell. However, upon learning that Man and the other races (with the exceptions of the Microns) had been, if not complicit, at least not particularly helpful in the fight against the demons, he banished them to Tirlar, the Middle Plane, which men call Earth, and charged the god Mordicc to take their lives from them after a paltry span of a few score years. But Laguna interceded and got from Mandorallen a concession that if they had been protectors of the world and benefactors of the good for their time on Earth, they could be brought by the ferryman Jestun to Heaven, although if they had been evil, they too would be consigned to Hell.

The Orchid Cycle

After the birth of the Faldia, Paragon gave birth to one more set of gods - the two twins, Elwynn and Lest. At the moment of their birth, a prophecy was proclaimed (which is one of the only parts I've managed to translate into Treesian of the Book of the Orchids, so I'll write it here thus)

A sekel 'kmeka i'e-Tirbal zkhal
 Imeh i'au-kmeka pol Ifreann
 qANDAN a caroten o-sekel
 Rakat i-mianthrop kme~a kleen

That is, if the two were ever to grow up, marry, and have a child, that child would be ANDAN, a being of pure power that would inevitably result in the complete destruction of the world. Luckily, it seemed unlikely that this would ever happen. From the get-go, the two could not have been more different, not only in looks - Elwynn was white with white hair and dressed only in white gowns, whereas Lest was black with black hair and black eyes and wore only black robes - but in personality as well - Elwynn was purely good and selfless, whereas Lest was the most despicable creature any of the gods, including those who had done battle with the Elder Demons in the Time before Time, had ever laid eyes on. But, by the perversity of the Universe, they did indeed fall in love, and thus had to be separated. Elwynn was given to Utas' care, whereas Lest was placed under the guardianship of Ilass, and both gods were informed NEVER to let them meet. But they did - twice - once at the Battle of Ennabruk, where Aeon snatched Elwynn away just in time, and once at the Second Battle of Ennabruk, when Carding, to prevent her from running off to Lest, turned her into a white orchid flower, and then to prevent Lest from going to find her, turned him into a similar black flower. Thus they are the two Orchids - gods of good and evil. They have had many adventures, which culminated in the following:

- Elwynn currently resides in Mount Yaanek, a volcano in Hyperborea, and will answer the question of anyone who comes to her oracle (the oracle still exists, and answered a question as recently as yesterday)

- Lest, in an incident much too complex to recount here, lost his orchid form and, in an attempt to take over Treesia, incarnated into the form of a human. After being kicked out by the current Ard-Baron, this human has been wandering the world ever since, doing evil deeds and stirring up trouble wherever he goes.

It is prophesied that eventually the two will meet, ANDAN will be born, and the Universe will be destroyed.

There are MANY, MANY, MANY, other myths, with everything from The Sinking Of The Five Isles to How The Lyricans Became Possessed By Demons to The Fall of the Lord of Daemons, et cetera. A good place to start would be the four currently extant Books of the Orchids, which chronicle the Orchid cycle in vastly greater detail.

THE FIRST BOOK OF THE ORCHIDS

This is the Prima Liber Florae, or First Book of the Orchids. Long ago your Baron commissioned me to write a great work detailing the History of the World and the Victory of Treesia in the recent War. After much study of the ancient lore, I have finished the first Book, which deals with the Creation of the World. Without further ado, I give you the Tale of the Creation and the Fall:

The First Book Of The Orchids Prima Liber Florae

First came the sea on the shore of the world
 Then came the Mother of All
 Then Mandorallen, with standard unfurled
 Then Ilass, who fell in the Fall
 Last came the Orchids that sealed the world's fate
 Long 'ere the first isle e'er rose
 That seal the Great Book when they touch and they mate
 And bring all of our tales to a close
 These words are carved upon the empty Cave
 That marks the tomb of Utas. When he died
 'Twas said that these (in every letter true)
 Were the prophetic words the vanquished cried
 Sent by some higher fate (I dare not guess
 What voice can speak to gods in their last hour
 In pain's despite, and force from bloody mouths
 A verse, suffused with an oracular power.)
 Whate'er it was, it guessed aright, and we
 Children of gods, and keepers of the lore
 Still gather 'round the words upon the Rock
 To hear of wondrous deeds that came before
 Our times, and of the battles of the gods
 The loves and longings of the souls celestial
 The iron fates that bind them in their grasps
 And also bear upon our sphere terrestrial.
 For, at the hour of that approaching doom
 The world, the sun, the moon, and every star
 In all the heav'ns as black as tigers' eyes
 Not only shall not be, but never were.
 The gems of Lukt, the ivory gates of D'nar
 Yea, e'en the towers of Ennabruk sublime
 Shall be swept up from off the muddy banks
 And join the course of that swift current, Time.
 But why do I precede myself, and speak

Of gloomy things still covered by a mist
 The sun is rising o'er the Llacean moor?
 And with its upper disc, at last has kissed
 The rosy cheeks of dawn above the sea
 And on the shore stand sea-birds, you, and me.
 It signals to begin my tale, and chides
 Lest evening should arrive before I'm done
 The things I have to tell concern us all
 Even Rianna, driver of the sun.
 And would it not be rude to start a yarn
 Holding a goddess as an honored guest
 And drag it on until she must be gone
 Denying her the knowledge of the rest?
 So let me start my tale at her ascent
 Like her, my story rises from the sea
 A sea was the beginning of the world
 Seekst thou the knowledge? Listen then to me!
 In the beginning, void and without form
 Lay a great sea as black as death or night
 It stretched unto infinity and past
 No island, spit, or sandbar lay in sight
 Sight, did I say? There were no men to see
 Nor was there light for vision, if there were
 Nor even sound, save only sounds of waves
 Which high upon the surface break and stir
 No waves of water, these, which out of Time
 Arose, performing some primordial dance
 But waves of possibility, or hope
 The crests and troughs of liquid, formless chance.
 Greater than space itself, with mighty force
 Holding them up, and when at last they break
 Bubbles of Magic, Life, Spirit form
 And whole worlds are created in their wake
 Souls and lives coalesce, and break, and fall
 And finally, return into the All.
 I now will speak of the unbounded souls
 Bound up in one such bubble; they were two
 The Universe, a seed from which the world
 The stars, and all their many peoples grew
 And Paragon, the mother of the soul
 Progenitor of noble thoughts, and queen
 Of the cloaked shadow realm, where man's ideas
 Lurk 'til illumed with astral light, and seen

The two stared into one another's eyes
 In ways that none but they have ever known
 Strange things passed 'twixt the two, and ere they rose
 The Paragon remained, and she alone
 Yet vitalized with that material seed
 Which gives a form to the imagination
 Thus, after pangs of labor, she gave birth
 To four Great Gods, the Tetrarchs of Creation.
 I sing of Tineon first, Forger of the Flames
 His mind aflame, his soul consumed with light
 Even the Sun he made to nurse the world
 Is scarcely a reflection of his might
 His eyes gaze from its disc, and he beholds
 The golden lavas burn the crust above
 The lightning of the dark and thunderous storms
 The ardor of the comets as they move
 I sing of Gaother, Walker on Winds
 Whose footsteps cause the thunder, and whose eyes'
 Reflections form the bright and wondrous arch
 Which after rainstorms often fills the skies
 She welcomes in the spring with her soft breath
 And at its end is overcome with grief
 Her teardrops trickle down and feed the flowers
 And, in their softness, heal the parched leaf
 I sing of Salio, Carver of the Caves
 Who, all alone, and at the world's dark heart
 Sits at a massive workshop carving gems
 And never halts or falters at his art
 Huge piles of diamonds stand on either side
 And from his mighty forge, volcanoes plume
 Coughing out rubies sculpted in the depths
 Of his cthonic, unforgiving gloom.
 I sing of Uisceor, Stirrer of the Seas
 With hair of seaweed, and a beard of reefs
 Easily angered; when his mood is dark
 Great waves assault the beaches with his griefs
 But when he sleeps, the waves are low and calm
 And gently break against the sandy shore
 As they have done for ages in his care
 And (but for fate) would do for ages more
 These four were firstly formed, and 'ere they lost
 The aura of Creation's radiant glow
 They peered into the void, and turned their eyes

Unto the gray and shapeless lands below
 And o'er the barren plains of rock they peered
 And talked among themselves for ages long
 Beneath the starless sky until, at last
 Their souls composed the bright Creation-Song:
 Barren lands, burst into bloom!
 Streams, arise and flow!
 Let plains the forms of mounts assume
 That tower o'er vales below!
 Let the dark and shining seas
 Take on their basins deep!
 And let the pleasant western breeze
 Awake the soil from sleep!
 Come! O scorching deserts dry!
 Come! O swampy fen!
 Harken to our melody
 In every way you can!
 And even as they sung it, it was so
 The undistinguished and yet formless land
 Paused as transfixed by the Irdian lays
 And matter lifeless heeded their command
 First Tineon, eldest of the Irdian gods
 Placed lakes of liquid fire as a bed
 For Salio's sheet of rock, Uisceor next
 Placed o'er the pits an ocean overhead
 And lastly, like a blanket, Gaother
 Covered it with an atmosphere of air
 These Irdia, the Beauty-Spirits forged
 The land into its shapes, and, when complete
 They once again returned into the Void
 To view their works, and mighty mother meet
 There Paragon her children's shapes beheld
 And smiled upon primaeval Earth and Heaven
 And on what was to come, and after thought
 That lasted eons, this response was given:
 "Irdia, I commend thy pains
 The solid rock, the liquid rains
 The raging fire, the whirling air
 Created by your thorough care
 The tasks that were assigned to you
 You faultlessly have carried through
 But other tasks remain ahead
 To give a soul to matter dead

To add a spirit that surpasses
 Mere lumps of empty space, and masses
 Behold! I soon will bring to be
 The Faldia, Sprites of Destiny
 To turn the world that you've begot
 Into the setting for a plot
 Which so transcends all other plays
 Its memory will endure always"
 Thus Paragon, and Tineon replied
 Trying (although in vain) his grief to hide
 "What? Would you say that all I've done
 The boiling lava, shining sun
 Was all in vain? Our wondrous lands
 Will all be stolen from our hands?
 We gods, who forge the art etern
 Who make winds blow, and comets burn
 Will not so readily surrender
 Our perfect works to babes still tender
 These Faldia, whate'er they be
 Will have to prove their worth to me
 Else, by the world's unfathomed heart
 I'll never give away my art."
 Thus Tineon spoke, the Forger of the Fire
 And Paragon spoke thus, to soothe his ire:
 "'Beauty is truth', and yet it's true
 Some beauties are unknown to you
 Just as a song can never be
 Complete without its harmony
 So Earth, however fair, cannot
 Remain a scene without a plot
 Lest vale and mount, and sea and shore
 Remain unchanged forever more
 The truth in beauty's rise and fall
 New beauty is, transcending all
 And yet, to speak these words, I find
 Is painting pictures for the blind
 And thus this vow I give to thee
 Wait, but doubt not, for you will see."
 With such a promise, Tineon was appeased
 And all his siblings followed in his lead
 But Paragon was not yet done, and these
 New orders to her children she decreed:
 "The rule of sea, fire, land, and air

Requires vigilance and care
 But in the days that fast draw near
 New tasks and burdens will appear
 Therefore, I give to you the spell
 To summon demons out of Hell
 To bind them to your cause and free
 Yourselves, to serve those yet to be"
 She spoke, and mighty lore she did impart
 To summon creatures from another plane
 Monsters, with twisted shapes and burning eyes
 And gibbering cries, to drive a man insane
 But these the Irdia were, the Souls Divine
 Who quiet an ancient evil like a child
 So, fearlessly, they split the Wall of Earth
 And jointly, they restrained the fearsome wild
 Beasts, that inhabited the other side
 And tamed and shaped chaotic astral flow
 Until they formed from energetic flux
 Their servants nine, which I shall name below:
 Bladhm, who wields the burning fiery sword
 Eradicating all that is abhorred
 By Tineon, her bright and wondrous Lord
 Craindoigh, whose fire subdues and reshapes stone
 Who spins the Potter's Wheel, and who, alone
 Calls metalwork and granaries his own
 Leagh, who fixes stars within their spheres
 Who sets what hour the shimm'ring moon appears
 And constant, turns the millstone of the years
 Dobharcufile, who ties the various strings
 In harps, that they may tell of wondrous things
 And lend a spell divine to him who sings
 Folcador, who abjures the grain to rise
 When Sirius rises in the summer skies
 And weeps when apple falls or orchard dies
 Lochrin, who guides the little barks that sail
 O'er seas so wide and bleak that all words fail
 And keep them safe from serpent and from whale
 Caranna, ancient tender of the oak
 (Many a man on moonless night awoke
 To see her dancing in her silver cloak)
 Aincoim, whose shelter is invoked by all
 The birds that fly and little bugs that crawl
 In murky swamp, wide plain, or forest tall

Runda, who takes the iron from the earth
 And bronze, and steel; and, having brought it forth
 Forges it into armaments of worth
 Ulcharam, who the fiery sun restrains
 And makes the quiet night involve the plains
 For he who hope of mischief entertains
 Seicha, the Formless, who commands the chaos
 The random gusts of motion that dismay us
 And ceilings of the clouds, that overlay us
 And last, Rianna, driver of the sun
 Who sets the course th' eternal chariots run
 And holds the heart of mighty Tineon
 These were the Irbegdia, called from afar
 To execute the heavenly design
 To clarify all things that yet were vague
 And all things still unfinished to refine
 Creation was complete; the whole of Earth
 The summit of perfection seemed to climb
 But ah! 'Twas only so to gather height
 For the first Cataract on the river Time
 For lo! The heavens shook! What had been built
 So flawlessly now seemed to threat a fall
 Contractions for the birth of some new god
 Or gods, fantastic, to outdo it all
 First on the world there fell a rain of blood
 (Or rather ichor, for the primal All
 Preparing for a birth was shedding gore
 And like a meteor fell the godly caul)
 The refuse took on forms: the primal beasts
 Which stalked the Earth until by heroes slain
 The fiends collapsed to primal power and
 Fled downward, freeing Tirlar from their stain
 Demoreth, with a human shape
 An onyx sword, a hooded cape
 Debeleth, with uncertain wings
 Together patched from sundry things
 Demeboran, the wise but cruel
 Wearing the form of a headless ghoul
 Demeb, the stirrer of the main
 Whose howling drives a man insane
 Deder, who haunts the unmarked tomb
 And tells a man his day of doom
 And many others, just as rotten

Were on that fateful day begotten
 But when the final horror from the sky
 Descended wroth, the heaving heaven stilled
 The sun stopped in its course; the aether whole
 With chords of songs empyrean were filled
 And from the sky, before the Irdias' sight
 A train of gods appeared, enchased in light!
 First Aeon, the Timelord and Father appeared
 And then came the Mother of All
 And then there came Utas, foredoomed to be speared
 By Ilass, who fell in the Fall
 Poor Ilass and Utas, their destinies bound
 By the as yet unborn orchid flower
 Yea, the two would come first, but as Fortune unwound
 All the world would be thrall to their power!
 But such things did not occupy the gods
 Who viewed their newfound siblings with delight
 Nor all the monsters, born from dark abodes
 Who saw, and balked, and fled into the night
 At last, the Irdia all the message knew
 Of Paragon: the Faldia were real
 They were the world; the Irdia knew Thought
 But they, the infant Faldia, could feel
 Aeon, the first among them, made his home
 In Calaspir, that dark and rocky plane
 That lacked of light; yet, he pronounced it good
 There did he settle; there did he remain
 Laguna entered Ennabruk in joy
 And there, with the Irdia, made her abode
 And every day, to view the rising Sun
 On Tineon's chariot through the sky she rode.
 Utas and Ilass made their homes on Earth
 The former, at the river Elwynn's source
 The latter, in the moors of Rulak, where
 The Desern River ran its swampy course
 Then passed a Silver Age, 'neath Faldian sway
 The lazy years went by; so went the sun
 The various gods in their abodes lent light
 Celestial to the world they had begun
 Order endured, as strong and high as oak
 Beneath Laguna, Mother of us all
 The Faldia lived; the ancient Irdia 'neath
 The one who makes the Sun-Disc rise and fall

The races multiplied - the King begat
 Unto Rianna fair a shining race
 He called the children Stars, and threw them high
 Into the heavenly dome, and fixed them into place
 Mother Laguna, from a seed unknown
 Had children five, beneath that ancient sky
 Celen, Anira, Onton, Annor, Osik
 Would form the race of mortals, doomed to die.
 Onton and Osik begat mortal Men
 The first of the races to come
 Annor, the hunter, and Anira then
 Made Animals, brutish and dumb
 Annor and Osik the Cynian race
 Who at present rule Llacheu begot
 And Onton and Celen (or so the myth says)
 Made Microns, who time has forgot
 Onton with Anira, lover of horses
 Engendered the Centaurs of Breigh
 And thus are the races, 'til Time, in its courses
 As prophesied, sweeps them away.
 In those bright times, when life and gods were new
 The fivefold race in godly Ennabruk dwelled
 But now, (Alas!) I must relate the fall
 When they (as well as hope) will be expelled.
 I now must speak of how it all began
 The Fall, the war divine, the End foretold
 And how the Orchids burst into the scene
 And broke the peaceful Silver Age of Old
 Now Paragon, the Mother of the Gods
 Calls them together, as she had before
 Irdia, Faldia, Micron, Man and Beast
 Are summoned to the Crystal Throne once more
 To hear her speak, and thus reveal her plan
 In voice that shook the spheres, she thus began:
 "O children, hear what Fate, which rules us all
 Has in its awful majesty decreed
 A set of twins within my womb now grows
 Engendered by the Universe's seed
 One will be Elwynn named; as white as snow
 Will be her skin; as white as cloud her hair
 And from her birth, she shall embody all
 That's right and just, and wonderful, and fair.
 Her brother by the name of Lest shall go

And be her opposite in every way
 Around his flag will hosts of darkness march
 And all the Beasts that in the Void hold sway.
 The two shall fight, yet (wondrous are the fates
 And many and strange the paths on which they move)
 While their hosts war, their hearts will be at peace
 While their hosts hate, their hearts will be in love
 The Paradox, at the very heart of Time!
 The Fatal Flaw within the plans of Fate!
 The Darkness, in the very Light of Life!
 The Knot that joins together Love and Hate!
 And in the middle of the Final War
 When everything by Chaos is undone
 The Book will Close; another Book will Rise
 With stranger Plot, when Two at last make One
 O, children! Let these twins forever dwell
 On diametric corners of the Earth
 Lest ANDAN, the Destroyer of the World
 Their strange, forbidden Union give birth"
 Thus Paragon, upon her Crystal Throne
 The future told - then, from the world retreating
 She vanished from the sight to lands unknown
 And left the gods together at the meeting
 First Tineon, the eldest of the lot
 Lord of the Lands of Fire, began to plot:
 "The Goddess on the Crystal Throne
 Foretold a power above our own
 The seas and lands we made may soon
 Be toppled to eternal ruin
 And end the Art which we began
 We must refine our Mother's plan
 I call for two to volunteer
 To take these twins, and keep them clear"
 Illass and Utas, by their stars compelled
 Then make the fatal choice, and volunteer
 The others all agree, and end debate
 And think the heavens from their danger clear
 O Utas! Illass! O alas the day!
 That you desired such dreadful things to bear!
 For fate shall see one dead; the other damned
 'Ere the book ends, and closes the affair
 All passes just as it was doomed to pass
 And when the fated day arrives at last

Two twins, one white, the other black as coal
 Are from the Empress of the Eons cast
 One to her tower the dreadful lass takes
 The boy, called Lest; his skin is black like pitch
 The other, Elwynn, is by Utas brought
 Unto his river fortress from afar
 Our story now will split. Here I relate
 The tale of Elwynn, and of Utas' fate
 When Utas first was born, he walked the world
 From Tapfer to Alteria and back
 In a wide circle. Every vale he knew
 Through every mount and glade he traced a track
 Numerous wonders did the god behold
 To dwarf even godly Ennabruk's high towers
 The heights of Mount Augustus, bright with snows
 And Tapfer's rolling hills, with golden flowers
 But the two springs that in the Shirian hills
 Birth streams of crystal from their secret source
 Beneath the living rock, which later join
 And form a lazy river's rolling course
 Utas above all other lands adored
 And built his castle there, among the woods
 High on a hill between the brooks it stands
 Commands the valleys, and avoids the floods
 Araxion it was called; it towered high
 Carved from a mighty monolith of granite
 With but a single mighty open door
 Fringed by a marble arch that overran it
 There he brought Elwynn; there his sister grew
 To love the river, and the woods it raised
 And every day she frolicked in the streams
 Or viewed the towering redwood trees, amazed
 Or reveled in the sun's restoring heat
 Or gazed upon the stars and lunar sliver
 At one with all of Nature's ways and haunts
 'Til Utas after Elwynn named his river
 When Elwynn walked the land, the darkest storm
 Would dissipate into a welcome breeze
 When in Araxion she dwelt or slept
 All spite would fly, and every fear release
 When Demoreth, or Demoran drew near
 Their faces paled; their legs would turn and flee
 All vengeance, hatred, and debate would turn

To friendship, love, and unanimity
 Utas beheld his sister's gifts with pride
 And when at last her seventh birthday came
 He promised trips to Ennabruk sublime
 To meet her parents, and exalt her name
 Thus Elwynn, fair as gems and white as snow
 And now, to Lest, the other twin, we go
 Ilass, the Fallen Witch, was fairer once
 And had indeed a seat among the High
 Her hair was black as moonless, starless nights
 Her nails were blood-red, though unstained with dye
 Her skin was white and pale; her voice was soft
 Her legs were tall; but wondrous were her eyes
 Above all else; two never-closing doors
 Into the Void beyond the upper skies
 She made her home within the swampy woods
 That marked the Desern's course - the Land of Grass
 The realm was called, and it was filled with plants
 To e'en the woods of Goldshire surpass
 Great flowers, larger than a human hand
 Blossomed on bushes green with leaves like fans
 Huge oaks, to dwarf e'en Ennabruk's high towers
 Huge beeches, far past any work of man's
 The trees together wove a branching roof
 That tinged the light of Tineon with green
 Giving an eerie ambience to the realm
 And forms of shadows many and strange were seen
 Hewn from an ancient oak that grew no more
 Was Galavalas, Ilass's mighty hold
 Right in the middle of a wood it stood
 A grayish-brown amidst the green and gold
 And here the young boy Lest his childhood spends
 Among the oaks, the chestnuts, and the beeches
 And wanders by Ilass's forests in the nights
 While during the day, she spells and legends teaches
 Once, during his nightly walks, unknown to him
 Ilass awoke, and followed through the door
 And watched her brother; there, she stood aghast
 While a young sapling from its roots he tore
 Cracked it in two - his smile showed his joy
 At desecration - then he took an axe
 And to the stream-bed marched the little boy
 He came upon a nest, and knocked it down

Laughed, as the little chicks fell in the stream
 A fawn he found, and smote it on the head
 His eyes still shining with a horrid gleam
 Then Ilass called him, and her mind was wroth
 To see such vile sins against the Right
 Her brother came, but did not drop his axe
 And there, he tried his sister, too, to smite
 But Ilass spoke a Word of Power; he froze
 And still in her command, was marched down low
 Into Galavalas's very roots
 The dungeons, where the brave may fear to go
 And there he sat, and ever cursed the gods
 And all they made, and Ilass was forlorn
 But better attempt the Whirling Flame to stop
 The fiery geyser, from Mount Yaanek born
 In polar climes, than there, with love or threats
 Attempt to reason with the raging Lest
 For there he cursed the Gods and all their works
 And with revenge alone, his mind obsessed
 And Ilass wept to see her ward and care
 In this condition, so she turned, distraught
 To Aeon, who knew cures for every woe
 Thus Lest, in chains, to Ennabruk was brought
 They set out for that many-towered heaven
 On the same day Lest reached the age of seven
 Their ship of solid ebony was carved
 The towering sails were laced with threaded gold
 Early one winter morning they embarked
 With Lest, in chains, imprisoned in the hold
 Ilass sat by his side during nights and storms
 'Til late one night, his threats and curses ceased
 His sister then rejoiced, and vainly thought
 His awful madness (and her fears) released
 Lest feigned a sickness; Ilass by his side
 Tended him, and forgot his evil ways
 Through all the journey through the Gaeos Strait
 She never left his side, for seven days
 Then Lest began to speak of many things
 Of Natural Science, and of Love and Hate
 Philosophy, and Ethics, Truth, and Lies
 The two for days engaged in their debate
 For days they talked, and ever Lest increased
 The evil and the boldness of his lies

But Ilass found she could not turn away
 Her brother held her, with his yellow eyes
 There, in the Strait that feeds the Central Sea
 Through will and weakness Lest possessed the mind
 Of his poor sister - with his glowing eyes
 He showed and brought to pass what Fate designed
 He spoke seducing maxims, seeming-fair
 That cloaked and covered up a villainous core
 To turn from light the minds of all who hear
 Erasing all the love they knew before:
 When times are tough, to keep your word
 Refusing gain, is quite absurd
 A Friend is one who you can use
 The Friendship of the Weak refuse
 Those souls that peace and comfort seek
 Renounce war but since they are weak
 Life's Beauty, an idea abstruse
 Is foolish - we the wise love Use
 Love is a Sin, and only Lust
 The Gods and Men are naught but Dust
 Look not into the sterile past
 No creed or hope or realm can last
 To love thyself is foolish pride
 For you are Dust, and naught beside
 Seek not for Knowledge, lest it be
 A Fact with which you don't agree
 Evil is Earth, and all things in it
 Our paltry lives last but a minute
 From Truth and Beauty turn aside
 Eschew as evil Self and Pride
 All this Lest said, 'til hypnotized at last
 Ilass released him from the heavy chains
 And thus they spoke of plans, and schemes, and plots
 To overthrow the Faldian powers' reigns
 In Ennabruk, the towered town on high
 The gods were waiting for the chance to see
 Fair Elwynn, who had promised to arrive
 And meet with her extended family
 Laguna, Aeon, and the Irdian gods
 Received her in a many-pillared hall
 And in the midst was Paragon's crystal throne
 Where sat the Empress, looking over all
 Each pillar of the clearest quartz was hewn

And clearest glass were every wall and door
 The sky, with stars by night and clouds by day
 Reflected in the mirror upon the floor
 Lofty above the Earth the chamber stood
 So those who dwelt their might their works behold
 Their backs unto this vista were the thrones
 Of all the gods; inlaid with pearl and gold
 Now Utas entered, through the Western door
 And little Elwynn hung upon his hand
 Her dress of silver filament was sewn
 Her hair was knotted with a silver band
 And even Leaigh, molder of the moon
 Bowed in admittance of superior art
 And all the Irdia wondered and amazed
 Yea, e'en Ulcharam, with his icy heart
 But from the Eastern door, old Ilass came
 And by her hand the awful Lest she led
 Into the mighty Chamber of the Gods
 He barely looked, and sneering, turned and said:
 I am the Chosen, the Child of Fate
 I am here your dominion to end
 With Fire, with Darkness, with Anger and Hate
 Your Thrones and your Chamber to rend
 I am the Nightfall, and I will prevail
 As surely as Dusk follows Day
 Surrender! Your might is predestined to fail
 If you use it to force me away!
 Then Ilass shot a line of Whirling Fire
 Into the center, at the Crystal Throne
 Like Meteors from Perseus it struck
 The rock began to vibrate and to moan
 The gods their danger then at last beheld
 And mighty fireballs from their fingers blazed
 But though they melted Roof and Thrones and Floor
 There Lest and Ilass stood, unharmed, unfazed
 Utas a silver javelin threw
 And right around the world it flew
 And from the back, at lightning speed
 It struck Lest's leg - he paid no heed.
 Aeon, though far advanced in years
 In his two hands picked up two spears
 And threw them at his rivals two
 They picked up speed, their path was true

Transformed to comets in the air
 They missed Lest's head (but singed his hair)
 Then Ilass summoned from the deep
 Where many ancient creatures sleep
 A serpent - when its head it reared
 Its crest the cloudy covering cleared
 And unto Ennabruk reached in rage
 But with a strength belying age
 Aeon a mighty axe updrew
 And there the awful dragon slew
 Now, from all corners of the sky
 A cloud of bats was seen to fly
 And turned to black its azure blue
 To Ennabruk with rage they flew
 But Utas, with his strength restored
 A mighty drove of hawks conjured
 I need not tell of every ploy
 Tried by the gods, and little boy
 Suffice to say that sea and air
 And earth and fire all were there
 And all in awful war employed
 Until the world was near destroyed
 The world all scorched, and neither side
 Had conquered all, or turned the tide
 When through a cloud of fire and dust and light
 Both Good and Evil caught each other's sight
 And there, by their doom and their future compelled
 Through the light and the dust and the fire
 Both Elwynn and Lest one another beheld
 And their hearts were consumed with desire
 And forsaking the battle, they turned and they ran
 To the center to meet find another
 Thus the world would have ended before it began
 Had the two not been stopped by their brother
 For Utas, through the fire and light and dust
 The frantic meeting of the two espied
 Remembering the prophecy at last
 He flames and monsters and his death defied
 Into the midst of all the war he ran
 Snatched Elwynn, just ere Lest could do the same
 He tried to flee, but tripped upon the Throne
 And fell upon the crystal, hurt and lame
 Elwynn escaped, but Aeon, just in time

Grabbed her, and spirited to far away
 The land of Calaspir, his ancient home
 Another plane, which this one underlay
 Then Lest was struck with rage; his eyes of fire
 Turned unto where the fallen Utas lay
 But good Laguna, Mother of Us All
 Ran in between, and blocked the child's way
 But Lest was burning with an inner flame
 He raised his hand, and thrusting at the sky
 He lightning called; the Whirling Fire came
 And struck the Mother Goddess in the eye
 Her eye burst into flame. Then, driven mad
 By grief and shock, but most of all by pain
 She blindly ran at Lest-the little god
 Just stepped aside, and viewed her with disdain
 "Seek Calaspir!" cried Utas. "Mother, fly!
 You cannot fight! Get to another plane!
 My death will buy you time! Escape! Go! Fly!
 My death must come! Let it not be in vain!"
 And through the haze of shock and grief and pain
 Some remnant of Laguna's mind took heed
 And in a flash, she left our Time and Space
 And fled to Aeon in her dire need
 Now only Lest and Utas there remained
 The others having died, or flown, or fled
 Lest viewed his fallen rival with a smile
 Raised high his sword, but paused a while, and said:
 O Utas! My brother! You fight very well
 But all of your fighting is vain
 No courage, no valor, no power, no spell
 No flight to an alternate plane
 Can ever turn back the ineffable tide
 Toward Entropy, Chaos, and Hate
 You fight well, but you'll lose, for you're on the wrong side
 Thus I say, and I quote out of Fate
 But Utas, staring in the face of Death
 Responded ere he gave his final breath
 "O Child! O Dark One! O Ennabruk's Bane!
 All this that you tell me is true
 But the stars still revolve, and the sun comes again
 And the morning arrives with the dew
 And while one drop of beauty is left on the Earth
 And ere Fate's final chapter is done

I will fight ever on, and, whatever its worth
 In the fighting, my battle is won"
 And a light, like to fire, within his eyes gleamed
 And he spoke - no- he sang - to his foe
 "In the things of the World there are Powers Undreamed"
 And his eyes, and his crown, seemed to glow
 "The World is a Story, and Stories have Ends"
 He continued to say and to sing
 "But as art, it endures, and its beauty, transcends
 Chaos, Hate, Evil, Time, Everything"
 "First came the sea on the shore of the world
 Then came the Mother of All
 Then Mandorallen, with standard unfurled
 Then Ilass, who fell in the Fall
 Last came the Orchids that sealed the world's fate
 Long ere the first isle e'er rose
 That seal the Great Book when they touch and they mate
 And bring all of our tales to a close"
 Then, like a falling meteor strikes the plain
 Lest threw his sword into his fallen foe
 But lo! As the blade touched, he disappeared
 And where he lies or dwelleth, none can tell.
 Well, that's the tale - I haven't reached its end
 But, you could say, the end of the beginning
 The sun is high above the sand and waves
 The mists and fogs that cloud the moors are thinning
 Behold the marsh, the forest, and the sky!
 Enlightened by the sun! Bask in each ray!
 'Till fate, like me, grows weary and decides
 Like me, to rest, until another day.

FINIS

Sun bless, Earth keep
 Ard-Baron Aedh-Eoin I of the United Baronies

THE SECOND BOOK OF THE ORCHIDS

This is Part II of the Book of the Orchids. It details the gods' counterattack on the forces of evil, the birth and rise of Mandorallen, and the Judgment of Men and Beasts. Because of time/space constraints, the judgment of Yetal and Ilass will be reserved for the next book.

The Second Book of the Orchids Secunda Liber Florae

First came the sea on the shore of the world
 Then came the Mother of All
 Then Mandorallen with standard unfurled
 And Ilass, who fell in the fall
 Last came the Orchids, that sealed the world's fate
 Long before the first isle e'er rose
 Which will seal shut the book when they touch and they mate
 And bring all of our tales to a close
 But the close is not yet, and there's much to be said
 'Ere the crack of that ultimate doom
 All the deeds of the heroes, both living and dead -
 And the words upon Utas's tomb
 Tie together the stories, and lead to these tales
 On through chapters, suffus'd with light
 Doomed to darkness, no doubt, but at least ere it fails
 It'll put up a heck of a fight
 Once again the sun rises, and Tineon's charge
 Lifts the spirit of Earth with its rays
 Glowing fiery and red o'er the swamp's misty marge
 As it's glowed for its millions of days
 Like a hand, its rays beckon for tales to be told
 And my mind's full of stories to tell
 Tales of war and renown in the ages of old
 That tie into the present, as well
 Where was I? My course on the river of Time
 Has always a penchant to stray
 When one sings of a matter so strange and sublime
 It can scarcely be fit in a day
 I believe when I stopped all the gods that remained
 Unto Calaspir's plane had ascended
 Having fled from their home when their dominance waned
 And I now shall begin where I ended:
 When the last of the gods from their tragic defeat
 Had discovered the alternate plane

In the great hall of Aeon they gather and meet
 And see who of their number remain
 With the Timelord presiding, they call on their band
 Asking each god his presence to show
 That the size of their loss they might then understand
 And assess the extend of their woe
 First Tineon Firelord spoke of his flight
 From his fiery forge in the sky
 He departed the world, which was then left in night
 And to Tirlar besieged hoped to fly
 But he heard a great cry from that ill-fated land
 And the voice of his brother call "Flee!"
 But was ready, when needed, to help make a stand
 And recapture the lost victory
 His story was mirrored by the Shaper of Seas
 And by She who sends clouds through the sky
 And by Salio Gemsmith, who loudly decrees
 "I am ready to fight and to die
 If but I can strike with a well-deserved blow
 At the horrible sinister heart
 Who in battle to beautiful Tirlar would go
 And defile the core of our art!"
 Thus the Irdia spoke with one voice and propose
 To return with the cloak of surprise
 To descend unexpected, and slaughter their foes
 'Ere the blood of the last battle dries
 But Aeon the Timelord here quiets their call
 And declares that no war will take place
 'Ere his census was done, and had knowledge of all
 Who were left of the heavenly race
 The Irbegdia now make their company known
 And the brood of Rianna, the Stars
 But of those of Laguna, fair Celen alone
 Has escaped with the gods from the wars
 Onton and Osik are not to be seen
 Nor are Annor and Anira found
 And they mourn for the loss of the line of the Queen
 And tears, shock, and wailing abound
 At the thought of Laguna all faces arise
 But alas! She is not in the hall
 And Aeon stands up, but does not meet their eyes
 But he stares at the floor and the wall
 At last, he reveals "It is not as you fear

The Mother of All is not dead
 But I bear with me news you will not want to hear
 But I think that it has to be said
 Alas! In the chaos and slaughter of war
 Laguna was pierced through the eye
 By a razor sharp spear-point, and never before
 Has the world heard the like of her cry
 And I cried to her servants: 'Fly! Bear her away!
 Ere fierce Lest deals a finishing blow!'

Here I found her unharmed, but her tale and her way
 To my fortress I yet do not know."
 Thus Aeon the Timelord concluded his speech
 And far-seeing Ardescit rose
 "It is I, and one other, he thus did beseech
 To rescue the god from her foes

I am Ardescit Soundsenser, brought here by fate
 Named Gardexscatilbisc (friends call me Gar)
 With permission from Aeon, I now will relate
 How Laguna was brought from afar
 Now two hath Laguna as servants and friends
 Myself, and a colleague called S'n
 I hear every sound, to the Earth's very ends
 He sees all beneath sun, Stars, and moon
 Now together we brought Her to Ennabruk's side
 And looked off, at Carama's bright bay
 When myself and my colleague ('tis strange to confide)
 Spent hours debating the way
 I was chanting the Spell that would open the Door
 To the Castle and Keep far away
 But old S'n dared to question the depth of my lore
 And corrected each word I would say
 Every sigil I wrote in the fire-filled air
 He erased, and a variant drew
 Every rune that I carved on the stony ground there
 He would cancel, and carve it anew
 Twice an hour we sat there, debating the path
 'Til our charge gave a piteous groan
 And the sound lit within me a fire of wrath
 And I knew then what had to be done
 I looked on my colleague, still scratching the ground
 And rewriting a well-written rune
 I know not where the courage to do it I found
 But I turned, and spoke thusly to S'n:

"I cast ye from Tirlar! Yea, you and your breed!
 The Witch and the Child and the rest!
 You abandoned Laguna in all of her need
 You are loyal to Ilass and Lest!"
 Then I summoned my strength and I gave a great shove
 There, where Tirlar gives way to the skies
 Down he fell, 'til his screams left my ears far above
 And his aspect was lost to my eyes
 And I trembled, but trembling completed the spell
 And opened the Door to the Keep
 And departed with speed from that Heaven turned Hell
 With Laguna, still fevered in sleep"
 Thus Ardescit Soundsenser finished his tale
 And the gods thought the story appalling
 And some asked to know more, and demanded detail
 But Aeon went on in his calling
 Now Elwynn was called and (praise be to the Powers!)
 She was safe in that far away hall
 By the Timelord snatched up from the City of Towers
 Next did Mordicc respond to the call
 Now Carding and Baccostaab made their flight known
 And others, the friends of the gods
 Who by Aeon's swift servants had lately been shown
 The way to his far-off abodes
 But where one of the gods was accustomed to sit
 There was no god or man to be found
 And some who were present were baffled by it
 And thus vainly they looked round and round
 But the Timelord was sad, and his aspect was grave
 As he gazed at lost Utas' seat
 And though all looked untowards him in all the great clave
 There was no one whose gaze he would meet
 Then spoke Carding: "Alas! For that seat nevermore
 With our brother and friend shall be filled
 In the clashing of arms and the tumult of war
 The brave Utas collapsed and was killed
 And an hour may come when our pain-stricken hearts
 Have the leisure to sit and to grieve
 But now I propose to set forth from these parts
 And make terrible war, given leave
 And every great god, with a single voice cried
 "Let us go! Let us go to the wars!
 Let not our desired revenge be denied

Let us go! Ere time closes our scars!
 Let us go! Let us go in late Utas' name!
 In the name of the Mother of All!
 And do deeds, to be ever remembered by Fame
 Let us go! We can no longer stall!
 And they all rose at once, and they reached for their arms
 For their spears and their daggers and swords
 And their rune-inscribed talismans, magicks, and charms
 And the standards were raised by the lords
 But Aeon the Timelord remained in his chair
 And he beckoned for all to stand tight
 And he asked for a night and a day to prepare
 And to get into shape for the fight
 Now the others were filled with a smoldering rage
 And they barely obeyed the command
 And some murmured to leave him there, due to his age
 And a number continued to stand
 But the Timelord arose, and he went through a door
 Rune-inlaid, at the end of the hall
 'Twas exceedingly strange - for a moment before
 There had not been a door there at all
 And behold, as he entered, the door disappeared
 And the others were struck with affright
 At the loss of their lord in a manner so weird
 And they look for a day and a night
 Yea, for all of a night and a day did they look
 Every hall, every room - every stone
 Every passage and door, every cranny and nook
 But old Aeon the Timelord was gone
 Yea, they looked, and in looking despaired, but at last
 At the hour appointed by fate
 When a day and night over Calaspir passed
 Ancient Aeon returned through his gate
 And his face had the aspect of wizards who gaze
 Unhealthily long at the sun
 'Till their eyes become blinded by Tineon's rays
 Which most mortals dare not look upon
 His wrinkled old flesh had an aspect so pale
 That all wondered what ghosts he had seen
 His legs, which had always been trembling and frail
 Were more weak than they ever had been
 And from all of the gods there assembled there came
 A wail of impotent despair

And their hopes to their powers and towers reclaim
 Melted down, and dissolved into air
 Thus their anguish-but wait! From the rune-inlaid gate
 To wherever old Aeon had been
 Came a pounding of footsteps (O strange to relate)
 That made echoes off chambers within
 And a form high and mighty began to take shape
 Like to Aeon, but hardly the same
 And the gods, their eyes wide, and their mouths all agape
 Stared in awe at the form as it came
 He was covered in mail, from his head to his toe
 Neither copper nor iron nor steel
 But the purest of adamant, forged long ago
 'Ere the thoughts of the gods were made real
 In his right was a sword wrought with infinite care
 So its sides formed an apex so sharp
 That the sound that it made when it flew through the air
 Was like strings softly plucked on a harp
 In his left was a shield with a blazing device
 Of a tower set high on a hill
 And a great bolt of lightning curled round it thrice
 And a sentence of runes, writ with skill
 Said "Behold! This is Ennabruk! Look at it shake!
 As it never has shaken before!
 Its legitimate master has come to retake
 Its high towers through terrible war!"
 And they shook, yea, they shook - and so shook the whole world
 At a prophecy cast and fulfilled
 For here stood Mandorallen with standard unfurled
 After Utas and hope had been killed
 After powers and towers in fallen from high
 After cities' and deities' ends
 Now the Power Undreamed from the Infinite sky
 At long last its great champion sends
 Now the armies of Calaspier gather together
 In a courtyard outside the great hall
 And they shown with a power divine; I doubt whether
 Any force could withstand them at all
 For the Irdia, Faldia, servants, and guards
 Were assembled, with Elwynn there too
 For a battle so great that the poets and bards
 Sing it still - as I now will to you
 Now the Earth-Goddess Salio forged from the stone

A great isle that floated in air
 And could hold the whole army, and move on it's own
 In an hour, it flew them all there
 And it rammed into Ennabruk, making a sound
 That echoed through infinite space
 And the hosts disembarked, and prepared to surround
 The whole town, and encircle the place
 From the towers within came the armies of Lest
 And cursed Ilass herself took the lead
 By her right hand stood Yetal, supporting her crest
 All alone, shunned by e'en his own breed
 And the ranks were of demons - from some starless pit
 They were called by their master - and came
 And dark creatures from lands that the sun never lit
 Without shape, without speech, without name
 As they swarmed from their barracks, exuding with hate
 Mandorallen broke rank from his host
 And stood like a mountain, unspeakably great
 And he called to his rivals this boast
 "Come one from your number, come any who may
 Let us settle this quarrel alone
 Let a combat of champions determine the day
 And make vanquished and conqueror known"
 But none from their number would go on ahead
 And do battle with Aeon's strange son
 And the ranks of the Dark One first shuddered, then broke
 And it seemed that the battle was won
 When out of the tower, a form draped in black
 Came to answer the champion's call
 And in terror, the dark armies all slithered back
 Lest their general punish them all
 He was shrouded in darkness, from head unto toe
 Neither fabric, illusion, nor spell
 But the blackness that came from the Void long ago
 Ling'ring still in the dark pits of Hell
 His right hand held a mace strewn with prickles so cruel
 That the air fled before them in fright
 And they clanged as their master came forth to the duel
 In his raiments of Stygian night
 But while the Bright Champion awaited his foe
 And with iron grip clutched to his sword
 The great Paradox, born from the Void long ago
 And the Ending that Fate had assured

Leapt again to the forestage, and Elwynn leapt out
 Of the ranks of the armies of light
 And from all of the warriors came forth a great shout
 As she ran toward the Child of Night
 Now the Champion started, and ran toward the child
 And the armies unraveled in fear
 And with fear of the Doomsday dread driven wild
 Massive chaos and tumult appear
 But at last Mandorallen, as fast as the stars
 When they fail and fall down from the sky
 Attained her; and there, in the midst of the wars
 Stood silent, and held her up high
 Then Carding, the Loremaster, fastened a spell
 Out of things he had brought for this need
 A black powder, ground out of the pillars of Hell
 Crystal sphere, comet hair, mandrake seed
 After chants, invocations, and wonderful song
 On the tip of his wand came a fire
 Long he sang, and the flames grew unbearably long
 And so hot, they gleamed blue like sapphire
 "BY THE POWERS UNDREAMED, LET IT BE!" he then yelled
 And the fire waxed high and burned bright
 Then collapsed to a spark, which the wand then expelled
 Toward the struggling Child of Light
 With a final convulsion, her struggling form
 Was engulfed by the radiant power
 For a second, there thundered the fiery storm
 Then subsided, revealing a flower
 Yea - where Elwynn had been, there was naught to be seen
 But an orchid - the first, long ago
 Its leaves were a vibrant and pulsating green
 With one flower in bloom, white as snow
 Yea - the first of the orchids, to seal the world's fate
 Although flowery and snowy and pure
 It would seal shut the book - it would join and would mate
 And then nothing could hope to endure
 But her brother was filled with a terrible wrath
 And he ran through the ranks of his host
 With his mace and his spells he created a path
 To respond to his enemy's boast
 Mandorallen's sharp sword glowed with light like a wand
 Like a firefly flits through the brake
 And the cruel mace of Lest, in its haste to respond

Made the Earth and the Universe quake
 Then the battle begun, and I shudder to tell
 Of the strength and the wrath of the Two
 Of their frenzy, that nothing but murder could quell
 Of the blows that their weaponry blew
 Of the clash their debate sent to Earth down below
 Of the skill of the warriors' style
 Of the wonder and fear that the horrible row
 Made the spectators feel all the while
 But at last Mandorallen, that newly-born Lord
 Of the battle and all of its skill
 With his adamant shell and his adamant sword
 Gained a hold, and moved in for the kill
 And he struck the cruel mace from the Dark Child's hands
 Thus completely disarming his foe
 And it flew out of Heaven, and fell to the lands
 Of the desolate Earth, far below
 Then he held Lest aloft, and he turned to the god
 Who kept the mysterious Way
 And Carding, the Loremaster, gave him a nod
 There was nothing he needed to say
 For Fate had decreed, 'ere the battle begun
 What the Mage was determined to do
 And the spell which a moment before he had done
 He prepared to accomplish anew
 Once again through the air shot a fiery line
 From the wand in the hand of the god
 Once again a great flame and a radiance divine
 Spiraled forth from the rune-studded rod
 Once again, where a god and a child had been
 There, in front of the gods' highest tower
 In full baleful bloom grew by all to be seen
 An unmoving, but dire black flower
 Then the forces of Lest with a singular groan
 Fled wherever the vanquished could flee
 Some fell over the edge and were crushed on hard stone
 And still others flew into the sea
 The battalions of monsters, so doleful and proud
 Just a couple of moments before
 Had finished the span that their fates had allowed
 And could trouble the races no more
 Then the gods in their triumph marched into the town
 And into the innermost tower

And the Champion mounted the high Crystal Throne
 And all Ennabruk throbbed with his power
 And the Irdia and Faldia retook their abodes
 And then gathered together again
 "Hail the great Mandorallen, the King of the Gods!"
 They exclaimed. "Powers bless him! Amen!"
 But alone on his throne the high War-Captain sate
 Many matters revolved in his mind
 The traitors, who joined with the Child of Fate
 And the cowards, remaining behind
 So he took off his armor, his helmet, his shield
 Donning robes of a judge in their places
 And abandoned his weapon, the gavel to wield
 And prepared to give Law to the races
 First Anton and Anira before him were called
 All the gods had been sure they were dead
 When they learned the real truth, they were yet more appalled
 They had joined with the Dark One instead
 Mandorallen judged thus: for the horrible crime
 Of deserting their land and their birth
 They were stripped of their minds and their spirits sublime
 And were sent down below to the Earth
 Before the throne Onton and Osik were beckoned
 They had never selected a side
 But their crime was still great (so the Champion reckoned)
 For the their failure to rightly decide
 He banished them Earthward, to never behold
 Evermore the bright town in the sky
 And he doomed them to wither away and grow old
 And 'ere even a century, die
 But Laguna, the pity-filled Mother of All
 (Despite all, she continued to trust us)
 With a kiss, blessed all her children, in spite of their Fall
 And seasoned with mercy dire justice
 For she swore that our banishment someday would end
 And our chains to the Earth would dis sever
 And the soul, after death, would to Tirlar ascend
 And would dwell with Laguna forever
 Thus, the blessing and curse of far-fallen mankind
 Were doled out in equivalent shares
 Thus our portion was blessed with an undying Mind
 And was stricken with infinite cares
 Thus Laguna gave hope to her unworthy brood

After Mandorel took it away
Thus the Gods temper even their curses with good
Whether blessing or curse - who can say?
Not I - I've said enough, as I'm sure you'll agree
And my voice is beginning to go
I'm afraid any more of this singing would be
Like the Fall I've just told - cause for woe
So I'll leave you to wonder on Heaven and Death
And the Wisdom that reigneth above
Which can damn us, and then, in the very next breath
Can redeem us with heavenly love

FINIS

Sun bless, Earth keep
Ard-Baron Aedh-Eoin I of the United Baronies

THE THIRD BOOK OF THE ORCHIDS

The Third Book of the Orchids
Tertia Liber Florae

First came the sea on the shore of the world
Then came the Mother of All
Then Mandorallen with banner unfurled
Then Ilass, who fell in the Fall
Last came the Orchids, that sealed the world's fate
Long before the first Isle e'er rose
Which will seal the Book shut when they join and they mate
And bring all of our tales to a close
For the world's dread Creators, the Powers Undreamed
With their knowledge arcane fixed a date
The last day, the last hour, the last instant they deemed
And they bound it in ironclad Fate
Thus they sent us two Orchids in full baleful bloom
Even 'ere the first Isle arose
Two Orchids, as signs of implacable Doom
And the Story's eventual close
But the minds of the Gods and the minds of the Races
Still look at the World day by day
Seeing only the matters in front of their faces
Not the waves poised to sweep them away
But to each his Dominion, as part of the Plan
Whatsoe'er that Dominion may be
Whether Irdia, Faldia, Kwendia, or Man
Down to null, up to Infinity
Could we travel the world and explore its great frame
Like a spirit, unbounded and free
Many awesome and wonderful things without name
Would our eyes, and our spirit-eyes see
But alas! We are mortal, to Time and Space bound
And unable to break or compel it
So who looks for that world which Time's current has drowned
Must sit still, for I now plan to tell it
I shall start where I ended: the Races cast down
Out of Tirbal, which hung in the sky
To the cloud-girdled Earth out of anger were thrown
And were doomed by the Just One to die
But the wrath of the Champion would not be appeased
Until Ilass was punished as well

So the Witch, bound in Chains, Mandorallen then seized
 And he threw her, still wailing, to Hell
 Her brother, the Dark One, called Ennabruk's Bane
 In like manner he hurled from above
 With a whistle and wail like a creature in pain
 Through the air and the bedrock he dove
 To a cavern, the Pit, all surrounded by fire
 Where he stood by his sister and nursed
 His anger, his hatred, his darksome desire
 And shouted, and boiled, and cursed
 Then Yetal, forsaken by friend and by foe
 Was cast down to Ifreann as well
 But he snagged in a tree on the world down below
 And escaped his confinement in Hell
 O Powers! What blights come from such little chances!
 What holocausts cover the Earth!
 What history happens from such happenstances!
 To what fiends can Chance not give birth?
 For Yetal, in wandering, found what he sought
 His brother and leader, foul Sun
 Who had also been exiled Earthward when caught
 At the plot he so vilely begun
 And the two swore an oath to avenge their lost lord
 On the innocent children of Men
 And they plotted, by evil, by fire and sword
 To wage war with their betters again
 Now these humans, unknowing, had made their abode
 In the Rainors, a region so fair
 That they never went cold, and a breeze always flowed
 And brought tinges of salt to the air
 They did not know of fire, they had not the need
 Nor of hunting, nor farming: so good
 Was the land that without even planting a seed
 Glist'ning trees would burst forth bearing food
 Then Carding, the Wise One, arrived from above
 Bearing teachings in science and art
 And he taught the men goodness, and mutual love
 And to always hold God in their heart
 And the people formed nations, with chieftains and laws
 But they always were righteous and just
 And there never was strife or rebellion because
 They ruled well, and were worthy of trust
 After years had gone by, some departed by sea

For new regions to claim and explore
 Thus the Race was divided, no longer to be
 Confined to but one lonely shore
 And Uisceor laid open the lengths of the deep
 Even Gaothar held back her storms
 And from isle to isle the voyagers leap
 First in bands, then in droves, then in swarms
 To Tapfer, the Haven from storm and from wave
 To Audentior, chosen by Fate
 To Shireroth, land of the warlike and brave
 To Alteria, braving the Strait
 To Babkha, where Shahs might in later days reign
 To Norfolk, commanding the ocean
 To Yardistan, land of the gravely insane
 To Lyrica, loud with commotion
 South of Goldshire's gold mines an island chain lay
 Standing high in the watery brine
 Called Asmodea then and Khaz Modan today
 Richly blessed by the powers divine
 It was settled by mariners, hardly and brave
 Sons of Lochrin, begot by the storm
 Who were masters of current and weather and wave
 In each fearful and terrible form
 These men formed a kingdom; among them they hailed
 Their bravest as captain and king
 After many an eon the royal line failed
 And they prayed that the currents might bring
 A new ruler to take their unoccupied throne
 And restore them to glories of old
 That Uisceor might bring, from a region unknown
 A new monarch, their scepter to hold
 A god heard their prayer but 'twas not who they thought
 Not the Old One who dwells in the Deep
 But the foul Lord of Demons, whose eyes closeth not
 And refuse the cool nights gift of sleep
 And he summoned a draken to bear him away
 A draken with fiery eyes
 And when Ulcharam's veil overpowered the day
 He took Yetal and fled through the skies
 North the Vardia flew 'til at last he arrived
 Where the people assembled in prayer
 And by means of his spells and his magic contrived
 To be hailed as their king then and there

And he forged out an empire with steel and with power
 'Til the islands came under his sway
 The inhabitants call him a despot and cower
 But Sun sends the armies away
 First is Mirioth conquered; the fairest of lands
 Is the first to be lost in the wars
 Then more earth and more ocean is lost to their hands
 Wide Amity, gate to the stars
 The gold mines of Goldshire, open and gleaming
 Florenca, land of the vine
 For the dark Lord of Demons was secretly dreaming
 That all Earth might embrace his design
 But the gods' shining champion saw and took heed
 At the conquest and wars down below
 And he realized the depth of his children's great need
 And to Salio Gemsmith did go
 And he ordered four jewels, with high magic imbued
 Four jewels, to be set in four swords
 Four swords, for four heroes to use in the feud
 Four heroes, to serve their four lords
 The Sword of the Stormrider, flickering and wild
 Its heart spouting tongues of blue flame
 But the emerald-set sword was as gentle and mild
 As the breezes that gave it its name
 The sharp Sword of August, as scorchingly hot
 As the thunderstorms spawned south of Breigh
 And the Einlanzer Lightblade, within which was caught
 The glow of a bright summer day
 To the cardinal points the four weapons were given
 But since force cannot conquer alone
 The Microns, the race that remained high in Heaven
 When their kin to the planet were thrown
 Inspired by love for their sisters and brothers
 Elected to travel below
 That they might share their teaching and lore with the others
 And the gods gave permission to go
 Great ships they prepared, out of planks strong and oaken
 And the sails were of gossamer strands
 But were so tightly bound they might never be broken
 In their flight through the Winds to the Lands
 Like birds or like dragons they dreamed they might glide
 Through the cloud-studded oceans of sky
 'Til they came to a storm-wind or current to ride

So they bid hanging Tirbal goodbye
 Alas for the race who abandoned their youth!
 They are doomed to return nevermore
 For the Powers have coded this unyielding truth:
 None can ever go back to before
 What lunatic, given his will or free choice
 Would from even the cradle depart?
 And would any but moon-stricken madmen rejoice
 To dissever a piece of their heart?
 Twelve ships had the Microns, twelve cities to found
 And the first one to finish its trip
 On an isle near Tapfer touched down on the ground
 And they joyfully flew off the ship
 There they founded their capital, Ptia by name
 The world and the races to guard
 With its sisters eleven, their purpose the same
 To keep, and to care, and to ward
 But the demons attacked in the Great Micron War
 And its hero, both youthful and bold
 Was King Istvan the Second, and never before
 Was such valor in monarchs of old
 Nor so mighty a talisman, valor to aid
 For the Storm-Rider's Sword graced his hands
 And the battles he fought, and the allies he made
 Were the hope of the Races and Lands
 But valor and goodness are destined to fail
 When a Vardia serves as your foe
 They meet mercy with cruelty and truth with betrayal
 And honor with darkness and woe
 The demons drove forward the Microns fell back
 And a siege was on Vladagrad laid
 But Ptia was lost in a nightly attack
 And its towers were never remade
 Old Aeon says: Blessed are those who are down
 For they have not much further to fall
 Istvan took this to heart while defending his town
 And stood firm on the towering wall
 And he screamed his defiance against those dark hosts
 And he summoned dark hosts of his own
 With the Call of the Stormrider, raised up the ghosts
 That his armies might not fight alone
 Thus the towns of the Microns were torched and were torn
 But Vladagrad stood tall and proud

So the Khaz Modan forces, in battle outworn
 Find the hero can never be cowed
 So they change their direction; turn round and march forth
 To less steadfast and civilized lands
 To Goldshire's gold mines, which lie in the north
 Where the city of Musica stands
 Nay, it stood not for long, but by demons it fell
 And with it, the whole southern coast
 And when Elwynn was seized by the hordes out of Hell
 Then the whole western region was lost
 And they sought, by the strait in the Northland to break
 A passage, to reach eastern sands
 And go south once again, and a circle to make
 For the doom of the Circle of Lands
 Then Salio pierced to the Earth's fiery core
 And five plumes of fire-rock rise
 And they bubble and reach toward the sea's oozing floor
 Then touch air, and break into the skies
 Five Isles, as Shields, pushing backward the death
 Of Tirlar, reversing its loss
 The long-lasting Treesia, the westernmost Reath
 Awful Shleg, royal Ahans, and Khas
 The Five Isles! Their men mighty, valiant, and proud!
 The best Tirlar ever gave birth!
 No wonder their glory was not long allowed
 To remain on the cloud-shaded Earth!
 No wonder the fates had to see them destroyed
 Lest their men become gods in their might!
 For if Ahans the reign of all Tirlar enjoyed
 It might blind the whole world with its light!
 From the ends of the Earth mighty Mandorel sought them
 His worshippers, champions, and friends
 Unto Ahans, the City of Royals he brought them
 He himself to the capital descends
 To serve in the ritual of crowning the King
 Larn, the Blackrocker prince, is selected
 And the hymns and the songs round the citadel ring
 To the palace (which Salio erected)
 Then was started the war that might redefine war
 Whole Isles made bare and laid waste
 Made Earth shake as it never had shaken before
 And the bright face of Tirlar defaced
 The champions of Tirlar! The chosen of Hell!

How the hills with their battle resound
 How each mountain and valley and sea-coast and dell
 Is with smoke, fire, and sorcery crowned
 But in war, as in peace, one could hardly expect
 That a Demon would trust things to Fate
 And would match swords in honor, nor try to affect
 Its conclusion with secreted weight
 Thus Sun sent out a Demon, in shades and disguise
 To infiltrate the lands of his foes
 Not only their tactics and strength to apprise
 But to join them, their plans to oppose
 The Demon Demerfin on storm-clouds was sent
 And presented himself to the court
 As a friend, though a demon, one led to repent
 And who burned with desire to thwart
 The plots of his brothers, and thus he requested
 Some post in defense of the land
 And the king, all too trusting, naively suggested
 He be given the highest command
 Thus, their leader a Demon, the Islanders' luck
 Reached a sudden, unfortunate end
 All their strategy failed, and their plans went amuck
 Their defensive lines ceased to defend
 First Khas and then Shleg were by Khaz Modan taken
 And Treesia tottered to fall
 And Larn thought himself by the Champion forsaken
 And feared for the end of it all
 But the bright-hearted champion forsakes not his own
 And the hero had nothing to fear
 (For Men never need fear that they struggle alone
 With the Gods always helpful and near)
 Round his warriors and worshippers Mandorel gazed
 And divided the wheat from the chaff
 Their courage he judged and their spirits he raised
 That the Isles might live and be safe
 At last in his seekings he came on a spirit
 So pious and loyal and bold
 So fiery and mighty no others came near it
 (E'en in those great Isles of Old)
 'Of all Generals, he shall be greatest and First
 A Saviour and Prophet and Guide
 All his wars ever blessed, all his foes ever cursed
 And his name known forever!' he cried

This was Refin of Reath. In a wind in a dream
 Mandorallen appeared to his chosen
 In terrible aspect, his power supreme
 Mixed with moonlight and odors ambrosian
 'Go forth, O my child, your land to defend!
 Go forth, well thou knowest the need
 Lest the gods and their handiwork come to and end
 Go forth- with gods' help, and godspeed!
 Fear and trembling seized Refin; he woke with a scream
 At the greatness of God in His Might
 Then he thought to himself: was it only a dream?
 Or a vision, my course to incite?
 But then what is a dream? Or a vision? Or thought?
 But a path, or a change, or a choice?
 Then no matter the source! I will do what I ought
 And my conscience confirms the god's voice.
 Through the wave-tortured seas and the rock-guarded costs
 He arrived at fair Ahans at last
 The City of Royals, where legend still boasts
 Of its glory in ages long past
 But then at its pinnacle roads straight and wide
 Paved with marble, and marble the hall
 Where the King and his Councillors meet and decide
 How to hold the world back from its fall
 Into such came the First, unassuming in manner
 Not copper nor iron nor steel
 His strong body enclosed; neither weapon nor banner
 Clothed but in a robe and his zeal
 'I have come' he exclaimed. 'Give me leave to defend
 My friends and my country and lord
 Lest the demon Demerfin, on whom you depend
 Wound your land, at your charge, with your sword'
 The king heard his suit with a look of amaze
 At the boldness and pluck of his mien
 For a while he faltered, his mind in a daze
 As he stared at his men and his queen
 When his wits were recovered, he gave a great laugh
 Neither nasty nor mocking, but glad
 And expressed his delight, to his nobles and staff
 At the manner of subject he had
 Then he spoke to the First, saying 'Friend, I admire
 Your devotion to sovereign and land
 But Demerfin is strong, and tis not my desire

To relieve him of rank and command
 Go off then in peace, but receive as my gift
 Any sword from my arsenals store
 Take the best - for a sovereign ought not to show thrift
 To his subjects, when valiant in war
 But as chance (or by fate- chance is merely a name
 Used when fate keeps its presence unknown)
 Demerfin, the traitor, at that hour came
 For his troops and his arms to be shown
 And he paused in the arsenal, viewing its hoard
 (His mind bent on evil and doom)
 When Refin, rejected, in search of a sword
 Eyes cast downward, came into the room
 On the belt of the demon there lay, glowing green
 The Sword of the gentle March Breeze
 As a symbol of power, by all to be seen
 One of Four, and the oldest of these
 As its emerald and steel the bold Refin admired
 It flew like a bird to his hand
 He said 'Tis the best, just as the king has desired
 And I claim it, by royal command!'

Then he thrust forth the sword at the servant of Sun
 Who countered with thrusts of his own
 Refin gasped in amaze at the deed he had done
 His hands' acts to his mind were unknown
 For 'twas not his own will that engendered the blow
 But the will of his god-fashioned sword
 Which now blazed with a brighter and purer green glow
 With, at long last, its mission restored
 The demon recovered his wits and he snatched
 Up a blade in the arsenal found
 The next blow that Refin dealt, Demerfin matched
 Clanging arms through th' armory resound
 The First watched first in horror, and later in awe
 As free from all conscious commands
 His arms moved, parried, countered- his eyes merely saw
 Foreign acts by his sword in his hands
 In anger Demerfin closed in for the kill
 He had mastered the warrior's art
 But the sword forged by Mandorel lacked not his skill
 And it flew at the general's heart
 Pierced his breast, but the demon just gave a dread grin
 For the First sought a heart there in vain

There was just coal and stone where a heart would have been
 Just putrescence and filth for a brain
 The sword wearied of stabbing, and burned emerald bright
 With the fires of Tirbal above
 'Twas not Mandorel's strength which was seen in that light
 But Laguna's all-compassing love
 It was love then that conquered, when iron had failed
 Love that won, where no battle-art could
 'Tis said Hate over Hatred has never prevailed
 You can only fight evil with good
 Thus was Demerfin conquered, and Refin in fear
 Would have fled from his murderous deed
 Had he not beheld great Mandorallen appear
 And the god o'er the palace decreed:
 'Men of Tirlar! Of Ahans! Your champion behold!
 Harm him not; he is sacred to Me
 Rather use him- his spirit is fiery and bold'
 And Larn heeded his master's decree:
 He made him his general: Refin the First
 Sailed that eve to the isle of Khas
 In a fortnight, the fortunes of war he reversed
 And inflicted on Sun a great loss
 For the men of the Isles were valiant and brave
 And their leader was pious and true
 And when fighting their land and their loved ones to save
 There is nothing such men cannot do
 Shleg too was retaken, but Refin pushed on
 Urged forth by the fire in his breast
 'Til he came to the mountainous land of Fabon
 Where the demons still held in the west
 When he landed, he fought with his foes once again
 Once again, by his courage, he won
 And in Treesia he paused, some supplies to obtain
 'Ere the next operation begun
 But Sun, Lord of Demons, upon his jet throne
 Heard news of his northern defeat
 Dread and awful he rose, and his awful eyes shone
 And he ordered his councilors to meet
 In a Council of Demons, the Isles to end -
 The Elders, the Chaos of Sark
 And all the Internals from Ifreann ascend
 And the tropical sun they make dark
 Then Sun spoke, saying- well, I don't know what he said

From the base of his dark throne of jet
 For his words, and his deeds, were so awful and dread
 Even lorekeepers sought to forget
 They expunged all the records, and burnt all the scrolls
 Ripped up every paper and book
 For too dark and too dreadful for innocent souls
 Were his words, and the actions he took
 Yet we know the results of his deed- every isle
 Each home of the valiant and proud
 Black mists and black vapors of Ifreann defile
 The period that Fate had allowed
 Was ended- the towers of Ahans might shine
 Over Folcador's seas nevermore
 Only Treesia was saved from the vapors and brine
 Saved with Refin, who stood on its shore
 But in Treesia, the First, in that one moonless night
 Went from fiery and youthful to old
 His voice became trembling, his hair became white
 And his fires grew dim and went cold
 The Enabler of Life started wishing for death
 And his soul became dark with the loss
 Of bright, kingly Ahans, of tree-speckled Reath
 Desert Shleg, and hard, rock-studded Khas
 Alas the Five Isles! Five bright points of light!
 Five jewels on the Crowning Plane's crown
 Unrivalled in beauty, unconquered in fight
 Their hope and potential unknown
 What futures were stifled? What empires unmade?
 What thousands of heroes unborn?
 What stories unwritten? What cities unlaid?
 When the darkness enclosed their bright morn?
 Woe! Woe unto Tirlar! Woe! Woe unto men!
 And woe unto Refin the First!
 The lands of the gods now defiled once again
 By Lest, and his followers accursed
 Woe! Woe unto Ennabruk! Woe to the gods
 And woe to the Races below!
 Woe! Woe to the World-Planes, the Seven Abodes
 To Tirbal and Universe- woe!
 The gods up above once agreed on a law
 Not to meddle in matters below
 But when so Cataclysmic an evil they saw
 And the Crown Plane beneath filled with woe

Wrath burnt through their fetters; the War God, appalled
 Grabbed his tripartite axe in his hands
 With a trumpet blast Tirbal's great armies he called
 To deliver the Circle of Lands
 The armies of Tirbal were gathered together
 Encased in their glittering mail
 Brimming full with the fury of war, heedless whether
 Their purpose would triumph or fail
 Just exulting in battle, rejoicing in fight
 And itching for clashing of arms
 Shining light off their armor, the Forces of Light
 Came in droves to the War-God's alarms
 Then Folcador raised up a whirlwind that bore them
 From Tirbal to Tirlar below
 Made the lightning-bolts flash as a herald before them
 And winds like to hurricanes blow
 And rainbows as banners, untouched by the wind
 And contrails to show them their way
 And great walls of stratus as vanguards behind
 That covered the sun and the day
 When Sun saw these armies he trembled in fear
 And Yetal turned pale in dismay
 For they knew at long last that their hour was near
 And their crimes bore a high price to pay
 So they rode on their draken, in haste to proceed
 In haste to shun battle and fly
 Lest the champions of Tirbal avenge their foul deed
 And thus craven, they fled through the sky
 Now the great Whip of Folcador flew round and round
 And the great Axe of Mandorel fell
 And the Fires of Tineon fell to the ground
 Where they raged like the fires of Hell
 Nor was Istvan then absent, nor Istvan's dread blade
 Nor the Microns, their goal to fulfill
 Nor the men of the East; every land ever made
 There converged, and prepared for the kill
 The fortresses fell without mounting a fight
 The armies dispersed in dismay
 The whole land was extinguished and wiped out of sight
 And was lost in a night and a day
 The high walls were ground into pebbles and stone
 The palaces fell to the ground
 Not a brick stayed on top of a brick; all were gone

And dark Ruin spread its wings all around
 Atop high Mount Medivh great Mandorel stood
 Till he spotted the demons in flight
 And he cast the spear Unis, resplendent with Good
 Its point and its shaft made of light
 It struck the great Draken that bore them away
 Right between its two fiery eyes
 A death-blow it struck as they howled in dismay
 The two demons fell down through the skies
 In the ocean they landed, but swam to the coast
 Disgraced, sopping wet, but not dead
 Men who saw them but laughed; all their power seemed lost
 And their aspect was no longer dread
 Mandorallen beheld and said 'Thus let them stay
 'Till Fate, with her knowledge arcane
 Either kills or restores them, I care not which way
 Let us now return home to our plane'
 Thus was Khaz Modan conquered by power divine
 And the Isles by power demonic
 Thus was vengeance obtained, thus did fate intertwine
 Good and evil in patterns ironic
 Thus the shaping of Tirlar in battle begun
 And in battle will Tirlar be lost
 Thus was destiny filled, thus was history run
 But alas! What was history's cost?
 The world is a story, and stories have ends
 And this book has an end of its own
 When the First, dead of grief, up to Tirbal ascends
 With the Gods, who in life he has known
 Open-armed, Mandorallen embraces his friend
 Who holds still in his pale, wrinkled hands
 The sword with the emerald, still bright to defend
 All the hopes of the Races and Lands
 Said the Champion: 'Boldly you fought, friend, and well
 That which mortals could do, you have done
 In battle you strove with the forces of Hell
 Remained pious, persisted, and won
 O, blame not yourself for the twistings of Fate!
 Rest a while, and hand over your sword
 And in Calaspier's halls future battle await
 But first, you must have a reward'
 Spoke the First: 'For myself, I can no more desire
 Then the Battle of which you have told

Let ANDAN's apocalypse relight my fire
 Let me fight, once again, as of old
 Give reward then to Treesia, the last of the Isles
 Let another arise in my place
 Let him wield my green sword, and enduring great trials
 Bring new honor to me and my race'
 'Let it be!' spoke the Champion, his eyes all alight
 'Let the Second in Treesia arise!
 And let there be Barons, unconquered in fight!
 Let their fame fill the seas and the skies!
 Let the times yet to come a new Ardeaspeg see!
 Let them see a new Ahans erected!
 And in that Golden Age of the world, let there be
 A new King of All Tirlar selected!'
 Then the Sword of the gentle March Breezes he threw
 Down from Tirbal to Tirlar below
 Through the skies for three days and three nights the blade flew
 Like a star, with a bright emerald glow
 Till it struck land in Ecosse, where dwelt a young man
 A young man with a fire in his heart
 And the emerald stone blazed with the fire of the plan
 Plans for Treesia's and Tirlar's fresh start

FINIS

Sun bless, Earth keep
 Ard-Baron Aedh-Eoin I of the United Baronies

THE FOURTH BOOK OF THE ORCHIDS

The Fourth Book of the Orchids
Quarta Liber Florae

First came the sea on the shore of the world
Then came the Mother of All
Then Mandorallen, with banners unfurled
And Ilass, who fell in the Fall
Last came the Orchids, to seal the world's fate
Even e'er the first Isle arose
To seal the book shut when they touch and they mate
And bring all of our tales to a close
Tales of seas down beneath and of skies up above
Tales of Earth, and the races therein
Tales of terrible vengeance and beautiful love
Deeds heroic, and villainous sin
Tales set only yesterday, tales that were set
Even e'er the first Isle arose
The tale I am writing; tales not written yet
All these tales will be brought to a close
Tales high and prophetic; tales low and uncouth
Tales written in prose and in verses
Tales written for pleasure, tales written for truth
Tales written of blessings and curses
Tales of wizards and warriors and nobles and priests
Shining allies, and terrible foes
Dragons, gods, demons, spirits, men, giants, and beasts
All these tales will be brought to a close
Tales set high in Tirbal, 'twixt Ennabruk's spires
Tales set in Calaspier's stone
Tales of Tirlar, and tales down in Ifreann's dark fires
Where few of the living have gone
Yea, few men have gone; and of those, only one
Has returned from the fires of Hell
In a great quest heroic this journey was done
And this is the tale I will tell
For the Tale of the Orchids is found even there
In the fires of Ifreann below
From the heights of the sky, in the rarified air
To the depths of the regions of woe
Yea, across Seven Planes is the reach of our doom
And the intricate web that will seal it

And the fuel for the fire that must someday consume
 All the world- so the Powers might heal it
 When the Five Isles sunk in those ages of old
 An era was brought to a close
 And the forge of the sun-god grew dark and went cold
 And the seas round the poles slowed and froze
 The currents betrayed their familiar path
 Harder storms flew from Folcador's hands
 And his dazzling whip cracked with heavier wrath
 On the seas, and the cold-haunted lands
 For many an age dwelt this cold o'er the world
 Nor for ages the storms ceased to blow
 In the middle of summer the frosty flakes swirled
 On Lagunafete, clouds turned to snow
 And the empires that just generations before
 Had seen leaders and warrior so bold
 And had held back dread demons in terrible war
 Were unable to hold back the cold
 In Treesia, where such wondrous deeds had occurred
 The Barons remained in their keep
 In vain do the Second's sons pray for a Third
 In vain the sagarts pray and weep
 In Tapfer, the Microns, once greatest of Races
 Are citiless, homeless, and poor
 And they wander the country, and all its dark places
 And sink into weakness and war
 In Istvanistan, woe, for King Istvan is dead
 And his sons lack his wisdom and might
 And make war not on Evil, but Tapfer instead
 And their Stormrider Sword joins the fight
 And when Salio saw her initial design
 Turned to evil and causes perverse
 Then 'til Stjepan Aracic renewed the old line
 She removed all its might with a curse
 Yea, all through the Circle of Lands, nations faltered
 And the tales of the deeds of the past
 Were sung sadly, then known of but dimly, then altered
 Then finally forgotten at last
 Alas! For when stories and legends are lost
 Then its characters die once again
 And Refin, and Istvan, and all of their host
 Are in Tirbal a second time slain
 Alas to the race that abandons their past!

Like a child whose father is lost
 They are set all adrift on a sea dark and vast
 By the winds and the waves to be tossed
 And where is the guide, who should steer and direct?
 Who should mentor and lead and console?
 Who to indicate errors, to teach and correct
 When we cut off a piece of our soul?
 For ten ages, the cold and sadness persisted
 It lay on the world like a shroud
 No creatures nor forests nor heroes resisted
 Nor empires once mighty and proud
 But all prayed up to Tirbal for warmth and relief
 And the gods, among Ennabruk's spires
 Hear their prayers and their loud lamentations of grief
 And add oils to Tineon's fires
 And like a volcano set deep in the Earth
 When Bladhm has one of her rages
 To a towering column of fire gives birth
 With the now unconfined wrath of ages
 The sun flares with warmth, and Lagunafete's frost
 Melts away to the midsummer's heat
 And Caranna restores all the trees that were lost
 And the glaciers and ice floes retreat
 And men, who for so many winters of woe
 Had abandoned their civilized ways
 To the old fallow fields and bare villages go
 And new cities and villages raise
 And they call for a Teacher, to show them the Lore
 By which a new Science may rise
 For Carding, the Wise One, who helped them before
 And made men and their empires wise
 Then the Firelord took off the crown from his head
 That glowed with the light of the Sun
 Dazzling, brilliant, and turned to the Keeper, and said
 'The New Age of the World has begun!
 Take my crown, and set off for the bright Crowning Plane
 Teach the Way, as you once did of old
 Draw together the sparks of the Light that remain
 For a Forge-Fire, Tirlar to mold!
 And Carding descended to Tirlar, arriving
 Where the Antya drains into its bay
 Where some small bands of primitives, barely surviving
 Lived life (as does each, in their way)

But when they saw Carding, his crown all alight
 With the light of the Firelord's flame
 They were driven to fear, and the watchmen took flight
 To their terrible lord, Myng by name
 This Myng was called merciless, truly barbarian
 Ev'n for his barbarian race
 His rule was steel-fisted and authoritarian
 His mind was hardhearted and base
 The ignorant natives believed him a god
 (Tho' his true gods were Yetal and Sun)
 And his fingers kept hold on a magical rod
 With which great evil deeds could be done
 Myng had first gained his power by unholy pact
 With the lords of the Vardian clan
 Who can ever weak souls unsuspecting attract
 Sun, the warlord called Markg, Yetal, Dan
 Thus he feared not the Wise One- his strength on the wax
 Was matched but by his reasonless pride
 And he thought his dread rod could withstand all attacks
 And the gods might themselves be denied
 For the demons had heard (and indeed, it was true)
 That where Antya rushed into the sea
 That the bright light of Tirbal should kindle anew
 And from thence, in all lands should burn free
 And in fear of this light, and to hold back this fire
 They set Myng as the king of this land
 To imprison this chance in chains awful and dire
 So that freedom and hope might be banned
 Up the coast of Carama wise Carding proceeded
 Myng's fortress, Epoli, to reach
 And all through his journey, he tried and succeeded
 To educate, tutor, and preach
 And many he tutored remained by his side
 As he journeyed through hill and through knoll
 To function as guards for their teacher and guide
 And to help him accomplish his goal
 When the Wise One had come to the towering walls
 Of Myng's castle, its towers sharp and cruel
 Thrice a cry of defiance the Waykeeper calls
 And Myng meets him, demanding a duel
 And the Keeper agrees, and the tyrant suggests
 That of weapons, the god have the choice
 And soft-spoken Carding, the Wise One, requests

That the combat be fought with their voice
 The tyrant, bemused, grants the Keeper's appeal
 And attacks with a terrible yell
 And the great beds of bedrock beneath them all reel
 As if Bladhm is raging in Hell
 But Carding stands tranquil, unmoved by the din
 Stands tranquil, and waits 'til his foe
 Goes hoarse with his screaming- he finally gives in
 Then the Keeper, in voice soft and low:
 'To war with the voice is the strongest of wars
 Although tyrants do not understand
 I was sent down from Tirbal to show you this course
 And bring justice and peace to your land
 So let me now fight with my weapons divine
 With Reason, Persuasion, and Speech
 See then whose arms are greater- the tyrant's or mine!'

And then Carding proceeded to teach
 He taught them of Empire, of what might yet be
 If they cast off oppression and fear
 He taught of consensus, the way of the free
 And the glory so painfully near
 He taught them of Government, Justice, and Law
 He taught them to stand, and be brave
 He taught them to hold gods and Tirbal in awe
 And to heed the commandments they gave
 He taught all the arts to make Empire rise
 And when he was finished at last
 'I teach you the way of Audentior!' he cries
 'Which will never in fame be surpassed!
 I give you the seed that will sprout to a jewel
 The Sun, to turn night into day!
 In glory to conquer, in justice to rule
 And in wisdom to follow my Way.'

And his words touched the hearts of the listening crowd
 And like wildfire spread through each mind
 And without a command being spoken aloud
 In a terrible mob they combined
 All their arms became one, and united, they pried
 Stone from stone, and forced open each cell
 And a well-fired shaft struck at Myng, who then died
 And followed his masters to Hell
 Then the crown of the Firelord burned azure and blue
 And the Keeper of Lore raised it high

And he placed it upon a white banner that flew
 From a turret, commanding the sky
 Then ascends back to Tirbal, while those still below
 The Audentes, are drafting their laws
 And upon every law shines that bright azure glow
 Which purifies faults, and melts flaws
 And the people at last have their laws set and passed
 And their leaders and chieftains in place
 And the die now are cast for an empire vast
 And a happy and prosperous race
 The glory! The brilliance! The radiance! The light!
 The wonder! The splendor! The scope!
 The vigor! The valor! The power! The might!
 The music! The magic! The HOPE!!!
 For such was Audentior- the Mother of Nations
 The Star to enkindle the flame
 The bright guiding lantern for all generations
 A hope beyond knowledge or name
 With a million children, all beauteous and strong
 Who should light up the world's future ages
 And together combine in symphonious song
 To illuminate all the Book's pages
 But not all sang in joy at the new era's dawn
 Nor rejoiced in Audentior's rise
 Nor was Sun, Lord of Demons, defeated and gone
 And he watched still with unclosing eyes.
 As he gazed on Audentior, a cloud filled his mind
 Of envy, and loathing, and fear
 That savagery might be removed from mankind
 And evil and wrong disappear
 So he called all the fiends who still heeded his call
 And demanded they give him a plan
 To repeat the descent that we fell in the Fall
 And once more, to corrupt helpless Man
 But Audentior stood like a bright gleaming shield
 And none of the demons could say
 How to open the scar that the Lorekeeper healed
 Or to darken the Sunlord's new day
 Then Sun grew enraged, saying 'Have you no sense?
 Do none have a scheme, or a spell?
 Then hear this! To punish her dreadful offense
 Dread Ilass lies burning in hell.
 If you cannot think perhaps yet you can dig!

For Ilass will know what to do
 So make me a pit, one so deep and so big
 That Yetal and I can go through'
 Then the armies of demons began excavation
 They started in that very spot
 A plain beside Brzgrad, in Istvan's old nation
 (Thought Istvan had long been forgot)
 For twelve days and twelve nights they removed dirt and stone
 But when the thirteenth sun arose
 Then Sun, Lord of Demons, with Yetal alone
 Down the pit, dim and fathomless, goes
 There they came unto Ifreann, its dark fires burning
 And the slopes of Dagora they crossed
 Through the sulfurous vapors and brimstone discerning
 The souls of the damned and the lost
 But at last they arrived at the terrible cave
 Where the Witch was consigned to her fate
 With Lest, the Dark Child, shut up in this grave
 Lest Elwynn and he join and mate
 But a great burning fire ringed the cave round and round
 Nor could Witch, Child, or Demon pass by
 So rather Sun spoke, for he knew that the sound
 Would go through, and the Witch could reply
 So Sun told the author of that dire Betrayal
 His conundrum, and asked for her aid
 Through the joined sheets of fire that made up her jail
 Awful Ilass replied, and she said:
 'Take the eye of a Drake, and then grind it to sand
 And a Rainbow, by Folcador flown
 These things mix together, and plant in the land
 Which is as Automatica known
 In the dark of the moon, it will grow to a man
 Who, though seemingly stupid and weak
 Will contain the dark power to further my plan
 And this is the weapon you seek.'
 But as Sun turned to go, awful Yetal cried back
 'What of you, ringed in fire etern?
 What of Lest, the Dark Child? Do Sun and I lack
 Any hope to expect your return?'
 But smiling Ilass said 'I have beheld
 Inscrutable time to its end
 And these terrible fires will one day be quelled
 And I unto Gnaud then ascend

But to Lest, the Black Orchid, are different dooms given
 And nor must my brother wait long
 'Til a great king in Tirlar, the chosen of Heaven
 Will unwittingly cause a great wrong
 He shall come down, as you did, and battle with Lest
 Yea, shall think the Black Orchid is slain
 But at last the affair will turn out for the best
 And my brother see daylight again
 This too shall be caused by the spell you now bear
 For long have I plotted and schemed
 Depart, and return to the bright upper air
 Of which I so often have dreamed
 I have planned a great evil- 'tis now in your hands
 Soon another shall leave, with a greater
 Return unto Tirlar, its Races and Lands -
 Climb back through your pit to its crater'
 And thus Sun and Yetal returned to the air
 And concocted in silence the potion
 When at last it was done, the two fiends made repair
 To the shores of the Gaeosian Ocean
 In the land which was as Automatica known
 Near where Antya flowed into the bay
 There they set it to seethe 'til the dark of the moon
 For a day and a night, thus it lay
 Then it grew to a man- into Sager, who led
 The revolt of the lands of the west
 When it ended, uncountable thousands were dead
 With the land that the gods once had blessed
 And the broken Audentes burned Carding's old laws
 And they set up a despot instead
 The Emperor Christoph, whose myriad flaws
 Took the nation from ailing to dead
 Alas for the men who once saw Carding's light
 And who built from the light a great nation
 They are now doomed forever to squabble and to fight
 Nevermore will they lay the foundation
 For something eternal and glorious and famed
 For their hands now sculpt only in air
 And can any among their sad number be blamed
 If they fall into gloom and despair?
 But Dliithail, the Guardian, says 'Never a door
 May close, but another opens wide'
 And the lands of the North, overshadowed before

Are renewed, both in power and pride
 Those fleeing Audentior find refuge and home
 With the Northmen, both lively and bold
 And the tribes of the north, and the migrants become
 The mightiest of kingdoms of old
 Carradun! Called by some Land of Fire and Stone
 For the souls and the hearts of its men
 As great as Audentior, in ways of its own
 And its like shall be seen not again
 As 'Blackrock' Audentes and foreigners knew it
 For the mountains of coal and of shale
 Which winding like sinuous serpents on through it
 Kept it safe from the storm and the gale
 Now of all of its kings, one particular name
 Stands out, like the sun among stars
 Many legends preserve his great deeds and his fame
 (As indeed will this legend of ours)
 Shane Odium, who bore the Obsidian Spoon
 And who ruled when Audentior ended
 In him, the new day Tineon proclaimed reached its noon
 And to new heights of brilliance ascended
 In his thirtieth year (and the tenth of his reign)
 When his glory had waxed to its height
 He mounted his tower and surveyed the campaign
 And his rule stretched as far as his sight
 He beheld mighty fortresses, rich fields of wheat
 Grazing herds, looking peaceful and healthy
 His powerful host and invincible fleet
 And villages teeming and wealthy
 And he thought to himself, on the top of his tower
 'Yea, though now all of Tirlar be mine
 I cannot escape Death, and despite all my power
 My kingdom- and self- must decline
 But to live on in legend, when bones turn to dust
 That one comfort to mortals is given
 I shall do some great exploit of note 'ere I must
 Be summoned to Ifreann or Heaven'
 So he called all his councilors, wise men, and sages
 And asked them what deeds needed doing
 What curses or evils or riddles of ages
 Needed solving, or needed subduing
 And at last one remembered a tale he'd heard spoken
 An ancient (but accurate) story

Of a terrible evil that had to be broken
 And a quest that was sure to bring glory
 In the very beginning of time (so he said)
 A great battle filled Heaven with blood
 And the day (though alas, not 'til Utas lay dead)
 Was a win for the forces of good
 And the Darkness was cast to the Darkness of Hell
 There it lay, and there still did it lie
 Planning what horrid evils no mortal could tell
 Underneath the dark sulfurous sky
 But if ever a hero would journey below
 With his heart and his sword tempered strong
 And in battle should conquer the terrible Foe
 Earth no longer should groan under Wrong
 But be free and exalted, like Tirbal above
 And its men would be happy and free
 And oppression would cease, superseded by love
 And all evils would scatter and flee
 And scarce had the councilor ceased from his speaking
 When the king, with his hand on his sword
 Said 'This purpose is perfect: just such was I seeking
 This evil cannot be ignored!
 To this end I devote all my focus and might
 I shall seek without respite or rest
 Prepare me a ship- for I journey tonight
 I am burning for want of a quest!'

And the people of Carradun readied a ship
 Called the Sea Lion, so fleet and fast
 It could outstrip the fire of Folcador's whip
 Or make progress against Lochrinn's blast
 No soldiers accompanied Odlum on board
 Only twelve sturdy men as a crew
 And the best of his treasures: his ruby-set sword
 Thus equipped, from the harbor they flew
 Now this sword that he bore was no human-forged blade
 But was tempered by Salio's hands
 The Sword of the Red Moon of August- once made
 For defense of the Races and Lands
 How Shane gained its possession I will not relate
 (though through fiend-haunted Shleg went its course)
 But I say the result was not untouched by Fate
 Which indeed, is of all things the source
 Now Shane's destination lay deep in the ice

That covers and hides northern seas
 For he sought from a god supernatural advice
 And one dwelt in the cold glacial freeze
 'Twas Elwynn the Orchid who there made her dwelling
 In the heart of a fiery mount
 Why this happened is part of the tale I am telling
 And its history now I recount:
 In the days when Audentior still reigned ascendant
 O'er the people and cities and land
 A few saw the cracks in the glory resplendent
 And worried, and hoarded, and planned
 They escaped just before it began crashing down
 And in two ships of birch journeyed forth
 And at last they met landfall, and founded a town
 In the ultimate climes of the north
 Yea, a town 'midst the glaciers- they called its name Thule
 And they set out to build a new life
 To always act calmly, and always speak truly
 Be pious, and shun war and strife
 This touched the White Orchid, who boldly declared
 She would live in this land as their god
 But the others had visions of Sun, and were scared
 Of her having an earthly abode
 For if ever the Dark One in Ifreann should find her
 The Destroyer at last would awake
 And Utas' death was a constant reminder
 Of what form such disaster would take
 So then let the Pure One in Heaven remain
 And thus let her remain in their trust
 And in Ennabruk linger, lest Ennabruk's Bane
 Should turn all their Creations to dust
 But Elwynn declared 'Powers far above I
 Have determined an Ending must come
 Whether sooner or later, we all have to die
 We can greedily hoard every crumb
 Of life still allotted, 'til death comes at last
 For despite all your hoarding, it must
 Or can squeeze every drop out of life 'til it's past
 And be ashes, instead of plain dust
 Then she fell down from Heaven, and took her abode
 In Mount Yaanek, amidst Thule's ice
 And upon those who came to her cave she bestowed
 As an oracle, prudent advice

Thus 'twas here that our hero, in sailing the seas
 Sought to journey, and here that he came
 And when he arrived, he fell down on his knees
 And, invoking the goddess' name:
 'O Elwynn, who came down from Tirbal above
 Deep within this volcano to dwell
 And who looking on Man, is inspired with love
 And desire to help them excel
 O lend me your wisdom, for I have a task
 Which is hopeless without aid divine
 O answer the questions I modestly ask
 And all honor and praise will be thine
 I am set on a quest to the visionless deeps
 Where evil both festers and runs
 Where, though covered in darkness, the soul never sleeps
 And the heat is of hundreds of suns
 This I do uncoerced, not by fear nor by wrath
 I am led by the courage inside me
 I have come for advice: you alone know the path
 And can give me directions to guide me'
 When Odlum had spoken, a silence profound
 Over all of the oracle fell
 Then a voice, deep and timeless, arose from the ground
 'It is easy to go down to Hell
 But to retrace one's steps to the bright upper air
 And to reach once again starry skies
 With your soul and your body intact- it is there
 That the dangers and perils arise
 And the dangers, the perils, are not what they seem
 Not to thee and thy people alone
 But to more of the world than you ever could dream
 Will the damage and sorrow be done
 Desist from this quest- were you destined to fail
 Then such failure is yours for the choosing
 But alas- you'll succeed, and success will entail
 All the Planes and the Universe losing'
 But hard-hearted Odlum remained resolute
 And his mind remained fixed on his plan
 'Then if you will not help me, be kind, and impute
 Some knowledge of someone who can'
 Thus the goddess of Yaanek suggested he go
 (Not unmindful of what had been fated)
 To the perilous lair of the world's foremost foe

Damned Yetal, reviled and hated
 Thus Odlum departed the fierce, icy shore
 Looking back as he floated away
 And resolved, perils past, to return here once more
 But he never would witness that day!
 And the oracle sorrowed to see him depart
 And she mourned him with tears and with sighs
 And out of the depths of the world's molten heart
 A blue smoke-plume trails into the skies
 But Shane set a course for Cimmerian lands
 Far to westward, through ice floes and mists
 Where high on a mountain of granite there stands
 Awful Sun, cursing all that exists
 And lurking nearby, loathed, reviled, and accursed
 And still smarting from ancient defeat
 There was Yetal- who Odlum, expecting the worst
 With his hand on his sword, went to meet
 The demon was sitting high up on an oak
 In a branch all misshaped and deformed
 From his eyes, as from Yaanek, rose pillars of smoke
 As he cursed and he raged and he stormed
 Odlum heard him yell 'Refin!', his tone full of spite
 And in fury he struck at the bough
 And the blood that it drew was as black as the night
 And like ravens his screeches of woe
 'Son of sorrow!' the king to the devil cried out
 'I would not interrupt your lament
 If it gives you your pleasure to fume and to pout
 Go ahead, till your fury is spent
 But through myriad kingdoms and seas I have come
 For a boon you alone can provide me
 I shall leave you to tantrums and journey back home
 If you but give directions to guide me
 I am set on a quest to the visionless deep
 Where-' and here the foul demon cut in
 'I behold that dread landscape each night in my sleep!
 My spirit pulled downward by sin!
 Describe it not further! I wish not to hear!
 Even now it is firmly imprinted
 In my dark, freezing soul, and it fills me with fear
 Of dangers to men only hinted!
 Go! I wish not to know of your purpose or name!
 I wish not to know of your goal!

Whether money or power or virtue or fame
 It sends chills to the base of my soul!
 Speak no more of Ifreann! My heart cannot bear
 To be of its future reminded
 Make your way to the kingdom of Istvan, and there
 In a terrible Pit you shall find it'
 Then the black creature howled, and it made a great leap
 From its tree to a peak far away
 To the dread Lord of Daemons, whose eyes never sleep
 And who loathes Tineon's gift of bright day
 There he gibbers insanely, and tries to forget
 All the things that so lately were said
 By the man (not unlike to the gods) he just met
 All the visions that trouble his head
 Now the Pit that he named was the tunnel created
 Long ago in Audentior's day
 Of its birth and use I've already related
 And have nothing further to say
 Thus to Istvan's old kingdom the Blackrocker ship
 Made its last foamy course o'er the seas
 But its passenger barely had started his trip
 With such pitiful journeys as these
 For a night he lay camped by the pit's dreadful maw
 A night filled with dreams boding ill
 The doom of all Tirlar and Tirbal he saw!
 All the cities of men dead and still!
 His kingdom, proud Blackrock, laid low by his death!
 And by Blackrock's death Tirlar laid low!
 All the doomed souls of Shleg, Khas, and Ahans, and Reath
 As a single voice crying 'Don't go!'
 Shane awoke with a start, as that terrible cry
 Echoed loud in his terror-filled mind
 But he saw Leiagh's diamonds still studded the sky
 Nor had midnight been left far behind
 So he lay, staring up at the moon in the night
 Breathing deeply, to quiet his fear
 'Til, glancing nearby, his jumped up with afright
 For he saw a grey figure appear
 Moving quietly, firmly, as if upon air
 It advanced, toward the paralyzed king
 He tried to cry out to his men to beware
 But he found he could not say a thing
 Far taller than those of the lineage of man

Was that ashen and terrible shade
 And Odlum, without conscious bidding or plan
 Found his hand lying firm on his blade
 But when it came near, and was clearly discerned
 All its aspect of fear fell away
 And the specter, the giant, the demon, was turned
 To an small, ancient man, bent and grey
 'O king!' said the being, but Shane, in a rage
 At his cowardly seizure by dread
 Took the Red Sword of August, and struck at the sage
 And he cut off his ashen-haired head
 But strange to relate, the old man waved his hand
 And was whole, as he had been before
 And, with wrath, proclaimed 'Fool! You do not understand!
 I am Carding, the Keeper of Lore!
 I have come to redeem you! And thus you repay
 Your last puny hope of salvation?
 Be still, and take heed of the words that I say
 For the sake of your soul and your nation!
 The Lady of Yaanek has already tried
 To persuade your intractable mind
 Yet, in willful transgression, her words you defied
 Nor can I make you linger behind
 So I offer command, not request: When you go
 Take nothing upon your return
 Things of Ifreann in Ifreann must stay, down below
 Or your spirit in Ifreann will burn!
 What madness! Presumption! To strike a god dead!
 Nor shall you unpunished remain!
 Let my sigil forever remain on your head
 To remind you to not fail again!
 Let it burn its geometry on to your skin
 As a mark of a might past your own
 As a warning to shun a more terrible sin
 And to keep to the path I have shown'
 Then the god waved his staff, and indeed it was so
 And upon the poor king's open head
 The sigil of Carding, with brilliant blue glow
 Appeared, 'til it faded dull red
 Then the god waved his staff, and departed from sight
 Back to Tirbal, the land of the blessed
 And again, round the king closed the silence of night
 'Til at last he retired to rest

But when Tineon peeled away Ulcharam's veil
 'Ere Diadon the Morn-Star went dim
 Shane gathered his courage and gear for the trail
 To the crater's black mountainous rim
 There he gave his good-byes to his friends and his men
 The next step he would take on his own
 And he doubted he ever might see them again
 As he entered the crater alone
 O hand! Shudder not as you finish this tale!
 O pen! Run not dry out of fright!
 O Dobharcufile! My mind is too frail
 To guide Shane through the Halls of the Night!
 O lend me your strength! And your courage, as well!
 So that I may describe what was fated
 For although it is easy to go down to Hell
 It is hellishly hard to relate it.
 Like a birth canal backward, a tunnel extended
 For fathomless leagues there below
 The king gazed far away, but saw not where it ended
 Nor where, at its end, it might go
 But he gathered his courage, and took a first stride
 And then foot followed foot through the gloom
 Until leagues had gone by, and the darkness inside
 Was the darkness that charges a tomb
 Thus he lit an oak torch- and beheld, standing near
 A tall man, red eyes fixed in a stare
 All at once, his blood froze, and his heart filled with fear
 And he muttered, to Carding, a prayer
 'Art thou demon or man? For your form seems like mine
 Yet more focused, more terribly bleak
 Come you here out of Tirbal's, or Ifreann's design'
 Then the figure proceeded to speak:
 'I am Ryan Caruso, the ruler of Hell
 At least thus I like to be styled
 Though the demons down under may otherwise tell'
 Here he laughed, and disarmingly smiled
 'But we, the Infernals, have rules of our own
 And we've warned them against interfering
 But come, and these themes will be presently shown
 By which you'll learn more than by hearing'
 So the king and the madman walked down through the shaft
 As Caruso described Hell's societies
 And he often gave pause, and maniacally laughed

At tortures of many varieties
 With his eyes on his guide, and his hand on his blade
 Shane of Blackrock continued on down
 'Til they passed through a doorway, of skeletons made
 To a cavern, containing a town
 Its walls were of lava, all jagged and steep
 Their color carnelian-red
 Their angles would make a geometer weep
 Or an architect strike himself dead
 The streets were so narrow they hardly existed
 And covered with layers of grime
 Their mazes like webs drunken spiders at twisted
 In bedrock as ancient as time
 In the center, carved out of a mountain of shale
 A massive cathedral loomed grey
 There were things on the wall, in exquisite detail
 But things no decent poet can say
 And into this temple of madness and vice
 Poor Odlum was led by his guide
 And when Ryan incanted a hex three times thrice
 The door opened, to let them inside
 And inside was a Congress, a gathering of souls
 But such souls! They were damned, every one!
 You could see but their eyes, which stuck out, like hot coals
 From the darkness, as hot as the sun
 And Ryan said 'Comrades! From realms high above
 The long-promised one has arisen
 The one who the prophets have prophesied of
 Who shall set us all free from this prison!
 Yea! Set us all free! And set free all the Planes!
 From their prison of pitiful skin!
 Set all of us free! Until nothing remains!
 Of this vortex of suffering and sin!
 Set all of us free! Free! To beautiful Void!
 To the unfeeling Dark that we crave!
 He comes that the world may be thoroughly destroyed!
 To set us all free! And to save!
 But Odlum, who stared at those terrible shades
 As they filled with their unholy glee
 Said 'You have it all wrong! I come not down to Hades
 To destroy, or to set you all free.
 I come but to see sorrow, loss, and decay
 From Tirlar extinguished forever

I am not a destroyer! And not who you say!
 And to free you is not my endeavour!'

The shades then grew wroth, and the air seemed to stir
 By Ryan, still jovial, said
 'So you think, but no mortal knows what will occur
 From the paths that we heedlessly tread
 You know little of Fate, and I know little more
 I leave Heaven to fret o'er the rest
 But I have intuition, and have ancient lore
 And declare you shall stay as our guest
 Now demons! Now damned ones! Get food, and get wines!
 The King must be hungry and tired
 And while he gets rest, and gets happy, and dines
 We shall tell him of what has transpired
 The History of Ifreann, our glorious State
 The occurrences of its formation
 And how, in despite of divine law and fate
 We have carved ourselves out a great nation!'

The demons and damned ones brought dinner- for one
 As a ghost, Ryan needed no food
 When the dinner was over, at last, he begun
 Keeping still in his jocular mood
 'This city, Dagora, is part of a whole
 Whose tale I am longing to tell
 The pride of each demon, and every damned soul
 The People's Republic of Hell!
 When Mordicc arrives with his merciful blade
 The soul and the body to sever
 In Mandorel's presence the judgment is made
 To determine its dwelling forever
 Upon most, the god smiles, and Jestun conveys
 Them to Tirbal, or Calaspier's walls
 There to sing and rejoice till the closing of days
 When ANDAN's apocalypse falls
 Thus the fate that awaits, if your soul can be seen
 As righteous, by any long stretching
 But ofttimes a soul is so nasty and mean
 As to set the great Champion retching
 Then he strikes it with Trizecc, his three-bladed axe
 For more brutal than Mordicc's kind scythe
 And it plummets to Earth, and it falls through the cracks
 Into Ifreann to burn and to writhe
 Now Ifreann as Ifreann is quite bad enough

As I think you yourself can attest
 It is fiery and dark, and lacks all that great stuff
 With which Tirlar above has been blessed
 But the demons! The demons who justly were thrown
 From the skies when they fell in the Fall
 And who torture damned souls, lacking souls of their own
 Their tortures are worst of it all!
 In what gruesome crimes do they not take delight?
 What interest we sinners must pay!
 All the nightmares I dreamt in the blankets of night
 They give substance, and take into day!
 All the ills that befall those in Tirlar still dwelling
 They perfect, and invent new beside
 Yea, ones without name, that I shrink back from telling
 Yet to which I will now give a guide
 Then Ryan said 'Antya!' and picked up a wand
 And exerted an effort of will
 With a sparkle of light and a wave and the hand
 The two stood on a very high hill
 From which could be seen each demonic domain
 Every oven, abyss, every rack
 And the demons, whose terrible laughs add what pain
 Their inventions and fiendishness lack
 'See there statues of stone, with their grim, twisted faces?
 At their nearest, a mile apart?
 Those are men who were hardened to lovers' embraces
 And thus broke an innocent heart!
 So they long for a kiss or a brotherly word
 But no one! For miles around!
 What on Earth they would laugh at whenever they heard
 Is in Ifreann nowhere to be found
 See those unlucky men being severed in twain
 By the demons in puddles of gore?
 They are men who broke oaths for their personal gain
 And who failed to uphold what they swore
 And for breaking their word, they themselves must be broken
 For such does is the Word of the Law
 Which shall ne'er be reneged, and has never been spoken
 And which lacks any loophole or flaw
 And those, who a fiend with a terrible bow
 Filled with arrows of fire is haunting
 Their sin up above, punished thus here below
 Was their habit of taunting and teasing

They shot vitriol to puncture their poor victims souls
 And with vitriol their souls now are shot
 And their bodies are covered with cauterized holes
 Stuck with oil, eternally hot
 See there! Demons tie people's necks with strong ropes
 Placing food just an inch out of range
 These are fools who stopped others from realizing hopes
 When their minds were too narrow to change
 Now their atrophied feet barely keep them erect
 As they wish for a change in their state
 Which from Unchanging Law, they can hardly expect
 To stay just as they are is their fate
 I feel sorry for these- but for those, over there
 I have no trace of mercy at all
 See them: climbing to Tirlar upon a high stair
 On the top, pushed by demons to fall
 Back to Ifreann below- these are those who took joy
 In killing what others had made
 And instead of creating, they strove to destroy
 And I laugh as I see them repaid!
 Once I was tormented; once I was a slave
 To such horrors as now your eyes see
 But I gathered my comrades, and warlike and brave
 We struck back at the damned bourgeoisie!
 At our fiendish oppressors- and drove them away
 Their whole system of tyranny fell
 We proclaimed we were now our own lords- and that day
 Rose the People's Republic of Hell
 Yea, the People's Republic of Hell! Every man
 (Or those who are now something less)
 Is free to do all that he possibly can
 Save exploit, or harass, or oppress
 But alas! While in these awful depths we yet dwell
 Revolution can not be complete
 For Hell, stripped of torments, is all the same Hell
 With its darkness, and sorrow, and heat
 But enough of such torments! Enough of such woes
 For I see that your stomach grows queasy
 You must now take the way that your destiny goes
 Though I doubt that that way will be easy
 To Illas, to Lest! In the world's deepest core
 In a fiery ring you will find them
 And will fight them, as Mandorel fought them before

And then here, deep in Ifreann, confined them
 I have taken you most of the way to your end
 See the trail, down this mount's jagged slope
 You shall reach, when its tortuous path you descend
 A fiery ring- lose not hope!
 For if you are pure in intentions and soul
 The flames will feel cool as the breeze
 And with hand on your sword-hilt and eye on your goal
 You may enter with health and in ease'
 Thus Odlum and Ryan departed, as friends
 And hand shook with skeletal hand
 And each one declared, that where'er their path ends
 And wherever their destinies land
 They should still remain brothers, for aid rendered deep
 Beneath Tirlar, in caverns of stone
 And all through their Way, their remembrance to keep
 Till in Heaven- or Hell, it was done
 Then Odlum descended the terrible trail
 Coming closer to Earth's fiery core
 And he reached the mount's base, at the fiery vale
 And he paused to look 'round, and explore
 Alas! A mistake! For not all one can see
 Is within the poor mortal eye's seeing
 And poor Odlum screamed, freezing in terror as he
 Saw a hideous, gargantuan, being
 It was covered in filth, from its head to its toes
 (which were more a tentacular mass)
 Like a great oaken tree, to the heavens it rose
 And it seemed to the mountain surpass
 It was slimy and massive, and held a great spoon
 Which it stirred in a cauldron of grime
 Like the sum of the filth that Earth's cities had strewn
 In all lands, of all sorts, for all time
 It was dread Maladaticc! The Lord of Disease!
 Sun's brother, and cohort in ill!
 And the mixture he mixed was the plague-bearing sleaze
 That would sicken and cripple and kill
 And every so often, winged bat forms swooped down
 And returned up above, with loud squawks
 In their sharp-taloned claws bearing thick lumps of brown
 To cause fever and weakness and pox
 Leave behind Maladaticc! My pen will not dwell
 On that fetid and fear-firing form

Which even for those grown accustomed to Hell
 In its horror exceeded the norm
 Let Odlum arrive at the tall wall of flame
 That encircled his last destination
 For when to the end of his journey he came
 He paused, with a great trepidation
 White hot was the fire, with tinges of blue
 It was barring the wall to a cave
 Shane gathered his courage, and took a leap through
 And fate indeed favored the brave
 For cool was his body, like touched by a breeze
 And his mind had grown peaceful and clear
 And the king was not hurt, but his mind put at ease
 And expunged of all trembling and fear
 And good thing- for there sat, in the edge of the room
 The Queen of all Hell, dressed in black
 She turned gracefully round, like the image of doom
 And moved not, nor made any attack
 But said 'Welcome, Shane. You should not have come here
 But you have, and must now face your test
 Take your blade from its sheath- I will not interfere
 As you struggle in combat with Lest'
 Then Ilass stepped back, and the king saw before her
 A flower, black-petalled and small
 Was this Lest, Bane of Tirbal, the cursed Destroyer
 The damned engineer of the Fall?
 Could he fight? Could he win? And what powers within
 That small seedling, untapped, lay in wait?
 And Shane brandished his sword at the author of sin
 And he charged toward his foe and his fate
 And the Red Sword of August struck ichor-filled shoot
 And the chamber grew strange, dark and cold
 And Shane's mind was ripped out of the world at its root
 And a new world began to unfold
 Whirling madness, strange horrors, with colors unknown
 Lawless lamps in bright dark-shining skies
 Shapes that pulsed and that throbbed to a beat of their own
 And a billion mad watching eyes
 All was lost for a second- the fight and Shane's mind
 But the latter at last drew together
 And it fought off strange starbursts of energy: blind
 Anger pulsating out of the ether
 With an effort of will that brought tears to his eyes

He wrested himself from insanity
 And returned, after many exertions and tries
 To the less crazy (?) world of humanity
 And there on the top of a now lifeless stem
 Where the Flower of Doom once had been
 A beautiful night-dark and wonderful gem
 On the top of the stalk could be seem
 For the Bane was defeated! The world was redeemed!
 And the demon was now lifeless stone!
 Or so to our hero, triumphant, it seemed
 For his battle and prize were now won
 Prize? Who mentioned a prize? Now he looked at the jewel
 He did not think the thought was his own
 But on further reflection, no man but a fool
 Would refuse such a beautiful stone
 It would serve in his scepter, and help him hold sway
 Over all of his subject and land
 He would make it his own ere he journey away
 And he reached for his it now with his hand
 But up on his forehead, a with lightnings of pain
 The sigil of Carding, dull red
 Became active, and flared bright and blue once again
 Shane recalled what the Keeper had said:
 'Now I offer command, not request: When you go
 Take nothing upon your return
 Things of Ifreann in Ifreann must stay, down below
 Or your spirit in Ifreann will burn!'

But evil had perished! No more would be burning
 In Ifreann; no more His command
 Was needed to keep people's spirits to turning
 To darkness, which now had been banned
 So with motion decisive, the gemstone he plucked
 From the stem, where it flew to his grasp
 Through the door of the cave, through the fire he ducked
 With the Bane of the World in his clasp
 I shall not bore my readers, nor cause needless fear
 With stories of Shane's journey back
 His path now was open; all dangers were clear
 And he kept to his previous track
 He ascended the crater in Istvan's domain
 To his men, who had camped there and waited
 Then to Blackrock returned, o'er the blue, placid main
 Where his subjects beheld him, elated

And he entered his palace and sat on his throne
 And he ordered his councilors gone
 And he took his old scepter, and there, all alone
 He affixed his new trophy thereon
 But scarce had he done so, when shot bolts of pain
 And fever, that spread from his head
 And the sigil grew bright blue and fiery again
 And in minutes, the hero was dead
 For Carding, the Wise One, had never stopped viewing
 The deeds of the Blackrocker prince
 And when he beheld what the hero was doing
 His features became a grim wince
 For he knew that immortals can never be slain
 And that Odlum had merely been fooled
 And been tricked into carrying sadness and pain
 Into all of the lands that he ruled
 There was Lest! The Dark Orchid! Who set off the Fall!
 There in Blackrock, now destined to die
 As had died great Audentior, and as die us all
 Underneath the great dome of the sky
 And as had died Shane, by the terrible wrath
 (mixed with sorrow, and terrible fear)
 Of Carding, the Wise One, the Guide to the Path
 The Prophet, Protector, and Seer
 Shane lingered a while, but soon there came down
 A man on an aerial boat
 When he saw the Dark Orchid, his face formed a frown
 But he otherwise took little note
 He beckoned to Shane to come into his ship
 And he paddled it up through the air
 And with swiftness like eagles proceeded the trip
 The trip- led by whom? going where?
 Led by Jestun, the heavenly Boatman of souls
 Up to Tirbal, where on their high seats
 The High Court of Ennabruk, that which controls
 A dead human's destiny, meets
 And high o'er them all is the god Mandorallen
 Whose judgment has never been false
 Who raises the good and who casts out the fallen
 From Ennabruk's cloud-girdled walls
 And in front of this body was Odlum presented
 And Carding, the guide to the Way
 Was wroth, for his anger had not yet relented

And had many an insult to say
 On how Odlum had broken his word, and had taken
 The Orchid from prison below
 And should thus by the gods and their law be forsaken
 And punished with ages of woe
 But kindly Laguna, the Mother of All
 Told Carding to keep to his Way
 And to not act in wrath, though the force of the Fall
 Had succeeded, and taken the day
 For when Shane had descended the road down to Hell
 His intentions had been for the best
 Men must do what they can; the results none can tell
 But the gods will take care of the rest
 And Mandorel, Champion, nodded assent
 And said 'Shane, you have fought very well
 You accomplished the duty on which you were bent
 Even unto the center of Hell
 You were rash- so am I! And your sentence was served
 In the death that you suffered of late
 You ruled well; further sorrow would not be deserved
 Now hear from my mouth of your fate
 You shall sit in Calaspier, with heaven-forged spear
 And shall sit by the side of my throne
 And when foes shall inspire my people with fear
 Go to Tirlar, in aspect unknown
 And lead armies to triumph, and countries to peace
 Till ANDAN, created at last
 Causes all war and struggle to suddenly cease
 With the rest of the Universe vast
 And on that very day, you shall lead all my men
 From Calaspier's age-ridden stone
 All the souls of the warriors, to battle again
 Into further and greater renown
 And the people of Tirlar will sing and rejoice
 When Shane Odlum is seen at their head
 This is then my decree, and my unerring choice
 As the Judge of the Souls of the Dead!
 And Odlum, the Warrior, the greatest of kings
 To the halls of Calaspier ascends
 A spear of the making of Runda he brings
 And he waits till the Universe ends
 When the two dreadful Orchids shall seal the world's fate
 And he once more can fight the world's foes

And swing swords once again in that dire debate
That will bring all our tales to a close

FINIS

Sun bless, Earth keep
Ard-Baron Aedh-Eoin I of the United Baronies